

Rel 310 Dietrich Bonhoeffer

Numbered Transcript

REL 310 • Eric Metaxas

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Lecture 1: The Formative Years

At a glance — Metaxas on Bonhoeffer's formative years.

- 1.1 Hello there. Welcome to lecture one. In German, it would be Eins of the Dietrich Bonhoeffer course. This is a course on an extraordinary figure, impossible to sum up. In the eight lectures, we will do our best. But his name is Dietrich Bonhoeffer. That's how we say it in America. In Germany, it would be Dietrich Bonhoeffer, but we're in America, so I'm going to go with Bonhoeffer. It is, as I say, virtually impossible to sum up Bonhoeffer. It is what makes him fascinating. He is undeniably one of the most fascinating, extraordinary figures I have ever encountered. I would suggest that anyone could ever encounter.
- 1.2 He's so fascinating—there's so much I want to say in the beginning. Let me start here. My book on Dietrich Bonhoeffer is titled Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy. That will help us frame him who he was. He was a pastor. He was a martyr. He was a prophet. He was a spy. I want to talk about that. I didn't just title the book Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy because I wanted it to echo Tinker Tailor Soldier Spy by John le Carre. It's actually important that we think of him as this complex figure who was all those things. He was genuinely a pastor. He was genuinely a martyr. He was genuinely a prophet. We'll talk about what that means. And he was a spy. And what do we mean by that? He was not an assassin, by the way, but he was a spy. He was involved in the plot to kill Hitler.
- 1.3 So I want to talk about who he was, and I will be following his life chronologically, obviously, as my book does, not thematically. Because the themes on Bonhoeffer, the themes of his life, they're woven all throughout his life. That's what makes him, to my mind, so fascinating, is that the themes that you see at the beginning of his life follow all the way through to the end of his life. That alone is fascinating. He doesn't lurch from thing to thing. He's consistent, but the themes evolve as his thinking evolves. It doesn't evolve dramatically. It evolves slowly, carefully, logically, which is the person that he was.
- 1.4 Before we get into Bonhoeffer's life and his chronology, his birth, his background, which I want to talk about in this first lecture, I want to talk about how I came to write a big book, a 600-page book—in German, it's 700 pages, but that's German—about Dietrich Bonhoeffer. It started in my mother's womb, but I was very young. I don't remember any of that. Although it did. But it really starts in 1988. I was really struggling with Christian faith. I wasn't really any particular kind of Christian. I met someone who starts talking to me about God and the Bible, whatever. He hands me a book by Dietrich Bonhoeffer. It's Bonhoeffer's famous book, The Cost of Discipleship. In German, it's just called Nachfolge, which means discipleship. The English translation is The Cost of Discipleship.

- 1.5 And he says, "Have you ever heard of Dietrich Bonhoeffer?" I thought, "No, I've never heard of Dietrich Bonhoeffer." But because this guy knew my mom grew up in Nazi Germany, he thought I'd be interested in it. And I was, totally. I thought, "What? Who's this? What's this?" He explains to me, the nutshell version, who is Bonhoeffer? Oh, he was a German pastor who, because of his Christian faith, spoke up for the Jews in Nazi Germany. He was a German pastor who, because of his faith, spoke up against Hitler in Nazi Germany. Now, he got my attention. I thought, You've got to be kidding me. What? It's not something people did in Nazi Germany, speak up against Hitler, speak up for the Jews, particularly a Christian, Christian pastor. I thought, this Christian I could at least get interested in. This is very interesting to me.
- 1.6 It's fascinating to me because my mother grew up in Nazi Germany. She was born in 1934. Hitler took power in '33. She grew up during this period. My whole family was in Germany during this period. My grandfather, to whom I dedicate my book, Erich, after whom I'm named Eric, he was an adult during this period. He, as my mother and grandmother have explained to me over the decades, my grandfather did not like Hitler. You don't hear a lot about all the Germans that did not like Hitler. He didn't want to go to war, but he was drafted. He was sent to the Eastern Front in 1943. He was killed April 4th, 1944. My whole life, I have grown up in the shadow of that, that my grandfather was killed at age 32, 31. My mother was 10 years old. So this has always haunted me that my family were there when this happened. They were there after it happened. Postwar Germany, post World War II Germany was a nightmare. There was no food.
- 1.7 So I grew up always hearing these stories and always wondering as a German—now my father is Greek from Greece, but my mother, as I just said, is German from Germany—always wondering what were my people doing and thinking then? My family, many of whom still live there. What was going on? I know that my grandfather didn't like the Nazis. In fact, my mother would tell me, my grandmother would tell me, that my grandfather would listen to the BBC with his ear literally pressed against the radio speaker for fear of being discovered by the Nazis that he was listening to the BBC to find out what's really going on.
- 1.8 There were tons tons and tons of Germans just like that, you don't hear about them. When I heard about Bonhoeffer, I thought, "Aha! Here is someone like my grandfather. He was not on board with what the Nazis were doing." This guy, Bonhoeffer, who comes from this amazing family, I'll tell you about it in a second, he was vocal about his disagreement with the Nazis. He was fearless about his opposition to the Nazis. Where did that come from? Where does that courage come from? What is that?
- 1.9 So, the story always haunted me of what happened in Germany. When I heard about Bonhoeffer from my friend, Ed Tuttle, I thought, "This is fascinating." I was attracted immediately to the idea of Bonhoeffer. That's 1988. I was simultaneously frightened somewhat because I thought to myself, as my friend Ed told me— yeah, and

Bonhoeffer was killed by the Nazis in 1945 in Flossenburg concentration camp. It's a chilling thing that he spoke up for the Nazis, but he was killed.

- 1.10** I also heard, and we'll get into this in-depth in these lectures, that he escaped in 1939 to America, but then makes this extraordinary decision to return to Nazi Germany. Unbelievable that he would do that. He didn't have to do that. Why would he do that? He goes back and his resistance is even stronger, and then he's killed by the Nazis, whatever.
- 1.11** I was not a young man of faith when I first heard these things, I thought, "How scary. Why did he do that? Strange." Then when I was, I mentioned, given the book that Bonhoeffer wrote, *The Cost of Discipleship* (Nachfolge), right in the beginning of it, there's a Bonhoeffer quote, a really important quote. It kind of sums him up. In the course of these eight lectures, I will be teasing this out, this theme. But he sums it up, and Bonhoeffer sums things always kind of brilliantly. It's like a lapidary quote. The quote is, "When Christ calls a man, he bids him come and die." That's not the chipper encouragement to faith I was looking for in 1988. I was like, "I don't know about this. It's a little dramatic, a little harsh."
- 1.12** But of course, one of the things we're going to be talking about over the course of these lectures is, what does it mean when Bonhoeffer says, "When Christ calls a man, he bids him come and die?" What does that mean? It doesn't mean what we automatically think. And especially when we think of Bonhoeffer in 1948, going to the gallows and literally giving his life as a martyr, we think it means that. If Christ calls a man, he bids him come and become a martyr and be beheaded or hanged or whatever. So initially, it's chilling and off-putting. That's not what Bonhoeffer meant. Bonhoeffer, one of the reasons he's so fascinating, he has the ability to clarify what Christian faith is on such a level that you see death dramatically differently than you normally would. I'll talk about that in the course of these lectures because that sums up who he was.
- 1.13** He was someone who was so rigorous in his thinking and so faithful as a Christian that he absolutely focuses us on the core of what it means to die to self and how anyone who doesn't do that ultimately is missing the greatest opportunity in human life. It is the greatest invitation when Christ calls a man he bids him come and die. What does it mean? To die to self and to get real life because your life is fake life. Your life is you're going to die and it's over. Bonhoeffer, his whole life, he's unpacking this idea, and we'll do it in the course of these lectures.
- 1.14** He really challenges us, and he challenged me when I first encountered him in 1988, to think about what does everything mean? What is life? What's the meaning of life? I do a thing called *Socrates in the City*, and we're always asking the big questions. Bonhoeffer was asking the big questions. What does it mean when we talk about life? What is life? What's the meaning of life? What do we mean when we say we talk about death? These are the ultimate questions. He, extraordinarily, through the course of his life, as we'll see, frames these things in different ways.

- 1.15 One of his big themes, which we'll be talking about, is faith in action. In other words, to have faith isn't just an intellectual ascent to some ideas, but to live it out. He is the classic example of that. He lives it out all the way to the end and in the most dramatic, literal fashion, gives his life for his ideas. So that's beautiful. It haunted me, this connection, because of my German background. I thought about this.
- 1.16 In 1988, I never dreamt ever that I would write a book about Dietrich Bonhoeffer. I never thought I'd write any biographies. I always knew when I was at Yale in the '80s—I was an English major—I always wanted to be a writer. Never dreamt that I would write biographies, ever. I've written three big biographies now. This one, obviously, on Dietrich Bonhoeffer. Then, of course, William Wilberforce and Soupy Sales, the comedian—I did not write a biography about Soupy Sales—I'm just checking, j ust checking. Look it up. I didn't. No, Martin Luther, who's a towering figure in Bonhoeffer's life because Bonhoeffer was a Lutheran pastor, so we'll get to that as well and touch on Luther's anti-Semitism and all that.
- 1.17 Also Luther's idea, which underscores everything, undergirds the whole eight lectures we're going to talk about because it undergirds Bonhoeffer's life, is this idea of we are saved by faith alone. What does that mean? What does it mean? Bonhoeffer tells us that if you take that idea too far, you miss it, and Germany missed it, and that leads to the rise of Adolf Hitler. It's amazing that bad theology can lead to the Holocaust—very, very important stuff.
- 1.18 I never thought I'd write a biography of Bonhoeffer, but obviously I did. One of the things that we'll be talking about is there are a lot of misconceptions about Bonhoeffer. I don't want to get into it now, but initially, I was a little confused about him because you hear different things. People have, over the years, really hit this idea that, "Oh, he was a pacifist. He was a pacifist. He was a pacifist." That's essentially not true because our definition of pacifism is very different than it was following World War I. We'll get into that, too. Also, if he was such a big pacifist, how does he get involved in a plot to kill Adolf Hitler? Kind of confusing, right?
- 1.19 There are a lot of misconceptions about Bonhoeffer. Again, he's such a brilliant figure that it's easy to be confused. So in the course of writing my book, I just thought, "Listen, I don't have a dog in the fight. I just want to tell the story of this heroic figure and find out who he really was." It was far more fascinating writing the book than I ever dreamt because he is dramatically consistent. I was expecting that he's going to lurch around and change his ideas. He's a pacifist. He's not a pacifist. Not true. That, again, is a testament to the genius of Dietrich Bonhoeffer—is that very early on, he knows what he believes, and his life is really just a process of unpacking those beliefs, deepening those beliefs.
- 1.20 In the course of writing the book, I was more and more fascinated to find out who he actually was. It's dramatic. I don't want to get too much ahead of myself. There's a reason the book is 600 pages. There's a lot to his story. It's so fascinating. It has so

many pieces and so many figures and stuff. If you've seen the movie, by the way, I'm assuming you've seen the movie. If you haven't seen it, it is spectacular. Do not miss it. Run. But a two-hour movie can't begin to do justice to the complexity of Dietrich Bonhoeffer.

- 1.21 The biggest ellipsis in the movie is it doesn't even touch on his love affair, his engagement to Maria von Wedemeyer. That's one of the most moving things. I was forced to reread my book recently in preparation for this course, and I was moved literally to tears reading about this love affair, this engagement with this amazing young woman. It's so beautiful and underscores the tragedy of his death—that he was in love, looking forward to marriage.
- 1.22 The movie doesn't even touch on that because, again, if you're making a two-hour film, you can only tell—you have to pick a slice and go with it. And so the film does a truly spectacular job, but it doesn't even touch on this moving love affair. There are a number of other things that it can't go into. We're going to put all that stuff in the 10-part TV series. If you want to fund that see me after this lecture.
- 1.23 Okay, so let's just leap into Bonhoeffer's life. His family—I say this, I've lectured on Bonhoeffer hundreds of times, and I always start with the fact that in 1906, he was born into what can only be described as an absolutely extraordinary family. When you read about his family in my book or anywhere, you cannot help but be fascinated and a little bit jealous. It is such an amazing family. You almost feel like "you're making this up."
- 1.24 Bonhoeffer, later in life, and we'll touch on this a lot, he became best friends with Eberhard Bethge. I had the privilege in 2008—my wife and I visited Germany—and we spent time with Eberhard Bethge's widow. She was the niece of Dietrich Bonhoeffer. She figures in this story. We spent an afternoon with her. Her husband, Eberhard Bethge, he wrote the 1,100-page reference work on Dietrich Bonhoeffer. A lot of the stuff that I say, ultimately, came from him, but he wrote something, I'll put it up.
- 1.25 He writes, "The rich world of Bonhoeffer's ancestors set the standards for Dietrich Bonhoeffer's own life. It gave him a certainty of judgment and manner that cannot be acquired in a single generation. He grew up in a family that believed the essence of learning lay not in a formal education, but in the deeply rooted obligation to be guardians of a great historical heritage and intellectual tradition."
- 1.26 So just to sum up who the family was, and again, there's a lot here. It's almost unbelievable who this family is. It's like talking about the Kennedys or something—they don't even come up to the level of the Bonhoeffer family, to be honest. His father was the most famous doctor in Germany for 50 years. He was easily one of the most famous scientists in Europe for decades. That's the father of Dietrich Bonhoeffer. Bonhoeffer grows up in a family that is profoundly intellectual, that is respected culturally, respected in the community.

- 1.27 His father is a huge deal. His mother is also a big deal. Absolutely brilliant. Both parents were brilliant. They had eight kids. Bonhoeffer was the youngest of four boys, four boys and four girls. Every one of these kids is brilliant. Every one of these kids marries someone who is brilliant. Again, it's hard to exaggerate about what an amazing family this was.
- 1.28 Now, it's interesting. The father, as I said, was one of the great scientists of the early 20th century. Later on, I don't know if I'll get to it, but he figures prominently in what happens in Germany in the '30s, when the Reichstag fire happens, a huge thing. We'll talk in a few lectures from now. In 1933, who is summoned to do the psychiatric evaluation of the Dutch arsonist, the young man, van der Lubbe, who set the fire that burns the Reichstag that really allows Hitler and the Nazis to take total power in Germany? Who is brought in to examine this arsonist? Dietrich Bonhoeffer's father is brought in. On and on, it goes from there. His father plays a prominent role in what happens in Germany under the Nazis because of who he is, a great scientist.
- 1.29 Now, his sons—the three elder sons, they kind of take—this is a funny thing, not to be genetically fatalist, but the three sons, apart from Dietrich, who's the fourth, have the same coloring, this very dark coloring of the father's family, the Bonhoeffer coloring. They follow in his footsteps in terms of being men of science. Bonhoeffer's eldest brother, called Friedrich, goes on to split the atom with Einstein. I mean, it's this level of one of the top physicists in the world. That's his eldest brother, called Friedrich. His other brother, Klaus, becomes the legal head of Lufthansa. That's the father's side of the family, in a sense.
- 1.30 The mother's side of the family, the von Hases, they have dramatically light coloring. They're those toe-headed people who start going bald if they're men at age 17. Like such fine hair, like super bright, white blonde hair. Bonhoeffer gets those jeans. As I said, I met Eberhard Bethge's wife. We spent time with her. That's Bonhoeffer's niece. She had that coloring, piercing blue eyes and this super blonde hair, thin, fine hair.
- 1.31 Why do I say this? I say this because I find it funny that Dietrich Bonhoeffer takes after his mother in a few ways. Her brother was a pastor. Her grandfather and great-grandfather were both very important theologians. She was, as a young girl, involved in the Herrnhuter. This is Count Zinzendorf, this Pietistic Moravian community, people of tremendous faith, actual faith, and theologically very sophisticated—because as I mentioned, the father and the great grandfather were big theologians, not just pastors, but theologians. So Bonhoeffer, in his genes, has this pastoral Christian foundation at the same time that he has this highfalutin and academic theological foundation. So he decides to go in that direction.
- 1.32 But this is all there, this extremely rich family heritage. I'll be touching on that as we move along. But Bonhoeffer was, I think—how do we put this? The environment in which he grew up, you get the impression that, again, this is practically the ideal family. You can't help but think, "Oh, man, what a beautiful family." I think of Ingmar

Bergman's final film, I think, Fanny and Alexander. Just this rich, beautiful world of 1910.

- 1.33** They weren't wealthy, but I'll read from my book: "Their mother presided over the well-appointed home. The staff included a governance, a nurse maid, a house maid, a parlor maid, and a cook." Paula Bonhoeffer, his mother, homeschooled all the kids up until a certain age. She disapproved of the harsh Prussian educational methods, and she thought, I want to educate my kids. She had a school room in the house. She was a very sophisticated educator. She was, as I've said, and I will continue to say, an absolutely brilliant woman.
- 1.34** He grows up in this world. I should say that the three eldest brothers and the two elder sisters, they were a group of five. Then you have Bonhoeffer's twin sister, Sabina. He was born 10 minutes before she was. He teased her about that for the rest of their lives. Obviously, as twins, they were extremely close. Then his sister, Susanne, who was the youngest sister. The three of them—Bonhoeffer, Sabina, and Susanne—they formed this little trio. They hung out together. They were the younger group.
- 1.35** They were overseen by a governess, Fraulein Kethe van Horn, and Maria van Horn. They come from the Herrnhuter world, from the Pietistic Moravian world. So these are profound women of faith charged with educating these little kids. They're the governesses for these kids. So Bonhoeffer has faith at the center of his life. But the mother was also big on this. Their daily life, this is in the Bonhoeffer home. Now, keep in mind, the father was probably an agnostic, and you get the impression that the three older boys were agnostics. But they respected the mother, the father—this was never an issue in the house.
- 1.36** There was great respect in the family between the mother and father. Again, if you think of the ideal marriage, it's hard not to think of their marriage as the ideal marriage, just beautiful. "Daily life was filled in the Bonhoeffer home with Bible reading and him singing, all of it led by Frau Bonhoeffer. Her reverence for the scriptures was such that she read Bible stories to her children from the actual Bible text and not from a children's retelling." Again, I can't say everything I want to say. I guess you have to read the book, but there is so much right in the beginning of his life that is compelling and that you begin to see this is the setup for why he's so great, what makes him who he is.
- 1.37** I want to say again, though, the father, being a great scientist, instilled in all the kids a profound respect for truth, for evidence, for facts. He was, by being this gigantic figure in Berlin as a scientist and a doctor, he really stood against this encroaching world of Freud. He never spoke about it publicly. He didn't make an issue of it. But he was a true brain doctor and scientist who stood against the vague world of Freud and instilled in his kids a respect, not just for facts and evidence and science, but to think clearly, to express oneself clearly, not to just yammer on. If you have nothing to say, feel free to shut up. If you don't shut up, somebody in the family will mock you for whatever dumb thing you said. You could see that there was a standard in the family.

- 1.38 Bonhoeffer's twin sister said her father possessed "great tolerance that left no room for narrow-mindedness and broadened the horizons of our home. He took it for granted that we would try to do what was right and expected much from us, but we could always count on his kindness and the fairness of his judgment. He had a great sense of humor"—and by the way Bonhoeffer himself also did throughout his life— "and often helped us to overcome inhibitions with a timely joke. He had too firm a grip on his emotions to allow himself ever to speak a word to us which was not wholly suitable."
- 1.39 Hard not to admire a man like that. I think most of us, and I'm at the top of the list, fall short. This man was in control of his emotions. "His dislike of clichés"—this is Sabina—" did at times make some of us inarticulate and uncertain of ourselves." They were afraid to talk because they thought, if we misstep or say something, he's going to look at us funny. "But it has the effect that as adults, we no longer had any taste for catchwords, gossip, commonplaces, or loquacity. He himself would never have used a catchword or a trendy phrase." That's the Bonhoeffer family. Those are the parents, really inescapably impressive human beings who raised all of their children to the highest standard, to the very, very highest standard. It's just undeniable.
- 1.40 I mentioned the mother's faith. She also had spent time as a young girl with the Herrnhuters, the Moravian world. So there was a real, a genuine faith. I should say that Count Zinzendorf—now this is the 18th century, but just so you understand what you're dealing with, with the Herrnhuter and the Moravians,— "Zinzendorf advocated the idea of a personal relationship with God rather than the formal churchgoing Lutheranism of the day. Zinzendorf used the term living faith, which he contrasted unfavorably with the prevailing nominalism of dull Protestant orthodoxy. Zinzendorf's ideas influenced John Wesley, who visited Herrnhut in 1738, which was the year of Wesley's famous conversion." So Zinzendorf is a giant.
- 1.41 When we think that that carries on through the 17th century, through the 18th century, early part of the 19th century, Bonhoeffer's mother would have visited probably around 1890. But that kind of living faith, relationship with God, as opposed to the dull Protestant orthodoxy of the day. In a way, that also sets up Bonhoeffer for who he ends up being, because as we'll see going on, he's very disappointed in the German church, in the Lutheran Church. They seem to be going through the motions, and he's trying to advocate, as you'll see, for them to have a living faith, to step out in an active way as a result of their faith when the Nazis come to power, to use their faith to stand against the Nazis.
- 1.42 So all of this underscores his development. When you're talking about Dietrich Bonhoeffer's early life, it doesn't take long before—he's born in 1906—before you get to World War I. We know World War I starts in 1914. Now, the Bonhoeffers, it's worth saying, they were very patriotic Germans, but they were not overly patriotic in the sense that—I, as a Christian, would say, you don't want to make an idol of patriotism—I think it's healthy to be patriotic. It's unhealthy not to have patriotism, but can you take

it too far? The classic case of taking nationalism too far is Germany going into World War I. It's hard for us today to imagine Germany fighting to the death with the French.

- 1.43** You think, what? What is going on there? We're not going to get into that. But the fact of the matter is it happened. You can look it up. It's called World War I. They thought it would be over pretty quick. It was not. It took four years. Bonhoeffer's three elder brothers all served in the war. Bonhoeffer was close with his brother Walter. Obviously, Walter is much older. But in 1917, Karl-Friedrich, who goes on to become the physicist, and Walter were called up. They were both born in 1899, so it's their turn. Bonhoeffer was 12 years old at the time. Walter goes to war, two weeks later is killed.
- 1.44** This is such a wound in the Bonhoeffer family. His mother, Paula Bonhoeffer, loses her mind a little bit over this. Keep in mind, she has three sons in the war. One of them is killed. Karl-Friedrich is in the war. Finally, the youngest, Klaus, is called up. I think they pulled some strings so that Klaus would not be on the front lines because the thought of losing another son—you can only imagine what happened.
- 1.45** But Walter's funeral in 1917, Paula, her brother, preaches the funeral sermon. Imagine, your 17 or 18-year-old son has just been killed. Paula Bonhoeffer also chose the hymns for her son's funeral in 1918. The one that I wanted to quote, just to give you some sense of the faith we're talking about in Paula Bonhoeffer. It's a famous Lutheran hymn from the 17th century. The English translation doesn't really do it justice, but what it says is, "What God has done"—imagine, her son has just died—"what God has done, it is well done. His will is always just. Whatever he will do to me, in Him I'll ever place my trust."
- 1.46** For her to choose that as a statement of faith at her son's funeral, that is just as bold as it gets. I think—I remember, I guess, my senior year in college, someone was killed, someone really extraordinary in a car accident. His father was a minister, and at the funeral, he said something like this, and I thought, "Wow, that is faith. What faith must you have to be able to say that when you've just lost a tremendously beloved son?" Now, Dietrich Bonhoeffer, he's 12. He really loved and looked up to his brother Walter. So this must have been very tough for him.
- 1.47** Now, I should say, to go along with the Forrest Gump theme of the Bonhoeffer family, the Germans obviously lose the war in 1918. This is devastating, very devastating for Germany. We'll get into it. It sets up the rise of the Nazis and everything. The Allies imposed very strict conditions on Germany. One is the Versailles Treaty, which is devastating. It was, I think, in retrospect, obviously far too harsh imposed on Germany.
- 1.48** The Allies also insisted the end of the German monarchy. So the Kaiser—Kaiser is the German form of Caesar, the Russian version is Tsar. So the Kaiser, this monarch, is forced to abdicate. It's an amazing thing. So they send Field Marshal von Hindenburg to do the dirty work, to go to Kaiser Wilhelm at the Supreme Headquarters in Spa and let him know, "You have to abdicate." This is just humiliating for the Germans.

- 1.49 But in keeping with the Forrest Gump theme of how the Bonhoeffer family is everywhere, I'll read from my book, "When Hindenburg left the conference room after that meeting, a 17-year-old orderly from Grünewald"—that's where the Bonhoeffer family home was located"—was standing in the hallway. Klaus Bonhoeffer"— this is Dietrich's brother—"never forgot the moment when the stout Hindenburg brushed past him. He later described the exiting Hindenburg as being 'rigid as a statue, both in countenance and bearing.'"
- 1.50 So Bonhoeffer's brother Klaus is standing there when Hindenburg exits from this unbelievably historic moment. It's like you are there at the moment when the Kaiser is forced to abdicate, when the Allies have imposed these harsh conditions on Germany. Klaus was standing right there. He got to tell his family about it. It's almost unbelievable. The war is over. Germany descends into what can only be described as chaos. They have never had democracy before. A lot of people don't even understand what democracy is. There are different kinds of democracy. Some democracies are not so hot.
- 1.51 The Weimar Republic was forced on Germany. They didn't have a history of democracy. They had done quite well under the Kaiser. It was not exactly a tyrannical monarchy. But so suddenly they're forced to have a Reichstag and to have democracy. It really leads to chaos in Germany because they didn't know how to govern themselves. This is not the time for me to lecture on that. I wrote a book called *If You Can Keep It*, and I talk about this a lot. What does it mean to govern yourself? What is self-government? What is liberty on the American model? They didn't have that in Germany. It was just imposed on them by the Allies.
- 1.52 And so suddenly, they're trying to govern themselves, and it leads to chaos. It leads to factions and so on and so forth. It leads, as we now know, to economic depression on a level we can't even comprehend. So Germany in the '20s is a mess, and this prepares the way for the ascent of Adolf Hitler and the Nazis.
- 1.53 At age 13, in 1919, Bonhoeffer is 13. This is a year after his brother's death. He decides firmly, "I am going to be a theologian." Again, in a family like this where they're looking at you funny and criticizing you, very, very big deal for him to say, "I want to be a theologian." Anybody know any 13-year-olds who say, 'I would like to be a theologian?' Pretty dramatic. Again, he's following the footsteps of his grandfather, his great-grandfather, but he was brilliant, in case I haven't said it yet, absolutely brilliant. He decides he wants to do it, but he doesn't announce it formally to the family until he's 14. He felt like, I better make sure I know what I'm thinking about this because he knew that they're going to give him a hard time, and they really did give him a hard time.
- 1.54 In fact, his brother Klaus—I just mentioned Klaus was standing there when Hindenburg brushes past at Spa after the Kaiser has been forced to abdicate. Klaus was, with the other brothers, critical of Dietrich. They knew how brilliant he was. And by the way, he

was also a virtuoso musician. So at this point, they're all thinking he may go into music. He's brilliant. But they mock him.

- 1.55** So his brother Klaus, when Bonhoeffer says, "I'm going to be a theologian," and also probably says, "And I want to be a pastor," his brother says that the church—so the brother is mocking this, right? He says, "The church is a poor, feeble, boring, petty bourgeois institution." The 14-year-old Bonhoeffer says, "In that case, I shall have to reform it." How many 14-year-olds would have the chutzpah to say that I am going to reform the church—not just like, well, I've just chosen to go into theology, but I want to reform the church.
- 1.56** It's really amazing. And guess what? That is exactly what he ends up doing one way or the other, as we'll see. It's amazing to me, and it's amazing to me that we even have the record of that, that the Bonhoeffers wrote a lot about everything. They record this moment when this precocious 14-year-old says that he vows to reform the church.
- 1.57** I should say that Bonhoeffer's mother, Paula, gives Dietrich, around this time, his brother Walter's Bible. So Walter had been killed in the war. They put this in the film, actually. He's given his brother's Bible. For the rest of his life, Dietrich Bonhoeffer used it for his daily devotions. I mean, imagine what it meant to him to have the Bible that belonged to his brother who'd been killed.
- 1.58** In 1921, so Bonhoeffer was 15 years old, we have a record of him going to the first evangelistic meeting of his life. Now, again, we have to be real clear. The church in Germany, Christians in Germany, tended to go along with the dull Protestant Lutheran orthodoxy. So they'd go to church, and it really was a petty, bourgeois, dull institution. You have the Herrnhuter and the Zinzendorf really living out their faith, but that's not typical in Germany.
- 1.59** So Bonhoeffer's experience of the church is very, very mixed. But at age 15, he goes—in Berlin, the Salvation Army had, because there was so much suffering, poverty—because, again, of the war, because the economy had tanked, starving people—Bramwell Booth, who's the son of the founder of the Salvation Army, visits Germany. They're feeding people. They're doing what Christians are supposed to do, feeding the hungry, and this goes on and on.
- 1.60** In 1921, General Bramwell Booth visits—Bonhoeffer's 15—and in Berlin, preaches a big evangelistic meeting. Bonhoeffer goes to that and was very affected by it. Bonhoeffer's sister Sabina, his twin sister, recalled that "Dietrich was eager to take part in it. He was the youngest person there, but he was very interested. He was impressed by the joy he had seen on Booth's face. He told us of the people carried away by Booth and of the conversions."
- 1.61** Somebody raised as the grandson and great-grandson of theologians as the nephew of a pastor, hadn't seen this Christianity. He's exposed to what many Americans are today familiar with, but he'd not seen it before, and it really affected him. He wouldn't see

this again, dramatically, until he goes to New York a few years later. But it's just interesting to me that he was interested in seeing this and that he was, in fact, moved by it and that he remarks on being moved by the joy that he saw. Joy that you don't associate with Lutheran liturgy or—there's this formality. So he was moved by that faith.

- 1.62** Well, by the time he's 17, it's time to go to college. He followed in the family's footsteps by spending his first year at Tübingen University. His father had been there. There's a lot I can say about that. We don't really have time. He joins a fraternity. Again, it's actually pretty interesting, and some of it's funny, but I don't have time right now. But I have to say that one of the members of the fraternity remembered Bonhoeffer as "extremely secure and self-confident, but able to tolerate criticism. He was also a companionable, physically agile and tough young man who possessed a sharp nose for essentials and a determination to get to the bottom of things, and who was also capable of subtly teasing people who had a great deal of humor."
- 1.63** I mentioned this in a few places in my book. It amazes me that throughout his life, people mention his humor, his sense of humor. I want to be real clear, we often get this version of Bonhoeffer as dour and headed to the gallows. You've got to throw that away and understand this is a man who loved life, who appreciated every aspect of life, of culture. At the heart of it was this keen sense of humor.
- 1.64** Well, so getting back to the state of Germany. Germany is in free fall, 1923 was particularly disastrous. The German mark, my goodness, I should say this. In 1921, the German mark, it dropped the value to 75 marks to the dollar. In 1922, it dropped to 400 marks to the dollar. By early '23, it plunged to 7,000 marks to the dollar. This is, again, the harsh terms of the Versailles Treaty were crippling Germany economically. By November 1923, \$1 was worth about 4 billion German marks.
- 1.65** So Germany is trying to figure out, what do we do here? We're falling apart. The Versailles Treaty is too harsh. One of the terms of the Versailles Treaty was you cannot have an army because they were so threatened. The Allies were so threatened by Germany, it was like, "Oh, you don't get to have an army either." And Germany was actually worried, just over the border—I should say they were only allowed to have a 100,000-man army—and so they were really concerned, the Russians just over the border in Poland, might have marched in at any point to subdue them. There was a lot of trouble.
- 1.66** So the Germans, to get around this, did private training of young men. So they weren't officially in the army, but almost like a militia or something like that. Dietrich Bonhoeffer, famously called a pacifist, which he was not, he enrolls in this. He decides, yes, I'm going to do this. It's 1923, November—23—what does it make him? 17 years old. He's attending Tübingen University, and he goes to serve in what's called the Black Reichswehr. He writes back home to his family, "Today, I am a soldier." He's proud of this. Again, to push against this idea that he's a pacifist or that they were all pacifists.

They were against hyper-nationalism. They were against going to war for no reason. They were against Hitler's kind of nationalism. But they certainly didn't feel that a country shouldn't be able to protect itself.

- 1.67** Around his 18th birthday, and this is important, Bonhoeffer—anyway, he was very, I mentioned in one of the quotes, very physically agile, doing all kinds of stuff, very interested in sports. He slips and falls on the ice. He was skating on the Neckar River in Tübingen—I have visited there. He lay unconscious for some time. So his family really is deeply worried about him, and they go to visit. While they're there, they celebrate his 18th birthday, and he gets this idea in his head to maybe to play on their sympathy, for their son who almost died skating, to say to them that he wants to do a semester in Rome.
- 1.68** Now, Rome, we've got to be clear—if you receive the classical education that Bonhoeffer received, to go to Rome would be a dream. So long story short, he and Klaus, that's his next older brother, they visit Rome. And what we see there—this sets us up for the future—Bonhoeffer, for the first time, is seriously asking the question, "What is the church?" Now, imagine you come from a Lutheran German Church. Now, he goes to Rome, and Bonhoeffer, again, being brilliant and incredibly curious, intellectually curious, culturally curious, he goes to every Roman Catholic Church service. He buys a missal to follow along, and he's really moved by what he sees. He observed the universality of the church.
- 1.69** Now, this is going to figure into his future, to ask the question, "What is the church? Is the church just the German church, or does the church extend beyond the boundaries of Germany? What is the church?" He sees in Rome, example after example, of this thing called the Church Universal. There's a moment, I guess he's at a service, and he sees people of every race and color celebrating. This is the quote from Bonhoeffer: "The universality of the church was illustrated in a marvelously effective manner. White, black, yellow members of religious orders— everyone was in clerical robes united under the church. It truly seems ideal."
- 1.70** So he's asking these questions now, "What is the church?" And he sees something here. Now, imagine that he's open-minded enough. He's going to be a Lutheran pastor. He's been steeped in German Lutheranism, but he's open-minded enough not to say, "Oh, these are the Catholics. We want nothing to do with them." He is very moved by it and open to it and is asking the question, "Is there something I can learn here from people? Maybe I disagree with them on some things, but can they teach me something? Are we getting something wrong?"
- 1.71** He starts wondering about the Lutheran Church. He starts wondering about the Reformation. Was the Reformation a good thing? He begins asking these questions. Now, he has just turned 18, but he's asking these questions. These are the questions he will ask for the rest of his life. As you'll see, he writes his doctoral dissertation on the question of "What is the church?" And then he lives it out, as we'll get to.

- 1.72 He also says that that Palm Sunday in Rome, he attends evensong and was deeply moved by it. He says, "With unbelievable simplicity, grace, and great seriousness, they sang evensong while a priest officiated at the altar. The ritual was truly no longer merely ritual. Instead, it was worship in the true sense. The whole thing gave one an unparalleled impression of profound guileless piety."
- 1.73 He's really thinking about this. What is mere religion as opposed to real faith? What is mere ritual? When does ritual move past ritual into worship of God? It's, at least interesting, that he asked these questions profoundly for the first time while he's in Rome, while he sees it in the Catholic tradition. I think that's very, very important. But as I said, it's 1923-24. He's going to leave Tübingen, go back to Berlin. He's going to study at Berlin University.
- 1.74 This sets us up now for the rise of the Nazis. It sets us up for all that follows, and a lot follows. But I hope that at least lays the foundation. It gets more exciting and crazy as we move along. But that's really the foundation. That's the childhood and family life of Bonhoeffer up until his 18th birthday and his visit to Rome.

Lecture 2: Theological Foundations

At a glance — Theological foundations.

- 2.1 Welcome to lecture two of this course on Dietrich Bonhoeffer. If you're not signed up for this lecture, you need to leave now. There's so much to say about Bonhoeffer, and I keep saying that because it's true, and it's hard to underscore that enough. In this lecture, I want to talk about his theology.
- 2.2 I mentioned at the end of the previous lecture that he spent some time in Rome. He goes to study at Tuebingen in for a year. Then he goes to Rome. He starts asking the question, the question that really is the question of his life: "What is the church?" Properly speaking, "What is the church? What is the role of the church?" This comes up when the Nazis rise to power. Bonhoeffer starts speaking to the church and saying, "Hey, church, it's your job to stand against evil." That's the job of the church. That's what it means to be the church.
- 2.3 So these ideas are not merely intellectual or theological ideas. That right there sums up Bonhoeffer—that he takes these ideas that are often merely theological and intellectual and makes it clear: "No, no, no." If they're merely theological and intellectual, they're useless, they're nothing. They must be lived out. You must put your faith in your theology into action. Otherwise, it proves you actually have no faith. This is a central theme for his life, maybe the central theme for his life. He's asking this question, "What is the church?"
- 2.4 The title of my book on Bonhoeffer is Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy. Right now, we're going to talk a little bit about him as a pastor and a little bit of him as beginning to develop what I would call a prophetic voice. He would not have called it that, but you see it. It seems undeniable once you know where his life leads. When you look back at him as an 18-year-old, a 19-year-old, a 20-year-old, you begin to see him developing this prophetic voice.
- 2.5 At the end of the last lecture, we were talking about his time in Rome, where he actually sees the church as being universal, as extending beyond the boundaries of Germany, beyond the boundaries of Lutheranism. He dares to ask these kinds of questions. He had tremendous intellectual confidence, and growing up in the home in which he grew up, which we spoke about in the last lecture, you can see that being surrounded by these geniuses at the dinner table every night, you really had to think about what you were thinking. You had to be careful about what you were saying. You had to be rigorous, and he was.
- 2.6 Eberhard Bethge, whom I've mentioned a few times and will continue to mention, who became his best friend and his most famous biographer, said of Bonhoeffer during the period we're going to discuss now—so 1924 to 1927. He's 18, 19, 20-years-old. He leaves Tübingen and starts studying after he comes back from Rome in Berlin at Berlin

University. He is now living at home. Again, he's in this extraordinary environment, amazing environment. He lives at 14 Wangenheimstraße. There's no way to pronounce that in English, 14 Wangenheimstraße. I have visited it. I think there's a picture of it in my book or someplace.

- 2.7** But this amazing home in this really important part of Berlin, a neighborhood where all the people who lived there were big deals of one kind or another. But Eberhard Bethge says of it, "It was hard for any group of people to live up to the standards expected and maintained in the Wangenheimstraße. Bonhoeffer himself admitted that newcomers to his home were put under the microscope. With that background, it was easy for him to create the impression of being superior and standoffish."
- 2.8** You can just imagine. His father is Karl Bonhoeffer, this very nationally famous scientist. Everybody there is brilliant. Whoever comes to the table, they're going to be expected to deliver. At this point, his eldest brother, Karl-Friedrich, is already working with Einstein and Max Planck. Bonhoeffer chooses now, of course, we've said it, to study theology at Berlin University. This was the place in the world to study theology.
- 2.9** To set the stage, the theological faculty, 1924, when Bonhoeffer enters as an 18-year-old, is headed by Adolf von Harnack, 73 years old at the time and a living legend at the time. Harnack was a disciple of Schleiermacher, which is to say staunchly theologically liberal, and one of the leaders of the historical critical method of the 19th and early 20th century. You often hear about the German critical theology of that period.
- 2.10** Harnack's approach to the Bible was limited to textual and historical critical analysis, which led him to conclude that the miracles it described never happened and that the Gospel of John was not canonical. Now, one of Bonhoeffer's students who was—Bonhoeffer took Harnack's seminar, several seminar studies under Harnack—he comes not eventually to agree with Harnack, but respects him and his intellect very, very much. But one of Bonhoeffer's fellow students said—Helmut Goes—recalled feeling a secret enthusiasm for Bonhoeffer's, "free, critical, and independent theological thinking." Bonhoeffer, already at age 18, is very self-confident intellectually, not cocky. I don't think he came across as cocky. There's a humility, but a confidence.
- 2.11** Helmut is talking about Bonhoeffer at this point, age 18 or 19. He says, "What really impressed me was not just the fact that he surpassed almost all of us in theological knowledge in capacity. But what passionately attracted me to Bonhoeffer was the perception that here was a man who did not only learn and gather in the verba and scripta of some master"—in this case, Harnack—"but one who thought independently and already knew what he wanted and wanted what he knew."
- 2.12** Now, again, there's a lot about Bonhoeffer that I find entertaining and funny. It's delightful. Here, Helmut Goes says, "I had the experience, for me it was something alarming and magnificently new, of hearing a young, fair-haired student"—this is Bonhoeffer—"contradict the revered historian, his excellency, von Harnack." This must

be shocking to see. I mean, imagine, in 1924 in Berlin—"contradict him politely but clearly on positive theological grounds. Harnack answered, but the student contradicted again and again." I just find this hilarious that Bonhoeffer—he's polite, but he's not intimidated by Harnack, even though he is, as you would be if you're raised as a Bonhoeffer, you're respectful. He was certainly respectful.

- 2.13** Bonhoeffer, as we're saying, is now at—it's the center of the world of theology. It's the center of the world of German theology, it's the center of the world of what we today would call liberal theology. Harnack is in the footsteps of Schleiermacher, effectively saying that we're not going to take the Bible too seriously. We're going to study it as a text. Bonhoeffer already is differing with the great master in this. Now, whether that's because of the influence of his mother and the Herrnhuter, the Moravian movement, it's not all that clear. But it's just important to say that he is willing to dissent, that he has the self-confidence to dissent.
- 2.14** Which brings us now to the subject of Karl Barth. We've been talking about Schleiermacher. We've been talking about Harnack. There were other big shots there: Karl Holl, the greatest Luther scholar of that generation, Reinhold Seeberg, specialized in systematic theology, Adolf Deissmann. But there was another theologian who had a greater influence on Bonhoeffer than any of these and whom he would revere and respect as much as anyone in his lifetime, who would even become a mentor and a friend. This was Karl Barth of Göttingen.
- 2.15** Karl Barth, just two years before Bonhoeffer enters Berlin, and again, to be clear, he was in Göttingen, he published his groundbreaking commentary, *The Epistle to the Romans*. I say in my book that his book, *The Epistle to the Romans*, "fell like a smart bomb into the ivory tower of scholars like Adolf von Harnack, who could hardly believe their historical critical fortress pregnable, and who were scandalized by Barth's approach to the Bible, which came to be called neo-Orthodoxy, and which asserted the idea, particularly controversial in German theological circles, that God actually exists and that all theology and biblical scholarship must be undergirded by this basic assumption" and that's that.
- 2.16** So, fascinating to think that the young Dietrich Bonhoeffer reads that book, probably read it before 1924, and is thinking along Barthian lines about who God is. Bonhoeffer, again—all of this stuff I find funny and fascinating—he would ride the streetcar from the Grunewald neighborhood into Berlin, where the University of Berlin was, with Adolf von Harnack. He's not just in the lecture with this revered liberal theologian, but he's hanging out with him, riding in the streetcar with him. You can see that he was mixing in circles where he just wasn't intimidated by anyone. But again, I want to make real clear he was always very, very respectful.
- 2.17** So '24, '25, '26, '27, Bonhoeffer's at Berlin University. I want to underscore how young he is. He is spending a lot of time at home. The cultural ferment of that family, again, is absolutely extraordinary. He's going to plays, he's going to operas, he's reading

everything, discussing everything. He's beginning to think about, what will I write my dissertation on. He gets his doctorate at the preposterous age of 21. By September of—I believe it's '27, no, '26—he makes his decision that he's going to write his doctoral dissertation under Seeberg, whom I've mentioned. He would write about the subject he'd been puzzling over in Rome, namely, what is the church? That dissertation, which eventually is published as a book is titled *Sanctorum Communio*, a dogmatic inquiry into the sociology of the church. He would identify the church as neither a historical entity nor an institution, but as, "Christ existing as church community."

- 2.18** It was such a stunning debut for this 21-year-old genius that Karl Barth got a hold of it, read it, and called it a theological miracle. Karl Barth is arguably the greatest theologian for 500 years. He calls Bonhoeffer's dissertation, written at age 21, a theological miracle. Eventually, Bonhoeffer, as we've mentioned, would meet Karl Barth and become a friend. But it's amazing to think that he was so already known at age 21 as a brilliant theologian that his dissertation falls into the hands of Karl Barth of Gottingen. Karl Barth reads it and calls it a theological miracle. I don't think he got a big blurb on the book from Karl Barth, but if it had happened today, he would have.
- 2.19** But this is the period where Bonhoeffer begins to put into action what I've mentioned a few times. He didn't believe that it's enough to have great theology. You have to actually live it out. You have to be able to communicate it. Here he writes this dissertation at age 21 on the highest theological level. But he's able to communicate what he's writing about on this highest of theological levels to anybody.
- 2.20** He eventually would communicate this as a pastor and as a preacher to average people in the pew. Even more dramatic, he would communicate these ideas to children. He always felt, "I've got to be able to communicate these ideas." I think part of the problem with a lot of academics and with a lot of theologians, and certainly a lot of Bonhoeffer scholars that I have read, is that they're operating in a realm that any average person couldn't possibly be interested in or understand what they're saying.
- 2.21** Bonhoeffer always stood against that. He never thought of the academy as some cast of high priests who will determine reality and then tell the dumb people, this is what you're to conclude. He wanted to invite people in to think for themselves, to help people think about this stuff. This begins already now. Again, imagine he's 18, 19, 20. He begins to wonder if he should pursue the life of a pastor rather than merely an academic.
- 2.22** To that end, he led a Sunday School class at his local church. He obviously didn't need to do this. He thought that he should. Out of the Sunday School class grew this thing called the Thursday Circle, "a weekly reading and discussion group of young men he personally selected, which met at his home and which he taught. He issued invitations to this group, which began in April of 1927"— so he's 21 years old. "The invitations"— this is classic Bonhoeffer—"The invitations stated that the group would meet every

Thursday from 5:25 pm to 7:00 pm." So like don't think about waltzing in at 6:05 pm or at 5:40 pm. It starts at 5:25 pm. I just find that German precision funny, delightful.

- 2.23** He felt that it was important to train up the next generation of young men. Clearly, he's not just some ivory tower academic, but he picks a number of these young men to be part of this Thursday Circle. He's doing this of his own accord. He's 21 years old, and he's really pouring himself into these young men. The topics were not merely theological. Sometimes he would talk about cultural things. One week, he gave a talk on Wagner's Parsifal, and then he took this group to see the opera itself.
- 2.24** Imagine, it's Berlin—tremendous cultural sophistication—and you can go and do these things. But in the group, he dealt with questions of Christian apologetics. Did God create the world? What is the purpose of prayer? Who is Jesus Christ? He would ask ethical questions. Again—well, I don't think I've mentioned it yet—Bonhoeffer dealt with ethics. His final book—he never quite completed it, but his friend Eberhard Bethge edited it after Bonhoeffer died—his book *Ethics*, he's asking these big questions. He doesn't have easy answers. He's really probing the depths of "What is right? What is wrong?"
- 2.25** Here already at age 21 with this group of young men, they deal with the question, "Is there such a thing as a necessary lie?" This is a big thing because a lot of Christians might have a very cavalier attitude and say, "Obviously, the Scripture is very clear, lying is a sin." That itself is a lie. That's not true. But a lot of people have a very cavalier, hidebound theology. It's very open and shut. Bonhoeffer knew that's not true. He's exploring this stuff, but this stuff becomes very central to his own life. Later on, as the Nazis are rising: "Can I tell a lie? If the Gestapo comes to my door and say "Are you hiding a Jew?" Do you say, "Oh, yeah, I'm a Christian. I can't tell a lie. Please come and get and kill the Jew." No. Bonhoeffer is thinking much more deeply.
- 2.26** Is killing wrong? That's another big theological ethical question. Well, the Bible says, "Thou shalt not murder." It doesn't say no killing. David kills Goliath, and we don't go, "Oh, yeah. That's before David became a Christian and repented and prayed with Goliath's family." It's a little more complicated. Bonhoeffer, God bless him, he has the sophistication and the confidence and the humility to really ask these questions, to really try to think about what is the right answer, what is God's answer. That becomes very important later in life. But already here as a 21-year-old, he's exploring these things with these young men. He really gets into all kinds of stuff.
- 2.27** I just want to touch on, again, his cultural sophistication. One week in this group, this Thursday Circle, the topic was the gods of the ancient Germans. One week, it was famous poets: Goethe, Schiller; another one, famous painters: Grunewald, Durer, Rembrandt. They discussed mystery cults, Muslim faith. He really gets into this stuff and invites others to do that with him. I don't want to get into this too much, but I just want to be clear, there's not much in my book that is absolutely brand new, that had

never been known before. I think it's never been collected and told in the way that I tell it. But there are a few things in my book that no one really knew.

- 2.28** One of those things, when I, in 2008, was doing research, I had the privilege of visiting, as I mentioned, Eberhard Bethge's widow. I was able in 2008 to ask her a question and get an answer, which probably nobody writing about Bonhoeffer would have gotten an answer to before, and I can explain why. But I had read here and there just a little—I got little glimpses that there was some woman in his life during this period, but I could never find out who the name was or anything. The only thing you know is later on when Bonhoeffer is 36, he becomes engaged to Maria von Wedemeyer, and there's that great love affair, which we'll get into in a subsequent lecture.
- 2.29** But who was this young man? Was there any woman in his life? Well, when I asked Frau Bethge in her home in 2008, she said in a very German matter of fact way, she says, "Oh, yes, this was Elisabeth Zinn." I thought, wow, I've never read that before. I did some research, and it's fascinating. I really won't go into it much, but Bonhoeffer, he spent a lot of time with Elisabeth Zinn in this Berlin period. The reason no one had ever written about this before was because I think it would have been embarrassing.
- 2.30** Elizabeth Zinn was a theologian. She's married. She eventually marries a big deal, a New Testament scholar, Gunther Bornkamm. It would have been uncomfortable to mention her, I think. She's kept out of everything. But by 2008, while I'm doing my research, all this stuff is ancient history. All these people are either very old or have passed away. Frau Bethge feels free to share with me this information. Because I think any human being wants to wonder, what was Bonhoeffer like? He's a young man. Didn't he have any women in his life? Yeah, he would go to operas and plays with her. As I say, the details are in my book, but I think it's worth mentioning.
- 2.31** In 1928, Bonhoeffer is 22 years old. He's already got his doctorate. He cannot get ordained as pastor till age 25. He's only 22. What is he doing? Well, he's teaching at Berlin University, doing some teaching. But this is when he decides, and it, again, underscores his cultural curiosity—the whole family is like this. He gets an offer to be the pastor—now, again, he's 22 years old—or the visiting pastor of a church in Barcelona, Spain, a German congregation in Barcelona, Spain. He really thinks, "You know what? This is going to be great. I'm going to get to leave my environment. I'm going to see if I can stand my own two feet."
- 2.32** He goes to Barcelona, Spain. This is his own words. He says, "This offer"—to be a pastor in Barcelona—"seemed to bring to fruition a wish that had grown stronger and stronger over the past few years and months, namely to stand on my own feet for a longer period, completely outside my previous circle of acquaintances." He goes to Barcelona. Again, you have to find this funny. He masters Spanish, like in five minutes. In two years, as we'll say in the next lecture, he learns—he goes to America, masters English. Did I mention he was a genius? He was a genius.

- 2.33** But while he's in Barcelona, he begins to develop more some of these theological ideas that follow with him, follow through his whole life. One of the things that he writes about, I have a quote—he was obsessed with the Incarnation. In other words, not to see God as distant, but to understand that the whole point of the Christian faith is to see that God comes into our humanity, this was hugely important to Luther, becomes a human being and wants us, if we are people of faith, to live out our faith in our real lives, not to have it separated, that it's this theological area, this religious area. No, we're supposed to live it out.
- 2.34** Bonhoeffer's quote is: "God wants to see human beings, not ghosts who shun the world." He said that in "the whole of world history, there is always only one really significant hour—the present. [I]f you want to find eternity, you must serve the times." This is just a huge theme for Bonhoeffer. He calls the this- worldliness of Christianity. You've got to live in this world. It's an important concept, and again, he lives it out in many ways. We'll be exploring that. But again, a lot of Bonhoeffer, he's so smart that I find a lot of what he does and says very funny because I think he's probably sometimes unaware of how he comes across.
- 2.35** I mentioned that he set up this Thursday Circle in Berlin. Now he goes to Barcelona and he decides on his own, he's not just going to preach on the Sundays when the head pastor is away visiting his mother or whatever it was, or the lead pastor goes away for the whole summer and Bonhoeffer is preaching. Bonhoeffer, on his own, just out of his own faith, says that he wants to give three lectures to the high schoolers of the time. These lectures are so impressive. I quote them at length in my book. Again, it's very funny to me because he's talking to high schoolers. He respects them enough to try to communicate these huge ideas to them. I want to quote from those lectures.
- 2.36** But before I do that, I want to go back and touch on another theme that you see with Bonhoeffer. I've mentioned it a little bit, but it's the idea—it culminates, as we'll see eventually, in his use of the term religionless Christianity. He gets this idea from Karl Barth. God is real, number one. Number two, to play at religion is wrong. Just to have liturgy and to go through the ritual—it has to be real. God is real. God wants us to have a relationship with him. Bonhoeffer becomes a critic of the church in a sense, because he sees all this piety and all the liturgy, and he thinks, "Well, wait a minute, are you actually living it out?"
- 2.37** While he's in Barcelona, he's writing a letter to a friend, and he says, "Every day I'm getting to know people, at any rate their circumstances, and sometimes one is able to see through their stories into themselves—at the same time one thing continues to impress me: here I meet people as they are, far from the masquerade of 'the Christian world'; people with passions, criminal types, small people with small aims, small wages and small sins—all in all, they are people who feel homeless in both senses, and who begin to thaw when one speaks to them with kindness—real people."

- 2.38 He always knew that this is the heart of the faith is dealing with real people, people who don't speak maybe the theological language or maybe don't speak the church religious language, but they're human beings created by God in God's image for whom Jesus died. How do we speak to them? How do we reach them? Then he says in the same letter, "I can only say that I've gained the impression that it is just these people who are much more under grace than under wrath, and that it is the Christian world which is more under wrath than grace."
- 2.39 Now, again, he's a very young man. He's 22, but he sees this already. He's criticizing the church, the religiosity of the church, this theological language that's often used. He's dealing with real people. Again, some of the anecdotes are funny. I don't have time to get into it, but this becomes real to him, and he begins to write about it. I want to talk about these three lectures. Now, this is so fascinating. When people talk about Bonhoeffer, as I say, when I first began writing my book, you encounter these versions of Bonhoeffer that something seems wrong or it's confusing.
- 2.40 This is a classic example. Here he is at age 22. He's giving three lectures to high school students. Again, it's funny. He doesn't need to do this. He's not getting paid extra. He just decides, I actually care about these young people. I care about them learning something, so I'm going to give these lectures. Thank God, these lectures have been preserved and we can read them. But I quote them, and it's just fascinating to me to see his theology is already formed. Now, it doesn't mean that there's not some evolution, but it's not evolution in the sense of real change. It's just a deepening of what's already there.
- 2.41 The reason I'm framing it this way is that some people say, "Oh, Bonhoeffer doesn't really become a Christian until he goes to New York"—which is going to be in the next lecture—he encounters the faith in Abyssinian Baptist Church in Harlem among the Black community. Something happens. He really becomes a Christian then. There's truth to that. We'll get into that. But the idea that he was not theologically grounded before that or that he had some wacky ideas before that, all you need to do is read these lectures and you realize: whoa, this dude got the faith on such an amazing level that I want to quote some of these here.
- 2.42 This is something—you'd think that C.S. Lewis wrote this. This is like, I don't know, 20 years before C.S. Lewis writes *Mere Christianity*. Bonhoeffer, as a 22-year-old, writes this. He says—this is in a lecture to high school students: "One admires Christ according to aesthetic categories as an aesthetic genius, calls him the greatest ethicist; one admires his going to his death as a heroic sacrifice for his ideas. Only one thing one doesn't do: one doesn't take him seriously." In other words, he's criticizing the popular cultural view among many so-called Christians like, "Oh, Jesus is great. He's a model. What would Jesus do? How did he behave? Oh, he believed in what he taught so strongly that he went to his death." And Bonhoeffer was like, "Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah." He's like "I see through that. Because you're not taking Him seriously."

- 2.43 Bonhoeffer says, "That is, one doesn't bring the center of his or her own life into contact with the claim of Christ to speak the revelation of God and to be that revelation." That's the challenge. If you're really trying to figure out what is the Christian faith saying, Bonhoeffer is saying that's what nobody wants to deal with. That's what everybody skates over the top of that. They say, "Oh, yeah, Jesus is great. He's a great role model." He says, "One maintains a distance between himself or herself and the word of Christ, and allows no serious encounter to take place"—a gain, he's talking to high school students.
- 2.44 "I can doubtless live with or without Jesus as a religious genius, as an ethicist, as a gentleman—just as, after all, I can also live without Plato and Kant. Should, however, there be something in Christ that claims my life entirely with the full seriousness that here God himself speaks and if the word of God once became present only in Christ, then Christ has not only relative but absolute, urgent significance for me." He's speaking evangelistically to high school students.
- 2.45 "Understanding Christ means taking Christ seriously. Understanding this claim means taking seriously his absolute claim on our commitment. And it is now of importance for us to clarify the seriousness of this matter and to extricate Christ from the secularization process in which he has been incorporated since the Enlightenment." Now, again, I find this funny. He's talking to high school students. I don't think that the other pastor ever brought up the secularization process or the Enlightenment.
- 2.46 But Bonhoeffer is getting to the point of points. He's letting them all know all this religious stuff, yadda, yadda, yadda. You are being confronted directly with, "Who is Jesus?" Bonhoeffer in the same lecture says, "Factually speaking, Christ has given scarcely any ethical prescriptions that were not to be found already with the contemporary Jewish rabbis or in pagan literature." He's basically saying it's not about that. It's not about that. He must have shocked some of his listeners, but his logic was undeniably compelling.
- 2.47 He then aggressively attacked the idea of religion. Again, religion in the negative sense. This is the way Karl Barth would use the term religion: He attacked the idea of religion and moral performance as the very enemies of Christianity and of Christ because they present the false idea that somehow we can reach God through our own moral efforts. This led to hubris and spiritual pride, the sworn enemies of Christianity. "Thus", Bonhoeffer said, "the Christian message is basically amoral and irreligious, paradoxical as that may sound." You've got to understand this must have been shocking if there were any parents of these high schoolers sitting there like, What? What are you talking about? I send my kids to church so that they'll behave better. He's hitting the stuff that through the end of his life, this stuff is important to him.
- 2.48 In the same lecture, he makes another bold, provocative statement. He says, "With that we've articulated a basic criticism of the most grandiose of all human attempts to advance toward the divine—by way of the church." Again, this is this idea that we can

lift ourselves up morally through our own moral efforts. He says no. Then he says, "Christianity conceals within itself a germ hostile to the church. It is far too easy for us to base our claims to God on our own Christian religiosity and our church commitment, and in doing so utterly to misunderstand and distort the Christian idea." I mean, he goes on to say you've got to really understand what the faith asks of you, and you've got to forget that that means—just be a good boy or a good girl, go to church, keep your nose clean. He's getting very, very clear about this stuff.

2.49 I should mention, at least in part, Martin Luther, because Martin Luther himself—now, again, Martin Luther is writing in the early 16th century. The Reformation is 1517 or so. Luther's basic idea is similar. The basic idea, by faith alone—what does it mean? It means that you've got to forget this idea—which is, again, and Bonhoeffer is criticizing it—it's everywhere in the church that it's about being a good person, it's about moral behavior, it's about climbing up the moral of ladder and becoming better and better and more and more holy. There's an element to that. But Bonhoeffer is saying, and Luther said, if you're climbing the ladder to reach God, you're not going to make it. The distance between you and God is infinite.

2.50 The first thing you need to understand is that the distance between you and God is infinite. The idea that you can get there on your own through moral effort is a joke. You can't. But that idea is very widespread. It's widespread today. Bonhoeffer clearly understood, yeah—that doesn't work. You have to accept Christ by faith, and only He can come to you. If you believe in Him, He will come to you. He will traverse the infinite distance between you and God. But if you don't think that distance is infinite, if you think somehow you can do it on your own, you're mistaken.

2.51 Of course, this idea comes from Luther. Luther sees this, of course, in the high medieval church. He sees that a lot of people are trying to do this, do that, pray harder, fast more, do all this stuff to work your way up. Luther makes it clear that ultimately you'll drive yourself insane if you try that, it won't work. Now, nobody tried it as hard as Luther did, so he was in a position to know what he he's talking about. He's basically saying this can't work. You'll kill yourself if you try, try, try, try, try. You have to accept God by faith. Luther says by faith alone. Now, the scripture doesn't say the word alone. He cheats and he puts it in there to underscore it. But that's a basic idea. Bonhoeffer is getting this idea that you really have to submit to God and you have to apprehend God by faith. You can't do it on your own. That's a very important idea, and it's an important idea to Luther.

2.52 The German Lutheran Church, to some extent, got that idea, but they took it too far. This is what Bonhoeffer gets to later on, where he's talking about this idea that if you say by faith alone, is it possible to take that too far? Is it possible to say it's by faith alone, it's by faith alone, which means I don't actually need to do anything. I don't need to care about my moral behavior. Bonhoeffer ends up writing about this and saying

that's bad. If you don't care about your moral behavior, there's all kinds of errors you can fall into.

- 2.53** One error is that I can climb the ladder of good moral behavior to God. That's wrong. The other idea is that I can't climb the ladder of moral behavior to God; therefore, I don't need to worry about my moral behavior. It's just by faith, as though faith could be separated from how you live. This is this paradox that if you're saved by faith alone—and again, this is a huge theme for Bonhoeffer—then your faith will be lived out. In other words, if you actually believe, if you have a saving faith in what Jesus did on the cross for you, if you apprehend that by faith, genuinely, it will be reflected in how you live. To say, I'm saved by faith; therefore, I don't need to do anything. I can just sin. I can do whatever I want. Bonhoeffer sees that idea has taken root in Lutheran Church. It might not be an open sin, but it is an omission.
- 2.54** In other words, when the Nazis are rising—and we'll get to this—many Lutheran theologians and pastors and churchgoers thought, "I don't need to stand against the Nazis. I don't need to do anything. I'm saved by faith." It's separate. Bonhoeffer often would criticize that as pietism, this idea that my faith is utterly separated from the world. As we said in that quote earlier, Bonhoeffer says, "You've got to live your faith in this world." It's not just some theological thing. It's not just some religious thing. You've got to bring your faith into this world.
- 2.55** There's another quote from some years later. He wrote this in a letter to his fiancée years later, but it sums this idea up, and I'll quote it. He says, "Our marriage"—he's talking to his fiancée at this point. He says, "Our marriage must be a 'yes' to God's earth. It must strengthen our resolve to do and accomplish something on earth." It's not just some pie in the sky, some idea. He says, this is the big quote, "I fear that Christians who venture to stand on earth on only one leg will stand in heaven on only one leg too." In another letter to his fiancée, he wrote that "Human beings were taken from the earth"—from the mud. Adam was made from the mud. He writes, "and they don't just consist of thin air and thoughts."
- 2.56** Again, you see this theme. Bonhoeffer sees that you can take Luther's idea, we're saved by faith, we're saved by faith, and it just becomes this intellectual ascent or this ascent to some intellectual theological ideas. Bonhoeffer says, "No, if you ascent to those things, you will now live them out in this world, in this broken, dirty world. You will live out your faith in this world. Your faith has to be lived out or you don't actually have faith." This becomes very big in 1933 and '34, as we will see.
- 2.57** But Bonhoeffer is already at this point lecturing high schoolers, and he's making these intellectual points that this is not about I believe I believe in this and this and this, so I'm a Christian. You've got to live it out. I find that so fascinating to me. Anybody who wants to say that Bonhoeffer evolved, all you need to do is read these lectures from 1928. He's 22 years old, and he is—and I'm just quoting a little bit; there's more in my book—he understands the Bible and the Christian faith dramatically well. I mean, it's

just astonishing to me, at age 22, he gets this. Again, he doesn't just get it. He gets it in a way that he can communicate it to high school kids. It's just so beautiful.

- 2.58** I think for now—in our next lecture, I'm going to talk—it's very exciting, at least I think it's exciting. He takes a trip to America, and that breaks things open for him. That really just kicks off everything that follows is his experience in New York City, where I live in America. It's kind of amazing. But I want to just make clear that all of this is set up here. This is all set up. So some idea that he goes to New York. I mean, yes, as we'll get to, he sees things that he hadn't seen before and something has deepened and changed, whatever. But all the intellectual ideas are already there.
- 2.59** This is not some dull theologian who suddenly finds God in the Black Church in Harlem in 1930. That's not right. You see just from these lectures that that's not true, that this guy gets it. He's wrestling with young people with these ideas and then communicating. Because I do think that one of the bad ideas about Bonhoeffer was that he was just this highfalutin academic who was theologically liberal, and he didn't believe in the Bible and whatever. You can see from this, that's simply not true. But anyway, we'll leave that for the next lecture.
- 2.60** I think for now, I'll just put a pin in it, and let's see if we can take some questions from this hostile audience. Let's see. Let's see.
- 2.61** Love these lectures. As you requested, I'll go way back to our previous lecture—question I had saved. You mentioned how his father didn't really agree with Freud, who was very popular at the time. I was wondering, are there any specifics, like any letters back and forth or a specific quote or anecdote that you had that you might like to share?
- 2.62** That is the easiest I've ever been asked. I'll answer it with one word: No. It's interesting. There may be, but I didn't come across anything like that. But this is what's so fascinating to me is that—who knows? I hope that scholars will discover that. I just didn't have the time or the breadth to look into that. But for sure, there has to be some evidence of this because he was such a towering figure in Germany from the last decade of the 19th century all the way through into the '40s. He's an intellectual giant, so there probably are letters.
- 2.63** But there was, I remember I had a quote in my book I didn't read it, but it was for sure people knew that—let's see. I'll read what I have. This is from the Bethge book. I'm quoting Karl Bonhoeffer's friend, Robert Gaupp, who was a psychiatrist in Heidelberg. This is what his colleague says. He says, "In intuitive psychology and scrupulous observation, Bonhoeffer"—the father—"had no superior. But he came from the school of Wernicke, which was solely concerned with the brain and permitted no departure from thinking in terms of cerebral pathology. He had no urge to advance into the realm of dark, undemonstrable, bold, and imaginative interpretation, where so much has to

be assumed and so little can be proved. He remained within the borders of the empirical world that was accessible to him."

- 2.64** Obviously, that is a kick toward Freud. When we're talking about "the dark, undemonstrable, bold" the model of the unconscious, how does anybody know there's anything to that? You can imagine—when you get the personality of Karl Bonhoeffer, what he have—he probably would have sneered almost audibly at Freud. Anyway, we'll leave it there. Thank you for that question.
- 2.65** At the beginning of the previous lecture, you mentioned the living faith, the idea of the living faith. And I have—throughout the past two lectures, I've heard you give examples of it, the joy of the missionaries of the Salvation Army, the universality of the Church during that Salvation Army event, the response of Dietrich's mom when Walter died and so on. I see the living faith as understanding that Christ is living in and with every single one of us through the Spirit. And so since he's here—not up there, not just observing—we want to act as if he's here, and we get joy from it and everything. But that's just the way I understand it. How would you define, practically, "the living faith?"
- 2.66** How would I define it? Well, I mean, who cares what I think? I'm here to talk about Bonhoeffer. But the good news is I agree with everything Bonhoeffer says. As I talk about Bonhoeffer, I would agree. Bonhoeffer, we'll talk about this more in subsequent lectures because this becomes very, very real as the Nazis are rising. But since we're only in lecture two, let me go back to in the first lecture, I talk about his family and his mother.
- 2.67** The mother, when they were little kids and their kids and all the way on into Dietrich's adulthood was always pushing them to live out their faith. She might not even have phrased it that way because a lot of times we all get religious and we talk about living out your faith. How about just doing what's right? How about behaving nobly versus ignobly? How about getting the door for somebody? How about asking someone if they need help? That was part of the culture of the Bonhoeffer family.
- 2.68** It was also part of the father's world. There was a dignity there. I think sometimes, and I'm sure Bonhoeffer kicked against this idea that it has to be couched in religious terms. Christians often do the faith a disservice by constantly talking in religious terms when it's just about reality. It's just about what's right. You don't need to be a sophisticated, mature Christian to understand that self-sacrifice is beautiful and noble and good. You don't need to be a sophisticated, devout Christian to know that there is right and wrong, that some people behave in a way that you say that is a man of character, that is a woman of integrity. You don't need to couch it in religious terms.
- 2.69** I think part of what Bonhoeffer gets to in his life is he starts realizing how by putting everything in religious terms, you shove it into this religious theological corner, which separates it from the real world. That's simply wrong. There's the quote that I quoted when he was in Barcelona talking about real people and somehow seeing in their lives

this dignity. He basically says, "I've gained the impression that it's just these people"—he's talking about real people—"who are under much more grace than under wrath, and that it is the Christian world which is much more under wrath than grace."

- 2.70** In other words, he sees the dignity of people's lives, and maybe some hidebound theological Christian would say, "Well, that person is not saved, or that person is not a Christian." Bonhoeffer didn't quite see it that way. He thought, and again—where does Bonhoeffer get these ideas?—from the New Testament, from Jesus—that don't judge by superficialities. You can talk about your faith and you can go through religious motions. God knows what's really going on. God looks at the heart. God looks at your life, and so do most people.
- 2.71** Bonhoeffer always felt that it's important simply to be honest and to be ethical. In a way, we're getting way ahead of ourselves. But at the end of his life, when he talks about religionless Christianity, he's getting at that—that we're constantly loading things down with this theological language when we're simply talking about reality. It's either right or wrong. It's either true or false. In his life, that begins in his family, his mother always creating a culture in the family of self-sacrifice, of doing the right thing. That was a big part of his family. Not everybody in his family, not all his siblings were people of faith. You get the impression maybe they weren't, but they still knew that's not the way to behave.
- 2.72** I think sometimes Christians are particularly guilty of this, of putting everything into this theological faith-language when it's simply an issue of what's the right thing to do? Why you do it is another story. But people know committing adultery is wrong. People know having no character, saying something and not doing it, that's wrong. That was part of the family culture, and it was part of the culture, I think, of that era and the world in which they lived. Many people in that world were not people of faith. We'll leave it there. Another question.
- 2.73** I'd like to preface with—this is my first time learning about Bonhoeffer, so I really didn't know what I was getting myself into. Really interesting. He was born in a context not just with his family, but also with the German culture, where in the 1800s, you would have characters like Hegel and the young Hegelians, which were extremely complex, not just in their thought, but also in their writings. This, when you mentioned his studies at Berlin University, it mirrors in a way how Jesus saw the Pharisees at their time, where if you want to understand God, you need to go and understand these complex ideas or systems. It just recalled to me what is said in Scripture and what Jesus used to say that, "Blessed are you, Father, for you hid it from the learned, but you revealed it to children." I also see Bonhoeffer, when you mentioned that he would love to explain this to kids and to younger people, that he would try to bring God to them in the sense that [inaudible].
- 2.74** Now, with that said, my question is the following. We've discussed a little bit about sola fide or the idea of just faith, right? In a way, we've also discussed sola gratia, but we

haven't gone into his ideas of scripture, or at least not as much as we have gotten into the other aspects. What was his take on scripture, specifically?

- 2.75** Bonhoeffer ends up—I don't want to answer this too much now because time and because I get into this in the next lecture and the next lecture and the next lecture. His view of the Bible changed. That is one of the things that changed. His view of Scripture became dramatically higher than I think it would have been early on at this point. I'll leave it at that. We have just a couple of the questions real quick before we move on.
- 2.76** In your first lecture, you mentioned the fraternity that he joined, and that was an anti-Semitic thing. He kind of went along with it, not understanding the dangers and where it led. It was just interesting to me to see where he stood in light of what is going on in America today, which is anti-Semitism that he experienced, on steroids. I think they're only prohibition back then was not to allow Jews into the fraternity.
- 2.77** You'll have to leap to the question.
- 2.78** Yeah. Do you have a reaction on—
- 2.79** I'll answer what I've heard so far. I don't think it's quite right to say that the Igel fraternity was anti-Semitic when he went there. That may have been a part of the backdrop of the culture. I know that in the '30s, that fraternity—this is long after Bonhoeffer left—they went along with something that he disapproved of with regard to the Jews. I think he and his brother took their names off or something like that. But I don't know enough about that. But we'll be getting into the anti-Semitism in subsequent lectures.
- 2.80** Thank you so much, Eric. I mean, at 14 years of age, he wants to reform the Church? What was in his mind, do you think, of the diagnosis, what the problem was that needed reform? Was it an absence of Jesus? Was it a Christlessness? Was it a correct view of like, okay, is it Christ in the Church and through the Church, and it's where the body of Christ is hands and feet? Thanks.
- 2.81** Yeah. It's so funny because you do have to ask yourself, what in the world does this 14-year-old—he knows enough to say that I will reform the church. I think partially, to be fair, he is smacking back at his brother. His brother is like, "Well, the church is a petty, bourgeois institution, blah, blah, blah." He just thinks, "Okay, well, if that's true, then I'll reform it. I'm not going to buy your view, but if there's any truth in that, then my job will be to reform it."
- 2.82** But I do think that, again, if you're raised in the Bonhoeffer family in this amazing environment, you are going to see the problems with the church. Why most Germans—I mean, look, you could say this today. Why is church totally irrelevant to so many people? Maybe because the church is actually irrelevant. I think Bonhoeffer saw that. He thought, you're going through the motions, there's all this religious stuff and the liturgy and whatever. But to most people, they're living their lives and they're thinking,

how does this speak to me? I don't know what the words you're using. I don't know. It just seems foreign and weird, and I'm not interested. I think he got that.

2.83 I think it's why, at age 18, he's teaching Sunday School and this Thursday Circle, or whatever, because he wanted to make it relevant. And he wanted people to understand, now this is extremely interesting, and this is vital. But somehow the church of his time—and you can say this of the church of almost any era, certainly the church of today—they don't get that. They speak in this religious language, and they don't know fundamentally how to communicate the heart of the faith to average people. Bonhoeffer, I think, saw that. Again, as we'll see in subsequent lectures, this is his passion for the rest of his life. Great way to end. Let's leave it there.

Lecture 3: Bonhoeffer in America

At a glance — Bonhoeffer in America.

- 3.1** Welcome to lecture three on Dietrich Bonhoeffer. If you're not signed up for this course, you need to get out. But please, if you're signed up, please stay. Thank you. This, to me—lecture three about Bonhoeffer in America—is fun and particularly exciting. I'm really psyched, I believe is the correct word to talk about Bonhoeffer in America.
- 3.2** But before I do that, I want to mention that someone had asked a question at the end of the last lecture about Bonhoeffer's attitude toward the Bible. I forgot to mention that while Bonhoeffer—before Bonhoeffer leaves for America in 1930—he becomes friends with someone named Franz Hildebrandt. Franz Hildebrandt is Bonhoeffer's absolute best friend until later on, Bonhoeffer becomes friends with Eberhard Bethge, whom I've mentioned.
- 3.3** Franz Hildebrandt is interesting for many reasons, one of which is that he is ethnically Jewish. Now, we're going to get into this concept later on. But there were so many Germans who were patriotic Germans, ethnically Jewish, who had at some point—their parents, their grandparents, their great-grandparents—converted to Christian faith. Franz Hildebrandt, not only is a Jew who is a Christian, who believes in Jesus, but also is in studying theology and in the ministry with Dietrich Bonhoeffer. So they become good friends.
- 3.4** They argued constantly, and I think that that was part of the humor of Bonhoeffer, that this constant arguing and jockeying because he had such a respect for truth that it wasn't about really arguing—it's about intellectual debate and clarifying things. But he and Hildebrandt, from the day they met, it was like a decade-long argument that they had.
- 3.5** But I bring up Hildebrandt because according to Eberhard Bethge, "Hildebrand and Bonhoeffer saw eye to eye" Bethge says, "in all practical matters." And Hildebrandt "influenced Bonhoeffer's imminent conversion to a stronger biblicism." Very interesting to think that in 1929, Bonhoeffer, again, this theologian, I think he got the gist of the Christian faith—there's no doubt about it—but that Hildebrand influenced him to a stronger biblicism, to taking the Bible more seriously, and you will see how that plays out in subsequent years.
- 3.6** In any event, so we're now in 1930, Bonhoeffer is, do the math, 24. He wants to be ordained as a pastor. He's done about as much as he can do academically. He can't get ordained until age 25. He's got a year to kill: "Hey, let's go to New York City." Let's go to America. Bonhoeffer's family, they were so culturally curious. They experienced everything. They traveled wildly. When Bonhoeffer was in Rome, he was there with his brother. When Bonhoeffer travels to Barcelona for the year, at age 22, his parents

come to visit him in Barcelona, Spain. They were constantly traveling. When they visited him in Barcelona, Spain, they all went on a journey, I think, up the Coast of France. They were constantly traveling and so on and so forth.

3.7 Bonhoeffer's elder brother, the physicist, Karl-Friedrich, has already gone to America to study. I think he was in Chicago, maybe at the Max Planck Institute. But in any case, he's doing physics in the United States. Bonhoeffer gets this idea, "Hey, I'd like to spend a year in America." At age 24, he sails across the ocean with the plan not just of hanging out, but he's going to study at Union Theological Seminary. There was a Sloan Fellowship. He decides, "Let me do that for nine months, so I'll be there." Of course, he would travel everywhere from New York, as we'll see, but he goes there for that.

3.8 Now, one of the things that I discovered, which I find funny is that Bonhoeffer doesn't know what he's going to find in New York. But Union Theological Seminary, ever since Bonhoeffer was there in 1930 and '31, they've hailed Bonhoeffer like this affiliation they have with Bonhoeffer. My research indicates that there are two sides to that story. Bonhoeffer was not even slightly impressed with Union. That's putting it positively. He was horrified by the sloppy theology that he found at Union Theological Seminary. This is 1930. Now, again, we have to remember, Bonhoeffer was not a theological liberal, but he respected his teacher Adolf von Harnack, who was. He respected selected theological liberals who did the necessary academic work, and he understood that.

3.9 In fact, I should say, before Bonhoeffer sails for New York, Harnack dies in 1929. So there's a special event, and Bonhoeffer, very young, is asked to be one of the speakers. And Eberhard Bethge says that, "Many were astonished at the breadth of vision and sympathy Bonhoeffer showed for his former teacher, since it was clear that his own path, theologically speaking, had taken a different direction." Bonhoeffer respected people with whom he disagreed. Again, this speaks to the Bonhoeffer family. They really took things seriously. And so they may end up disagreeing with you, but that didn't make you their enemies.

3.10 But now Bonhoeffer comes to New York and he encounters theological liberalism at Union, but he is not impressed. He is shocked because he saw the greatest theological liberal academics in Berlin for years, studied with them and under them. Now he comes to New York, and he's a little bit horrified, to put it bluntly. The funny thing is that unless you read—in my book, I quote his letters and his diaries at length—so you really meet Bonhoeffer the person. If you just read his theology or whatever, you don't meet Bonhoeffer the person. But in these letters to his friends and family and in his own diary, he's really honest and plain-spoken.

3.11 One of them, Bonhoeffer, so he goes to Union, and here's what he says in a letter to his parents: "The Union students talk a blue streak without the slightest substantive foundation and with no evidence of any criteria. They are unfamiliar with even the most basic questions. They become intoxicated with liberal and humanistic phrases,

laugh at the fundamentalists, and yet basically are not even up to their level." Bonhoeffer, again, he's a little bit scandalized by this. He's never seen anything like this. He's only been around the best of the best, let's put it that way.

- 3.12** One of Bonhoeffer's professors at Union reckoned Bonhoeffer— now, again, Bonhoeffer is 24 years old—but one of the professors at Union reckoned Bonhoeffer: "The most convinced disciple of Dr. Barth"—Karl Barth—"that had appeared among us up to that time, and with all, as stout an opponent of liberalism as had ever come my way." We have to be clear, Bonhoeffer is a stout and impressive opponent of theological liberalism. He goes to Union, and what he finds there is a little bit strange for him because he thought, "Well, at least I'll learn something. I'll go to America." But he just was not expecting to be so disappointed by the academic level at Union.
- 3.13** Again, he writes about it. I've quoted some of it already, but he writes about it at length. He writes about his fellow students. He says, "Without doubt, the most vigorous have turned their on all genuine theology and study many economic and political problems. Here, they feel is the renewal of the gospel for our time. At the instigation of this group, the Student Body of Union Theological Seminary, has over the winter, continually provided food and lodging for 30 unemployed, among them, three Germans, and has advised them as well as possible."
- 3.14** This is what we call the social gospel. They're doing good things. He says, "This has led to considerable personal sacrifice of time and money." He's praising them. They're doing good things. They're living out their faith. He says, "It must not, however, be left unmentioned that the theological education of this group is virtually nil, and the self-assurance, which lightly makes mock of any specifically theological question is unwarranted and naive." Again, he's just amazed because he's seen the best of theological liberalism in Bonhoeffer. Here, he's seeing very bad examples of it.
- 3.15** He says, "The lack of seriousness with which the students here speak of God is, to say the least, extremely surprising." The theological atmosphere—now this is 90 years ago and it's still happening like crazy at Union Theological Seminary in New York, but this is 90 plus years ago: "The theological atmosphere of the Union Theological Seminary is accelerating the process of the secularization"—the secularization—" of Christianity in America. Its criticism is directed essentially against the fundamentalists." There's more here, but he really is observing something. He's saying it's like they know they hate those jug-headed fundamentalists like H. L. Mencken and others and think, "Oh, those stupid rubes who believe in God and the Bible, whatever."
- 3.16** He sees this, but he doesn't see them providing the slightest intellectual argument against the fundamentalists. It's just a mockery and an ignorance. So this really shocks him. He finds the same thing happening at the upscale Protestant churches that he visits. He writes, "Things are not much different in the church. The sermon has been reduced to parenthetically church remarks about newspaper events." Sound familiar? "As long as I've been here in New York, I have heard only one sermon in which you

could hear something like a genuine proclamation of the Gospel, and that was delivered by a Negro. Indeed, in general, I'm increasingly discovering greater religious power and originality in Negroes."

- 3.17** Now, this brings us to the main point of what happens in New York City. Bonhoeffer, let's be clear, I don't think he's expecting to get much theologically even before he gets there. He's just thinking, "Listen, I got a doctorate from Berlin University. Now I'm pretty much going to a community college just to have a place to hang my hat while I get to visit New York and America." So he goes there and he's shocked. He goes to the churches; he's shocked. But what makes his time in America life-changing for him, what affects everything, is he meets an African-American. He befriends an African-American fellow student, Frank Fisher, who's from Alabama.
- 3.18** Frank Fisher grew up in Alabama. He's doing some work as a student at Union with a church. What church is that? It's Abyssinian Baptist Church in Harlem. It's there today, 138th Street. Bonhoeffer—again, being culturally very curious, says, I would love to visit Harlem. I mean, imagine you're a tow-headed German academic from Berlin and you get to visit Harlem in New York, wow. He goes up to Abyssinian Baptist Church, and is, to be blunt, blown away. He has never seen anything like what he sees in 1930 in this Black Church in Harlem.
- 3.19** He's so transformed because what does he see that he doesn't see in any of the white churches. He sees real faith, the thing that he keeps coming back to, real faith, the real thing. When he was 15 and he saw at the Salvation Army crusade, this evangelistic crusade, he sees the joy and these people coming to faith. It's this beautiful and he sees emotion. He wasn't seeing this in the Lutheran churches in Germany. He's definitely not seeing any of this studying theology. He's not seeing this in the white Protestant churches in New York, but he now goes to this Black Church in Harlem, and he just sees this profoundly, the worship we can imagine, amazing worship, real worship. People worshipping God with emotion as though God is really there. He's not just a social construct. This is not just hidebound theology. This is not religiosity. He finds it very, very moving.
- 3.20** The preacher at Abyssinian was this powerful figure named Dr. Adam Clayton Powell Sr., born in 1865, had a tremendous conversion experience. You can see photographs of Powell baptizing people. I'm not sure what river it is, but it's that Christianity. It's revival of Christianity. This church becomes, I think, the largest church in the United States of America at the time. Thousands of parishioners. Bonhoeffer gets to experience this, and he's so moved by what he sees. He says, "That's it. I'm going back here every Sunday."
- 3.21** He goes every Sunday to this church in Harlem. He teaches Sunday School. Again, he's not getting paid extra. He just wants to do this. He wants to teach young people at this Black Church in Harlem. So he gets very involved in the life of the church, and he gets involved in the life of the parishioners. Thinking about this—this is 1930—he gets

involved in the very beginnings of the civil rights movement. Because one of the things you see, if you live out your faith in every sphere, and again, this is what he always advocates. He advocates it later in life with the Nazis.

- 3.22** He sees it here: They're living their life out in every sphere. So they really believe God is real. They're worshipping. It's powerful. The preaching is powerful. Their lives are affected, but it affects their whole lives. So it also makes them politically active. So they're hanging flags out. When somebody is lynched in the South, they don't say, "Well, we don't do politics. We're just going to talk about Jesus." They think, "Oh, no. Actually talking about Jesus means I'm going to mention it. We're going to stand against lynchings in the South." And so he sees this full-throated Christianity, this three-dimensional Christianity in this extraordinary church, and he gets involved with those who are leaders in the civil rights movement in 1930.
- 3.23** He travels—now in the Bonhoeffer film, they show this—he travels to Washington, DC. And quoting from my book, Bonhoeffer says, "In Washington"—Washington, DC, which is like a Southern area at this point—"I lived completely among the Negroes, and through the students, was able to become acquainted with all the leading figures of the Negro movement"—so the budding civil rights movement—"was in their homes and had extraordinarily interesting discussions with them. The conditions are really rather unbelievable, not just separate railway cars, tramways, and busses south of Washington, but also, for example, when I wanted to eat in a small restaurant with a Negro, I was refused service." So he sees something that his brother had written to him about this. It really was shocking to him. It informed him going forward when he goes back from America to Berlin, he's thinking differently.
- 3.24** Now, this is actually extraordinary. His brother, Karl-Friedrich, this really hit him hard. His elder brother, this is the physicist. He was amazed by it. But this is a line that in retrospect, there's irony. It's painful to read. He says, "There was no analogous situation in Germany. We know what's coming with the Jews any minute." Bonhoeffer even ventures to say that our Jewish question is a joke by comparison. There won't be many people who claim they are oppressed.
- 3.25** Now, we have to think about this. This is basically true on one level, is that until the rise of the Nazis, there might have been anti-Semitism, I'm sure there was, but the Jews were fully assimilated. They had tremendous economic power. They had jobs all through the culture. Obviously, that is not the case among the Blacks in the United States. That fools Bonhoeffer into thinking that, how bad can it get in Germany? He's going to find out in about a year how bad it can get.
- 3.26** But he has really changed by his experience in Abyssinian Baptist Church. Something happens to him. Again, if you think about his theology from his lectures in 19—what did I say? 22, 23, 24. He's giving these lectures in Barcelona. He gets the faith. This is not somebody who doesn't get the faith, but something happens to him. It deepens now in

New York. Another thing that happens, he became friends with a few people. Another one was Jean Lasserre, who was a Frenchman.

3.27 Now, this is really important because imagine—Germany has been just devastated by the loss in World War I. Most Germans probably hate the French. Most people in Germany feel that the only problem is we lost the war, not that we shouldn't have been in the war. Bonhoeffer meets Jean Lasserre, and Jean Lasserre, who's a profound Christian, they form a friendship. When we get back to the idea of the Universal church—that Bonhoeffer sees it in Rome—that the church goes beyond the German Lutheran Church.

3.28 Now he meets all of these Black Christians in New York, and now he meets Jean Lasserre, a Frenchman who's a Christian. This is where he begins to make explicit this idea that this is my brother in Christ, and what I have with this Frenchman, Jean Lasserre, as a Christian, as my brother in Christ, transcends our national differences. Now, again, this doesn't mean that Bonhoeffer stands against nationalism. People want to demonize the idea of nationalism. But the idea of hypertrophied nationalism, the idea that Germany is the greatest thing ever, and let's go to war, and let's kill the French and let's take a—he knows, in part because of the way he was raised, and now in meeting Jean Lasserre, that that's wrong, and that we have to be very careful about what does it mean to be a proud German. It doesn't mean we're going to take over the world.

3.29 But when he meets Jean Lasserre, this becomes very real. They go to a film. The film came out in 1929, but he sees it in New York, *All Quiet on the Western Front*, which is based on the book by Erich Maria Remarque. It really shows the downside of, at least World War I, the downside of what it is to be so proud to be a German that you're happy to kill Frenchmen. His friendship with Jean Lasserre really spoke to this. When they saw the film together, it affected him so profoundly.

3.30 Now, Jean Lasserre was a confirmed pacifist. For a season, I think Bonhoeffer bought that idea. But we have to make very clear that our idea of pacifism today is remarkably different than Bonhoeffer's idea of pacifism. Why do I say that? Well, because the Germans were so nationalistic in going into World War I and fighting World War I, that I think anybody with common sense realizes that that was wrong, that that war was wrong. To say, I'm going to go to war just to expand the borders of Germany, to that extent, Bonhoeffer would say, "I would be a pacifist. I'm not in favor of picking up a gun."

3.31 But to cast him as a pacifist in the 1960s model of he'd be the third guy in the bed with John and Yoko—no, that doesn't follow. And a lot of Bonhoeffer scholars and people have tried to twist him into this '60s pacifist. It doesn't follow. I mean, there are many examples that I can give that are certainly in my book. I'm not going to get into it. But I think it's important to say that the main takeaway here for Bonhoeffer's friendship with Jean Lasserre is to realize that if you are a Christian, you are my brother or you're my

sister, and that connection is more important than any identification nationalistically as a German or as an American, that it's more important that our relationship in Christ. That really hit Bonhoeffer at the time.

- 3.32** Just parenthetically, I want to say that I already said that Bonhoeffer did a lot of traveling. The amount of traveling that he did when he was in America is almost funny. It's unbelievable. We mentioned that he drove down to Washington, DC. At some point, I don't remember the chronology, they decide—he and some friends decide to drive to Mexico from New York. They borrow a 1928 Oldsmobile, and they drive to Chicago, and then they drive south all the way through Laredo, Texas, into Mexico. He just was somebody who loved to experience absolutely everything.
- 3.33** Another parenthetical, within the parenthetical. A number of years ago, I think when I wrote my book, my father, who passed away this last year at 96 and a half, told me that someone in our Greek Orthodox Church in Danbury, Connecticut, had a father living who knew Bonhoeffer. I said, What? Are you kidding? That was the father— or this father, this man has passed away, but it's the Ern family, E-R-N.
- 3.34** When Bonhoeffer came over in 1930, on the ship, he met a family, the Ern family, and there was a 10 or 11-year-old boy on the ship, Bonhoeffer being Bonhoeffer befriends the boy and is talking to him and ends up visiting this family while he's at Union Theological Seminary that year. He drives up or he goes up to Westchester and is hanging out with this family. That 10-year-old boy, that 11-year-old boy, his son ended up going to the Greek Orthodox Church where my father was. You just start making these connections with people.
- 3.35** I say all this because it is our temptation to think of Bonhoeffer as a mythical figure. But I have met many people who knew him personally. There's something really moving, very moving, when you're talking to someone and you realize they knew him. My wife and I visited—I write about all of this in the long introduction to the new edition of the book. But my wife and I, in 2008, we visited Eberhard Bethge's widow. We also visited Bonhoeffer's fiancée's elder sister. You spend time with these people, and this elder sister remembers Bonhoeffer preaching. It's so moving to me that I've been in touch with someone whose father, as an 10 and 11-year-old boy, knew Bonhoeffer, this wonderful young man. It's powerful. When Bonhoeffer was in Mexico, he writes a postcard to this young friend Richard Ern. It's just moving to me. It's just moving to me, these personal connections.
- 3.36** I do think that we are always tempted to think of Bonhoeffer simply as a saint, but I want to be clear that Bonhoeffer himself would say to us, "Don't do that. If you see anything in me that's praiseworthy, you can do it, too." I think that that's a lot of times in talking about Bonhoeffer, people think—wow, he's this amazing human being, this amazing saint, like he exists in some pantheon. But I think the whole point of Bonhoeffer's life was to say, "No, this is the actual faith. I'm living faith, and you can do it, too." And by the way, it's beautiful. And to miss it is somehow sad.

- 3.37** He only spent one Easter in America. When he comes back in '39, that's in the summer for a month. He's only in New York, in America, once for Easter. It's 1931. He obviously hoped to attend an American church, one of these big deal white churches on Fifth Avenue or whatever. But he writes to his grandmother that it was impossible, "One had to get entry tickets for the larger churches far ahead of time." So these are people who all like we're going to go to church on Easter, of course. They probably didn't go to church most Sundays, but they're going to go.
- 3.38** So he says, "because I didn't know that, nothing remained—" He couldn't get in to a church on Easter. So he writes to his grandmother, "Because I didn't know that, nothing remained for me but to go hear a famous rabbi here who preaches every Sunday morning in the largest concert hall before a full audience." Carnegie Hall, Rabbi Stephen Wise, would preach. He's a rabbi, he's not a Christian; he's not a pastor; he's a rabbi. But the only Easter Sunday that Bonhoeffer ever spent in America, he goes to hear a rabbi preach. That obviously seems telling. It's very interesting to me that he experienced that.
- 3.39** Then Bonhoeffer sails back to Berlin. This is the summer of '31. He's had his experience. But I want to quote from my book about his time in America because a lot of people have commented on this. When he comes back from America to Berlin, I write, "Something had obviously happened to Bonhoeffer in the previous year and was happening still" when he comes back to Berlin in '31. "Some have gone so far as to call it a conversion, which it can hardly have been. To Bonhoeffer and to others close to him, however, it was evident that his faith had somehow deepened in the previous year. And it was obvious that his sense of himself as called by God was becoming clearer."
- 3.40** I just want to make clear that something happened. He writes about it later on, and I will quote that. In any event, so now he comes back to Berlin. It's 1931. He visits Karl Barth in Bonn. Again, he can never sit still. So as soon as he gets back to Berlin, boom, he gets on a train, goes to Bonn, and he gets to meet his hero, Karl Barth. He's hanging out with Barth. He goes to Barth's seminars. Somebody writes that at one of those seminars, a student quoted Luther's famous maxim that, "Sometimes the curses of the godless sound better than the hallelujahs of the pious." Barth, pleased with what he'd heard, asked who had said it. It was Bonhoeffer. This was likely the first time they met. They soon became friends.
- 3.41** Now, think of that concept. Luther said it, but Bonhoeffer is quoting it at a Barth seminar, the first day he meets Karl Barth. The curse—"Sometimes the curses of the godless sound better than the hallelujahs of the pious." Again, this underscores this idea that religiosity can be ugly and that sometimes the reality, I mean—he says Luther being Luther, of course, puts it as bluntly as he can put it—but that the curses of the godless, what he's saying is that somebody just cursing with passion about something they feel is right or wrong or whatever.

- 3.42 Sometimes, Luther says, that can more honest and more beautiful and more true than "the hallelujahs of the pious." That's a theme that you see throughout Bonhoeffer's life. It leads us to religionless Christianity. But he's always suspicious of religiosity, that it can be just a fig leaf trying to fool God. And that honesty, even from somebody who is godless, somehow that's closer to the heart of God. But I just find it interesting that Bonhoeffer is quoting Luther to Karl Barth.
- 3.43 Okay, so Bonhoeffer comes back to Berlin, 1931. The Nazis have gained tremendous power in the Reichstag. The Reichstag is the German Parliament. We referred earlier to the Weimar Republic. They have this parliament. They have all these different parties. The Nazis are a fringe party. We now know of insane lunatics—that's redundant—of lunatics. But while Bonhoeffer was in New York, they leapt to much greater power. They hadn't quite got enough power to take Germany over, but it was significant, and Bonhoeffer could see it. He could feel it.
- 3.44 The Nazis are rising. Again, we have to go back. The Versailles Treaty, the loss of World War I was devastating to Germany. The Versailles Treaty, the Allies really, really foolishly decided we're going to use this opportunity of victory to crush Germany. They made things so bad that Germans were desperate enough to turn to the maniac we know as Adolf Hitler, who, of course, and we've got to be clear, he's not exactly advertising everything he believes. He's not saying everything that we now know he believes because he's a great politician. He's not going to advertise like, "Oh, I'm working for Satan. Follow me." No, he's going to use God language.
- 3.45 In fact, it's funny. There's a good documentary about Bonhoeffer that came out about 20 years ago. It shows Hitler— by the way, I recommend that documentary—it shows Hitler unabashedly using religious language. Now, doesn't this tie into this Bonhoeffer theme? That here you have Hitler knowing that if he talks about if God is with us, he would say that knowing that most Germans are some kind of Christians, but they're also not theologically sophisticated enough to figure out this is talk, he's not, you know. Bonhoeffer smells this, and he was aware that Germany was in trouble, that what was coming was not at all good.
- 3.46 Right before Hitler comes to power, to get the chronology, so Bonhoeffer comes back from Germany in '31, his friends can see something is different in him. He wrote his friend Erwin Sutz. Now, this is another one of the friends that he made in New York. He said, "Having arrived in Germany now, the outlook here is really exceptionally grim." He felt they were standing at a tremendous turning point in world history, that something was about to happen. Bonhoeffer, in his prescient way, somehow sensed that whatever lay ahead the church would be threatened. He wondered if it would survive at all.
- 3.47 Now, this is, again, where I speak of him as a prophetic figure. My book's titled Bonhoeffer: Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy. The prophetic element starts to come in here. How is it that he has a sense of this? I mean, yeah, his brilliance and all else plays into it, but he has a sense. He wondered if the church would survive what lay ahead.

Then he says, "Then what's the use of everyone's theology?" That's amazing to me that he realizes that we've got all this theology. And he's basically saying if you cannot stand against this evil, who cares what you claim to believe? It's just meaningless.

3.48 So he begins to speak out. The Nazis don't take power. Hitler becomes Chancellor January 30th of 1933. Two months before that on Reformation Day, which, of course, is a powerful day in Germany. This is the day they celebrate Martin Luther, November 1st, 1932. And Bonhoeffer is asked to preach at a very famous church that day, the Kaiser Wilhelm Memorial Church. If you visit it today, you'll see it's no longer there. If you look very carefully, you'll see it's not there. It was bombed in 1944. That's a whole story.

3.49 But he's asked to preach on Reformation Sunday. Now, let's think about this. This would be like being asked to preach in a red state on July 4th. Surely you're going to say something celebrating America or whatever. To be asked to preach on a Reformation Sunday at this church, this big fancy church in Berlin— this is to celebrate Luther, to celebrate German Lutheranism. Well, Bonhoeffer, being the prophet, he does exactly the opposite.

3.50 The texts that he chose, the first one was Revelation 2:4-5, " Nevertheless, I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love. Remember therefore from whence thou art fallen and repent, and do the first works, or else I will come unto thee quickly, and will remove thy candlestick out of its place, except thou repent." So anybody paying attention is like, "Uh-oh, what a sermon are we going to get?" It doesn't seem like it's going to be too much fun celebrating German Lutheranism. So Bonhoeffer goes right to it. And again, speaking like a prophet, he says, "The Protestant Church is in its 11th hour, and it's high time we realize this."

3.51 "The German church" he said, "is dying or is already dead." Then he starts kind of attacking the congregation. Again, think how young he is. What year is this? '32. He's a kid. What is he— 26 years old, this brilliant pastor, preacher, theologian? But he basically says that if the church is dying, and he's being honest about this. He says, "The fanfare of trumpets is no comfort to a dying man." In other words, who are we kidding? Whom are we kidding? Whom are we kidding? We're celebrating—he's saying what everybody ought to know.

3.52 The German church in many ways has become irrelevant to your average German, and he doesn't quite say it, but the Nazis are rising. They are really offering an idol to worship. When we talk about nationalism, again, everybody, we get worried about nationalism. Nationalism on the model of George Washington or Abraham Lincoln, to be proud to be an American the way they were proud is a beautiful thing. Nationalism on the model of Adolf Hitler is a vile and wicked thing. Bonhoeffer sees that Hitler is going to use this German woundedness over their loss of power in World War I and the pain of the Weimar Republic. He's going to use this and he's going to play to their patriotic instincts and ride this all the way into hell.

- 3.53** Bonhoeffer is trying to say to the church: We need to wake up. We're going to a precipice. We, the church, are not being relevant. We're not speaking God's truth. We're just playing church. The Nazis are offering this compelling alternative vision, and it is powerfully tempting to want to go in that direction. In fact, most people would be tempted in that direction until you knew the reality of it.
- 3.54** I think I mentioned at the beginning of the first course, the first lecture, that my grandfather and grandmother and most of our relatives did not like Hitler and the Nazis. I don't know what they would have thought in 1933 if they would have picked up on it so early, but they could see these are bad people. A lot of Germans could, but in 1933, I would say most could not. Bonhoeffer could and his family could, and they think we're in a real spot here. So he realizes that if I can wake up the church, if I can get the church to be the church, the church is the only thing that can stand against this wickedness. He knew that to be true.
- 3.55** He knew the cultural power of the church in Germany was significant. If he could get the church to acknowledge what its real job is, and again, this comes back to the question from the beginning—what is the church? Bonhoeffer asked the question in his dissertation at age 21—what is the church? What is the role of the church? Bonhoeffer now is actually living this out. In this sermon, two months before Hitler comes to power, he is delivering this very strong message. Again, only Dietrich Bonhoeffer would have the confidence—what 26-year-old, unless they're simply being immature and foolish, but he was not. He had this confidence to say what he knew was right. It was harsh, but something had happened to him in his life that he felt he could say these things. He was a different person.
- 3.56** Now, in 1936, remember I mentioned that he had this woman in his life, Elizabeth Zinn. In 1936, so a few years later, looking back, he says, "Something happened, something that changed and transformed my life to the present day. For the first time, I discovered the Bible." So again, we get a little bit of this maybe from Franz Hildebrandt, his friend who pushes him toward a stronger biblicism. And then his time in the Black Church in Harlem, something has changed. He's a different Christian. He's reading the Bible. He gets it.
- 3.57** He writes—again, he's writing in 1936, but it's appropriate to where we are now in 1933. He says in this letter to Elizabeth Zinn, "I had often preached. I'd seen a great deal of the church and talked and preached about it— but I had not yet become a Christian." I think he's overstating things there. I think he was a Christian, but he realized something happened in New York.
- 3.58** He writes, "I know that at that time I turned"—that before this—he had" turned the doctrine of Jesus Christ into something of personal advantage for myself. Also, I had never prayed or prayed only very little. For all my loneliness, I was quite pleased with myself. Then the Bible, and in particular, the Sermon on the Mount, freed me from that." Now, I think that comes from Jean Lasserre, the Frenchman whom he befriended

in New York—this obsession with the Sermon on the Mount. He was really challenged. Do you believe this, Dietrich? Read these words of Jesus. Can you live like this?

- 3.59** So he writes, "Since then, everything has changed. I have felt this plainly, so have other people about me. It was a great liberation. It became clear to me that the life of a servant of Jesus Christ must belong to the church. And step by step, it became plainer to me how far that must go. Then came the crisis of 1933." The crisis of 1933 is the rise of Hitler. He's writing this letter in '36. But in '33, it's just extraordinary, the lightning speed. He gives this sermon two months before Hitler comes to power, warning the church. In 1933, January 30th, Hitler actually comes to power.
- 3.60** Bonhoeffer, just to finish this letter, he says, "The crisis of '33 strengthened me in my faith. I also now found others who shared that aim with me. The revival of the Church and of the ministry became my supreme concern"—to get the church to be the church. "My calling is quite clear to me. What God will make of it, I do not know. I must follow the path." So again, he's writing this in '36. He says, "Perhaps it will not be such a long one." And he quotes Philippians 1:23. That's where—to be with the Lord. In other words, he's considering he may die in this calling to serve God. That's in 1936. He says, "But it is a fine thing to have realized my calling. I believe its nobility will become plain to us only in coming times and events if only we can hold out."
- 3.61** It's just an amazing thing that he's writing about this period, 1933. Something happens to him. He realizes his role is to wake up the church, and he's absolutely unafraid. You pick this up. Now, Bonhoeffer had a small group around him. He's teaching these young people. One of them, a woman, Inge Karding, writes, Bonhoeffer said, "When you read the Bible"—so this is the new Bonhoeffer— "When you read the Bible, you must think that here and now God is speaking with me. He wasn't as abstract as the Greek teachers and all the others. Rather, from the very beginning, he taught us that we had to read the Bible as it was directed at us, as the Word of God directly to us. Not something general, not something generally applicable, but rather with a personal relationship to us. He repeated this to us very early on that the whole thing comes from that."
- 3.62** Another of his students, Joachim Kanitz, says, Bonhoeffer told them "they shouldn't forget that every word of Holy Scripture was a quite personal message of God's love for us." Then he says, "Bonhoeffer then asked us whether we loved Jesus." This is a very different Bonhoeffer than the theologian. It's extraordinary to me how different he is to talk about something like that. You're hanging around with these Black Christians in New York City, you're going to hear stuff like this. Something changed in him to talk about, "Do you love Jesus?" This is a new level for him. Again, I think that that existed in his mother's world and then the governesses that were around him, the Herrnhuter, the Moravians, the Zinzendorff acolytes. But suddenly this becomes real for him. He's 25, 26, 27 at this point.

- 3.63** Bonhoeffer, right before Hitler takes power, that year that he's there—1931, '32, whatever—he gets involved with a bunch of working class kids in a suburb of Berlin called Wedding. It's spelled like the word "wedding." But these are like juvenile delinquents, basically. These are like very troubled kids. Bonhoeffer decides to teach this Confirmation class, and I don't have time to get into it right now. But all I can say is it's just another example of what an extraordinary person he was because—to say that these kids, these are 13, 14-year-old, most of them, real troublemakers from bad homes who were not slightly interested in what they had to hear in this Confirmation class—Bonhoeffer, by the strength of his personality, his charm, his love, he won them over.
- 3.64** It's one of the most moving passages for me in his life, and obviously, I deal with it in the book. But it's just so beautiful that you see this over and over in his life, these examples of him living out his faith. Anyway, well, before we get to the ascension of that monster known as Adolf Hitler, I think we'll stop there for this lecture and we'll take a few of your questions.
- 3.65** Regarding when Bonhoeffer gave the speech, when he was asked, "Hey, can you present a speech on Reformation Day?" Do you think he was thinking because he had gotten a little more biblical, so to speak, do you think he was thinking similarly to when—I'm a terrible Christian. I don't remember the words or anything— but when Jesus was asked to denounce the Roman rule and He simply said something like, "Give to Caesar what is Caesar's; give to God what is God's." Because when you were talking about that—I don't know anything about this guy, but it just it reminded me of that. Are there any ties to that theologically?
- 3.66** It's a little complicated. First of all, just to clarify, of course, it wasn't a speech, it was a sermon. The only reason I say that is because Bonhoeffer, he's very much preaching sermon. Again, not from a pulpit like this, but from an ornate pulpit in this gorgeous church. He realizes that, and he took it very seriously that he's preaching a sermon. This is the Word of God. This is God speaking through the preacher to the congregation. He took that very seriously, that you're supposed to hear from God. I'm a speaker, but I want to say what God has to say.
- 3.67** There's a lot to the idea that he is warning the church. He doesn't get too specific because, again, it's a sermon. But the implications are clear that something is happening in Germany, and we're pretending like everything's great. Everything's fine. It's Reformation Day. Hurrah for us! Hey, we brought the world Martin Luther! We brought the world Protestantism! We're great! He's saying—no, shame on you even for thinking that. By the way, and he makes this point, I think I quote it, that Luther himself would call you hypocrites. Here you are celebrating Luther. Whom are you kidding? Luther would see that the German Church of 1932 was not the German Church of 1540.
- 3.68** It really had become this religious version of itself where we get dressed up and we go to church on Reformation Day or we go through the motions. There may be some

people who are real believers, but as an institution, it's not doing what it's called to do. So again, that's his question: What is the church? And he's saying, this isn't it. This is just a ritual. This is just religiosity. Again, you can only push that so far. There comes a time when there's a crisis, and then at that point, the church has to stand up and be the church. You realize that that happens at certain times in history, you can imagine that Bonhoeffer realizes that we've been skating along here.

- 3.69** Now we come to a crisis. Isn't this what prophets do? Again, my book's titled Bonhoeffer: Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy. He's now behaving like a prophet. He's calling the people of God to be the people of God. What do the Old Testament prophets do? They call the people of God to actually be the people of God. Stop pretending. Stop saying that's who we are, but you're not behaving that way. To some extent, this is a really bold example of that for Bonhoeffer. There's a lot to be unpacked. You can find actually these whole sermons. I quote a lot of it here, but you can find the whole sermon. It's a barn burner. Yes, sir.
- 3.70** Don't you think it would be problematic for Bonhoeffer to reference Luther in terms of anti-Semitism?
- 3.71** Don't I think it would be problematic for Bonhoeffer to reference Luther in terms of anti-Semitism? Absolutely not because, and I know that I cover it in my book, Bonhoeffer and most Lutherans at the time, including extremely educated Lutherans like Bonhoeffer, were mostly unaware of what Luther had written against the Jews. We are only aware because the Nazis scoured the writings of Luther, and Luther's writings are volumes and volumes and volumes.
- 3.72** They found what Luther, late in life, had written against the Jews. I actually deal with that in the book. Earlier in life, Luther was very positive toward the Jews, dramatically positive toward the Jews. At the end of his life, he said unbelievably vile things. But the Nazis, cynical as they were, as if they actually cared what Luther thought, they found the worst things that he said and used it like crazy to convince Germans that if you want to be a good German, a good Lutheran, this is the view you should have.
- 3.73** So Bonhoeffer, in 1932, would not have been aware, and most Germans would not have been aware. It was Goebbels and the Nazi propaganda machine that said, hey, did you see this pamphlet? See what Luther said here? In 1543, three years before he died, I think we can make something of this. So it's really sick what the Nazis did. They took this stuff, bad as it is, but they made it sound like this is the official Lutheran view of the Jews, and it's at least more complicated than that.
- 3.74** I mean, I wrote a whole biography on Martin Luther where I deal with this in-depth. But I do deal with it in the Bonhoeffer book that even Bonhoeffer and his best friend, Eberhard Bethge, they were unaware of what Luther had said about that. In other words, it wasn't widely known at this time. The Nazis found it and thought, We'll use it. And of course, they did.

- 3.75** Eric, something, as you said, took place in Bonhoeffer's life that clarified his calling in New York? Something like it seems combustible that took place. Was it the gospel? Was it the Church confronting, bringing the truth of the gospel, the truth of Scriptures, confronting racism, and that is like, wow. I mean, that is faith in action. Did that help clarify his calling? Do you see?
- 3.76** Yes, I think that's right, and I meant to make that clear, so I'm grateful for the question. The racism that Bonhoeffer saw in America stunned him, and it woke him up. I mean, it woke him up in many ways. First of all, as I said, he saw faith in action in the Abyssinian Church, in the Black churches. He thought, first of all, they took the Bible really seriously. They preached on the cross, they preached on repentance, all the stuff that you would expect. They did that. The mainline Protestant churches, at least the upscale white churches in Manhattan, did not. They had adopted the liberal line that he sees at Union Theological Seminary and at Riverside Baptist Church, one of the worst examples of it, which I will come to in a subsequent lecture when we get to 1939.
- 3.77** But Bonhoeffer saw that in the Black Church, he saw the whole package. He saw them worshiping God with emotion, and it was not just religiosity. But then he saw them taking the themes of the Bible and the themes of the gospel seriously. The idea that we are all sinners. We all need God. We all need to repent. No, we're not wonderful, and we're just trying to burnish things to make ourselves a little bit better. He really saw that.
- 3.78** Actually, he talked about, I didn't mention this earlier, but that one of the things that shocked him at Union was he says that at Union, they didn't deal with any of that. I wonder if I can find the quote because it's so shocking when he says that the classes that they taught, they didn't deal with the cross, the atonement, forgiveness, whatever, not even slightly. He was a little bit blown away by that. So, yeah, he experiences it for the first time in the Black Church.
- 3.79** I think maybe I said this earlier. He's writing home and he says, "In New York, they preach about virtually everything. Only one thing is not addressed or is addressed so rarely that I have as yet been unable to hear it, namely the gospel of Jesus Christ, the cross, sin and forgiveness, death and life." He couldn't believe it. He says in the homiletics seminar at Union—now, that's in the churches—but then at Union, there was a homiletic seminar. So this is—they are teaching these seminarians to preach. And it was taught by Fosdick.
- 3.80** Now, I deal with him in the book. He was the arch anti-fundamentalist he gave out sermon topics, and a few of them are on what Fosdick condescendingly called traditional themes. And what were those? The forgiveness of sins on the cross. So Bonhoeffer just could not really believe how bad things were. Anyway, it goes on. I quote it. But there's no doubt that it all comes together for him.

- 3.81** He sees the real faith in the Black Church. He sees faith in action. They're not just preaching on the right stuff. They're not living it out and just taking the Bible seriously, but then they live it out in the community. They are feeding the poor. They're doing all the stuff that the theological liberals are doing, but they know why, and they're doing it for the right reasons, and they're not pretending that that's all they need to do. They need to have a personal relationship with Jesus. They get all that in the Black churches.
- 3.82** But of course, the issue of the plight of the Negroes, as Bonhoeffer called them, that was very heavy for him, and I didn't mention it earlier, so I should now. They wanted him to go back to Germany to tell the world about their plight, "Look at how we're being treated and how wrong this is." This became a thing for him. Obviously, when he sees the Jews being vilified and demonized, he thinks, "Oh, my goodness, here it is happening in my own country." It's a mixture of things that led him to this kind of conversion.
- 3.83** Again, it's not like he was rejecting it and then suddenly he accepts it, but something happens where it all comes together, and you definitely see a different Bonhoeffer. By 1932, he is pretty different from the Bonhoeffer of 1930. His friends saw it, and that only deepened. But the prophetic calling on his life, that's what happened. You could see it happening in '31, '32, '33. It just takes off from there. All right. Well, when we come back for lecture four, we'll talk about the rise of Adolf Hitler and what Bonhoeffer did in reaction. It's pretty powerful stuff. Thanks.

Lecture 4: A Call to Action

At a glance — A call to action.

- 4.1 Welcome to lecture number four. The title of the class is the same title as my book, Bonhoeffer: Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy. We'll keep talking about him as a pastor. Obviously, he doesn't become a martyr until the end. We've talked a little bit about the prophetic aspect of his life, and we're going to be getting into shortly where he becomes a spy. Not yet in this lecture. Most of you know the midterm is coming up. Look to your left; look to your right. One of you will not be here when this midterm is over. I want to be clear, spelling counts, penmanship counts. If you're not here in lecture number five, that's on you, okay? But the midterm is coming up. If you're watching at home, perhaps this does not include you, but it might. I want you to be prepared. Listen carefully.
- 4.2 All right, we're going to start now. Things get exciting right now because this is the culmination. We keep talking about Bonhoeffer asking the question: What does it mean to be a person of Christian faith? What does it actually mean? He's boldly asking the question and boldly answering the question. At the heart of his answer is the idea that faith is not simply believing in some intellectual ideas or theological ideas saying, "Yes, I believe Jesus rose bodily from the grave." Check. "Yes, I believe the Bible is the word of God." Check, check, check.
- 4.3 It's like, yeah, you need to believe that stuff, but you must live it out. If you don't live it out, it proves you don't actually believe it. So actual faith is different from this Enlightenment rationalist construct. I believe, in these ideas. At the heart of it is the idea of faith in action. Bonhoeffer talks about faith in action. You need to understand what you believe, and then you need to live it out. If you don't live it out, it means you don't believe it. That's at the heart of it. I bring it up now at the beginning of lecture number four because this is where the rubber hits the fan. Is that the right phrase? I'm just asking. Help me.
- 4.4 This is where the rubber meets the road because what happens now, this is January 30th, 1933, Hitler comes to power. Before this, Bonhoeffer and his family could see Hitler is probably coming to power. There's this feeling in Germany, the wound of the loss of World War I and the crushing conditions of the Versailles Treaty have all culminated in Germany, turning its lonely eyes, not to Joe DiMaggio, but to Adolf Hitler.
- 4.5 And so what does this mean? Well, it means a lot of things. But let me say up front, the Bonhoeffer family—we talked about this particularly, I think, in the first lecture—it was such an extraordinary family. They were so connected in Berlin to elites. They actually knew what was going on and had their finger on the pulse of what's happening in Germany, finger on the pulse of who the Nazis really are in a way that most Germans could not possibly.

- 4.6 One of the reasons is because they were so elite. Everyone in the family had these big jobs. Bonhoeffer's sister, Christine, is married to Hans von Dohnanyi, who has a big job in the in the German government. They're all keyed into what's actually going on. Also, they live in Berlin. Berlin was the headquarters of the Nazis in many ways. They can see what's happening better than most other Germans by far. They know what's happening.
- 4.7 Now it happens. January 30th, Hitler is elected. There's an irony there. You can elect a maniac, you can elect an enemy of a democracy, you can vote, and then you don't get to vote anymore. It's over. Basically, Hitler becomes the democratically elected Chancellor of Germany, January 30th, 1933. Two days later, Dietrich Bonhoeffer gives a speech, a lecture, a radio address at the Potsdamer Strasse radio station.
- 4.8 Now, in the past, and in my book, I tried over and over and over again to correct these myths. I do it also in my Martin Luther biography. There are these myths that are out there. They sound good, but they're not quite right. So the myth is like: Bonhoeffer, two days after Hitler, gets on the radio and speaks against Hitler. That's not quite right. It's sort of right, but it's not quite right because this lecture was scheduled long before they knew the two days before Hitler would come to power.
- 4.9 The concepts Bonhoeffer is writing about are still valid. They're what is leading the Nazis to take power. Bonhoeffer gives a speech. When I say a speech, I really—I'm sorry—an address. Now, Bonhoeffer was very, how do we put this? Unemotional? In some ways, he is the precise opposite of Adolf Hitler because he doesn't want to use his personality and emotion to get people excited because you can fool people with your personality and with emotion. If you want to lead people along emotional lines, you can lead them into hysteria and freaking out on TikTok. Anything can happen.
- 4.10 Bonhoeffer was about the facts. He was about evidence. He's laying out in this radio address, in a very clinical way, his argument. So okay, what was his radio address about two days after Hitler comes to power? It was called The Younger Generation's Altered Concept of Leadership. Sounds boring, but it's not. The German word "leader" is Führer. The word Führer means "leader."
- 4.11 We just need a little historical context. Germany had had a leader. It was the Kaiser. They had a monarch. They looked up to him. He embodies the nation. When you have a monarch, that's the way it goes. He's forced to abdicate, we mentioned this at the end of the war. The Allies say, no more monarchy—now you're going to have democracy in Germany. So Germany was like, now what? We want a leader. We had a leader. We had a king, we had a monarch. So Hitler plays on this. Also, there was this idea in Germany, I guess early in the 20th century, certainly through the '20s, this idea of the Führer, the leader.
- 4.12 Now, it's a little vague, but the point is Bonhoeffer being philosophically brilliant, he dissects it. He dissects this concept of the Führer, we need a leader. He's asking the

question, "What do you mean we need a leader? What kind of a leader? A good leader or just a leader?" It's almost like the idea of the Führer principle is like, "We want a leader who leads. We want leadership." It's like well, you're going to get that. His name is Adolf Hitler. You want a leader who leads, you're going to get that. He's evil, satanically evil, but he's going to lead. Don't worry about that. He's not going to dither. He's very decisive.

- 4.13** Bonhoeffer in the speech, in a clinical way, is trying to explain what is legitimate leadership. What he talks about in a nutshell is legitimate leadership derives its authority from God. In other words, God is the ultimate arbiter of what is true and good and beautiful. Any legitimate leader, a father, an elected official, a mother, they derive their leadership from above. In other words, they don't just say, "I said it and you need to do it." Even if they do say that, their ability to say that comes from them buying into the idea that they are themselves under the authority of God or of some overarching order, that they are submitted to a leadership above them, and that gives them authority over those below them.
- 4.14** Hitler's idea of leadership and the idea of the Führer principle was the opposite of that. It was a cult of leadership. It's like you don't question the leader. The leader is really making an idol of himself. An idol, it's like, "Look at me, look at me. I'm the leader. You want to worship me." It has this cultic aspect. Bonhoeffer, in a very clinical way on this radio address, is talking about why this is wrong. He says that kind of a leader becomes an idol and a "misleader." This leader is going to mislead you. So he delivers this. Now, the speech was cut off before he was done. And again, all these myths say, "Oh, probably the Nazis shut it down or whatever." That's possible, but we have no idea if that's true. It may have just been a mistake. He ran out of time. The bottom line is we don't know.
- 4.15** But Bonhoeffer, two days after Hitler takes power and becomes the Führer, the leader, is on the air giving a speech about how that leader is actually a misleader, and that's a fundamentally mistaken and dangerous view of leadership. The same day, so two days after Hitler takes power, the same day Bonhoeffer gives his radio address, Adolf Hitler —do I have to clarify when I say Hitler? We're talking Adolf Hitler. He himself gives a speech.
- 4.16** In his speech, now, listen to this, Hitler says, "We are determined as leaders of the nation to fulfill as a national government the task which has been given to us, swearing fidelity only to God, our conscience, and our Volk." The "Volk" is the people. Hitler then declared that his government would make Christianity, "The basis of our collective morality." Then Hitler closes by saying, "May God Almighty take our work into his grace, give true form to our will, bless our insight, and endow us with the trust of our Volk."
- 4.17** All right, you can probably guess, some of you already know, even though you haven't taken these lectures before, Hitler is a bad guy. He lies. He's evil. So there's nothing

sicker than him talking about God. He couldn't care less about God. And we'll get into that, what he actually thought about God and Christian faith and whatever. His views of it could not be lower. But you understand, he's the ultimate deceiver. He's a liar. He's evil. He will say literally anything to get more power. You have to be clear, in 1933, when Hitler takes power, he doesn't have a lot of power—yet.

- 4.18** He's going to use the power he now has to get more power and more power and more power. He's going to lie, and he's going to use events, as we'll see in a moment, to get more power. If it means talking about God, talking about Christianity is going to be the basis of our collective of morality. He'll say that. He doesn't mean it. He means the opposite of it. He's the enemy, as you'll see, the enemy of Christian faith and of Christians. But if he can get a little more power with the German people, he's going to take it. So he's using religious language. There's just nothing sicker, really, than Adolf Hitler talking like this, especially when you find out what he really believed. But most Germans, again, the overwhelming majority of Germans had no clue who Hitler was. The Bonhoeffer family pretty much did.
- 4.19** I say that this is two days after Hitler takes power, Bonhoeffer gives this radio address, Hitler gives this speech. The battle now between Hitler and the church in Germany has begun. It's out in the open. Hitler has power. Four weeks after Hitler takes power, Bonhoeffer preaches at the Trinity Church in Berlin. It was the first time he'd preached since Hitler came to power. He is right out of the gate speaking directly to the situation. He's not saying, "We just want to do church. We don't want to be political. We don't want to lose our big tithers in the audience. Yeah, they're good people who disagree. I'm just going to keep my mouth shut on politics."
- 4.20** Bonhoeffer understands that it is the role of the man of God to speak truth. If truth becomes political, so be it. The issue of slavery was a political issue. Are you going to be a Christian and say—well, we don't take a position on slavery in this church? Preposterous, right? Bonhoeffer gets that. In this sermon, four weeks after Hitler takes power, he goes right to it and he says, "The church has only one altar, the altar of the Almighty, before which all creatures must kneel. Whoever seeks something other than this must keep away. He cannot join us in the house of God. The church has only one pulpit, and from that pulpit, faith in God will be preached, and no other faith, and no other will than the will of God, however well-intended."
- 4.21** He's really drawing some sharp lines here because you can feel, four weeks after Hitler takes power, that people are just going along. National socialism is going to pull them out of their malaise out of their difficult time, whatever, and they're looking to this leader. Now, some of us are old enough to remember the malaise of Jimmy Carter and the election of Ronald Reagan. It's human to put hope in a leader and to say that he's going to lead us out of this. But if the leader is not Ronald Reagan, if it's Adolf Hitler, be careful. Now, again, people at the time didn't know that.

- 4.22 How much faith you put in a leader—is that leader going to lead in the way that Bonhoeffer talks about genuine leadership? There's nothing wrong with strong leadership. There's nothing wrong with a leader inspiring people that I'm going to take you out of this slough of despond, this abyss. There's nothing wrong with that. But you have a responsibility to try to figure out—is this leader just saying that? Is this leader wanting people to worship him? Is he really leading us in the way that God would want us to be led? What's going on here?
- 4.23 So Bonhoeffer, right out of the gate, he can smell where this is going, that the German people are bowing to this idol of Adolf Hitler, and he talks about it. Now, I just have to frame things that Bonhoeffer has a sense of urgency because he can see that there is a window of opportunity in which the church in Germany can act and speak boldly and strongly against what the Nazis are going to bring. He knows that the Nazi theology, which we'll get into, is antithetical to Christian faith.
- 4.24 Now, we got to be clear. Many people thought, well, maybe not. Many people thought, okay, maybe Hitler doesn't think the way I do or the Nazis, but they're pretty good. They're going to do some good things. Bonhoeffer sees pretty quickly—no, there's going to be a crash. There's going to be a decisive moment where you have to make a decision. We can't go along with the Nazis. He's trying to wake people up to say this is going to happen, and I'll get to that in a minute—how it happens.
- 4.25 But before that, there's something familiar with what happened, the Reichstag fire. This is months into Hitler's chancellorship, and suddenly, the Reichstag, which is the German Parliament building—you can go in Berlin, you can see it, it's basically still there—burns down. So it's been rebuilt. But the capital building, the Reichstag, is on fire. There was this Dutch arsonist, this 24-year-old, van der Lubbe, who set the fire. But Hitler and the Nazis seize on this moment to go after their enemies.
- 4.26 Now, this is not the only time this has happened in history. Something happens and you declare this is the narrative. The narrative is the communists are trying to bring down Germany and we must hit them hard. We need to put them in prison. We need to execute them. We need to go after our enemies. We need to wipe away the rights that everybody has because we're living in a tough time now, so we're going to throw people in prison. The Nazis, they're just drooling at this opportunity.
- 4.27 They create the narrative and they basically say what we now know not to be true—oh, the communists were behind this, on and on and on. I think I mentioned it in a previous lecture that Bonhoeffer's father, Karl Bonhoeffer, the great psychiatrist in Germany, in Berlin. He's called upon to examine van der Lubbe, but to find out, is this guy insane or whatever? He's inconclusive about it, which, of course, the Nazis didn't like. They wanted him to—in any event, just to show you that the Bonhoeffers, they're always there. There's always a Bonhoeffer around the corner.

- 4.28 But so the Nazis take control of the narrative and they get Hindenburg, the President of Germany, he's 85 years old, to sign the Reichstag Fire Edict, a decree officially suspending those sections of the German Constitution that guaranteed individual liberties and civil rights. Think about that. Think about that. So suddenly, all of your rights are gone with a stroke of a pen, and Germany is no longer the Germany it was before the Reichstag Fire Edict is signed. Bonhoeffer and a number of others see this going on.
- 4.29 I think where things come to a head, because I mentioned that there's going to be a question now of what is the role of the church? Bonhoeffer is trying to get the church to be the church. What is the role of the church. What is the inciting incident for the church to make a decision? That is something called the Aryan Paragraph. Now, Aryan, of course, refers to this sick Nazi idea of that we're the Aryan race, we're this pure race. The Jews—they're the opposite of that. They're evil, whatever. So the Nazis, and again, this is 1933, they're going to define everything along racial lines.
- 4.30 Now, if you want to do that, that's fine. I don't agree with it because it's not Christianity. The Christian faith and the Bible clearly do not operate along racial lines. But a lot of people in history have operated along racial lines. In America, around this time, people were operating along racial lines. So the Nazis create a whole doctrine, a whole worldview based on this concept. And again, it's all insane and false and destructive. But at the time, you could see a lot of people wouldn't get that. A lot of people, including Christians, are very confused about that.
- 4.31 There are many things in the Bible that—if anybody says racism is wrong, I'm like, good for you. Where did you get that idea? People are like what do you mean? Everybody knows it's wrong. No, everybody doesn't know it's wrong, and it hasn't been wrong through much history. Where did you get the idea that it's wrong? It is wrong. Where did you get the idea? The idea comes inevitably from the Bible. Now, if you don't like that, tough luck, because that's just a fact. I'm not going to get into it, but I mean, the whole abolitionist movement, I wrote a book about William Wilberforce called *Amazing Grace*. The whole idea of abolition of slavery, the idea that we're made in the image of God, it comes from the Bible. A lot of people are like, well, I knew that, I knew that, but I'm not a Christian. Well, understand where that idea comes from, that racism is wrong.
- 4.32 Bonhoeffer is now confronted in Germany with this racist idea or racialist idea, whatever you want to call it. And he's like, if the people want to vote for that, that's fine. But the church can have nothing to do with it. The Aryan paragraph is something that the Nazis are trying to introduce. They're trying to say that throughout the whole of German society, we want the Jews out. They effectively are going to become second-class citizens. Now, again, they're not telegraphing that, oh, we're going to murder the Jews. We're a long ways from that. We're practically a decade away from that. But they're saying, we want a racially pure Germany.

- 4.33 Now, if you're an American, you understand that's insane. We don't believe in that. We believe in coalescing around ideas, not around race. The Germans really thought that we want a pure German society, no Jews. Bonhoeffer says, "We have a problem because the church can't go along with that idea." But it gets more pointed because the Nazis are going to do this in every part of society.
- 4.34 This is what totalitarianism is. They're going to define everything, and we're going to move forward with these national socialist ideas. And so the Jews are over here. They're not going to be part of our government. They're not going to be part of our medical establishment. They're not going to be part of it. So this is what the Nazis are doing. But if you don't have a doctrine of separation of church and state, if the church and the state have always been mushed together, which you see a lot in history. You could see how if the head of state is now Adolf Hitler, he feels like, well, we can also affect the church. The church is under the state. The German church is under the state.
- 4.35 Anybody with a really clear biblical worldview understands we have a problem. I just quoted it when I said that "the church has only one altar," Bonhoeffer says. Bonhoeffer is making it real clear. If you're a Christian, you bow to God alone, and everyone has to bow to God. But now Hitler is thinking, "Well, we'll see about that." He wants to institute the Aryan paragraph in the German church, and he wants to create a national German church, a Reichskirche. You could understand how a lot of people wouldn't have a problem with that because they didn't know where this was going.
- 4.36 The idea of a national church, a lot of nations have had national churches. It doesn't need to go wrong. It can be okay for a while. But Bonhoeffer sees clearly this cannot work, that the church has to be distinct from the government, and now we have a clash, and the church has to stand up. There's a famous quote from Bonhoeffer, I think it came from his father, but it's associated with him. Many in the church were saying, listen, we don't love Hitler, but we think we can work with him. We think he'll make Germany better in many ways. He'll give us more opportunities for evangelism.
- 4.37 That's always the big one. Listen, we'll make this compromise, this compromise, this compromise, this compromise, because we'll get to do more evangelism. We'll sell ourselves to the devil because we'll get to do more evangelism. That's basically what Bonhoeffer was dealing with, that many in the church were thinking, "Don't be so hasty, Dietrich Bonhoeffer. We think this could work for us, and we think that we should not have an open clash with the Nazis. We can go along with them."
- 4.38 This is where the famous Bonhoeffer quote comes that's on the board. It says, "If you board the wrong train, it is no use running along the corridor in the opposite direction." It's a comical image, that you're on a train rocketing down the tracks and you're like, "Oh, I'll just run in the right direction." Well, it's not going to work out for you. Bonhoeffer is trying to tell the church, "Hey, church, you need to be openly defiant. You cannot get on this train."

- 4.39 Pretty quickly, this comes to a head, and a lot of the leaders, the church leaders in Germany and Berlin, look to this brilliant young man, Dietrich Bonhoeffer.
- 4.40 What is the biblical point of view? How do we deal with this? How do we deal with the question of the Jews? What do we do? What's the biblical view? Bonhoeffer goes off, and again, this is very early in 1933. It's—I don't know—about two months maybe after Hitler takes power. Bonhoeffer writes a famous essay called *The Church and the Jewish Question*. What is the job of the church with regard to the Jewish question? Do we just do church and ignore this issue of how the Jews are being treated? What is our job as Christians? Again, Bonhoeffer is always asking the question: What is the church? What does it mean to be a Christian? What is our duty? There were plenty, Adolf Hitler—and Satan among them—who would say the church has no business messing with this stuff. Just do church. Just do evangelism. Have your services. You got nothing to do with politics.
- 4.41 Bonhoeffer looks into this and he writes this essay, *The Church and the Jewish Question*, and he delivers it as a speech to a group of ministers. In it, and this is rather famous, he enumerates three possible ways in which the church can act toward the state. Now, think of this. In the United States of America, we did this homework before our Constitution comes out in 1787. We figured this out. Our Founding Fathers dealt with this issue. There was no way in the United States of America we could avoid this issue. We're breaking away from England. We're thinking broadly about what is the role of the church, what is the role of the government. We came to the conclusion from the Scripture that the church is 100% free.
- 4.42 Now, this—to be free people—means at the heart of everything, we are religiously free. The government cannot tell us what church to go to, whether to go to church, how to go to church, whether we need to be atheists, whether we need to be Muslims, whether we can be Christians. The state, the government, has zero say in a truly free society. Our Founding Fathers understood that fundamentally, but Germany never had to deal with it until now. They task Dietrich Bonhoeffer, like a Thomas Jefferson of his time, go deal with this.
- 4.43 He comes up with this essay, *The Church and the Jewish Question*. I say he comes up with three possible ways in which the church can act toward the state. The first was that the church, number one, had to question the state regarding its actions and the legitimacy of those actions. It's the role of the church. He often called the church the conscience of the state. It's the role of the church to help the state be the state in the way that God has ordained.
- 4.44 Biblically, there are many examples. Romans 13 is the most famous example in the Epistle of Romans. But the idea is that God has instituted government to protect the innocent, to use the sword to protect innocents from criminals, from whatever, to protect citizens from those who would want to come into the country and take it over

from barbarians and whatever—that there's a legitimate role of the state. In Romans, Paul is writing about this in the mid-first century.

- 4.45 But Luther, as I think I said one or two lectures ago, overemphasized Romans 13. He elevated the idea of that governments are instituted by God a little higher than the rest of scripture puts it, and Luther makes it seem like, well, the state is always right. Bonhoeffer is not there. Bonhoeffer is like, no, the state—the church is the conscience of the state—and the church will speak boldly to the government. If the government is at a line, it's the job of Christians to speak against the government and to determine whether that government is legitimate. He says this. Most of the pastors are like, okay, fine.
- 4.46 But then Bonhoeffer says, secondly, the job of the church is "to aid the victims of state action." In other words, if the state is harming human beings, it is the job of Christians and the church to help those victims. So if the state is treating people poorly, whether it's the Blacks in America or the Jews in Germany, it's the job of the church—Bonhoeffer is saying clearly—to help the victims. Then, that's number 2.
- 4.47 2B, he basically says, by the way, if those victims are not Christians, if those victims are, in this case, Jews, it is still the duty of the church to help the victims. Okay, this is going to make a lot of the pastors uncomfortable as he's living this. It's like, whoa! So you're telling us the Nazis are bullying the Jews and are starting to take these different actions, and you're saying it's the job of the church to help those victims, to help the Jews. Kind of challenging, philosophically challenging, for a lot of these pastors. They're trying to think this through. Is this right? I might want to do that, but really, I have to do that? Is that my job?
- 4.48 But then Bonhoeffer goes to the third and certainly the most incendiary point of the three points. He says, "The third way the church can act toward the state is not just to bandage the victims under the wheel, not just to help those victims, but to put a spoke"—that's a bad translation, to put a stick in the spokes of "the wheel itself." In other words, the juggernaut of government is crushing its victims. It is the job of the church to stand against the state, to take action against the state.
- 4.49 Now, to a nation like Germany at this time, that has been steeped in this Lutheran idea of Romans 13, and we respect the state. For Bonhoeffer to make it clear like—yeah, yeah, respect the state, respect the state, until this happens and this happens, and then it is your duty as Christians, as the church, to stand against the state, to work against the state. Now, Bonhoeffer, with crystal clear logic, because nobody could defeat him logically, he is being utterly logical and utterly biblical, comes to this conclusion, and he knows this is right.
- 4.50 But there are pastors that walked out of the meeting when he said this, because this is very threatening. He's telling them—yeah, you're going to have to be political, like tough luck. That's the biblical view. If you don't get it, show me where I'm wrong. This is

like, let me show you my work. Show me, where did I get this wrong? That's the answer. Did I get anything wrong here? No, he didn't. It made them uncomfortable.

- 4.51 This is where people just get emotional and they go, "Well, that's our tradition. We don't do that." Well, good for your tradition. Is it possible your tradition is wrong? Is it possible your tradition is not biblical? Is it possible that history has now conspired to point you to a moment where you got to fix this? You've been getting this wrong. For a lot of people in America, the issue of slavery was that issue. There are certain things, something pops up and it forces you to reassess.
- 4.52 So Bonhoeffer does this. It's simply radical. It's a radical thing. It reminds me of when Jesus talked about you have to eat my body and drink my blood. He lost a few in the audience that day. There are a lot of people like, "You know what? I'm out. Too radical for me. Thank you very much. I like a lot of your ideas, but I'm going to have to go my own way." When Bonhoeffer shares this, a lot of these pastors were like, "You know what? No, we're not up for going against the Nazis."
- 4.53 Now, ironically, if they had had the guts then to go up against the Nazis, the German church, I'm sure I said this before, had the power culturally and still had the power politically because the Nazis hadn't amassed the power that they were amassing. They had the power, the German church, to stand against this and to win. But if you have enough cowardly, confused, hand-ringing pastors, evil wins.
- 4.54 Bonhoeffer, this is the first example of how he's disappointed. Again, he's in the role of prophet. He wouldn't put it that way, but I would: "Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy". He's prophetically speaking to the people of God, trying to get them to be the people of God, and many of them are saying, "No, thank you." This is just the first example, but over and over you see this. He gets frustrated because he sees what he sees with crystal clarity. Again, where am I wrong? What am I getting wrong? Nobody could really tell him. They just didn't like it.
- 4.55 Now, I want to say that there was—April 1st, 1933. Think about this, folks. This is a couple of months after Hitler takes power. They pretty quickly instituted a boycott of Jewish stores. Some of you have seen the photos, right? "Kauft Nicht Bei Juden," (Don't buy Jewish goods), right? Now, again, you understand a lot of these ideas, they're kind of attractive if you don't understand where they're going, right? If somebody says, only buy American goods, I go, "Yes, correct. That's right. That's good."
- 4.56 In Germany, they're saying, "Yeah, don't buy from Jews." Now, the Jews were all Germans. The Jews were real Germans who paid taxes. They had fought in World War I. Many of them died in World War I, lost limbs in World War I. But now the Nazis are dividing things along racial lines and they say don't buy goods from Jewish stores. Kind of amazing that this quickly the persecution of Jews starts. Now, again, this is nothing compared to where it's going to go. But you can see in Berlin, you've got all these Nazi

stormtroopers standing in front of these stores and threatening people, bullying them—don't come in.

- 4.57 I want to say again, Bonhoeffer's sister, Sabina, his twin sister, had married a man, Gerhard Leibholz, who believed in Jesus, but he was ethnically Jewish. By Nazi standards, he's a Jew. They didn't care if he believes in Jesus or whatever—parentheses, Jesus was also a Jew—they didn't care. He's ethically Jewish. He's out. He's not German. He's a professor in Göttingen.
- 4.58 Bonhoeffer's sister, Sabina, wrote, she says, "I'd often heard my husband's lectures and went to the university to hear his lecture on the actual day of this boycott in order to be there and to hear what the students would have to say. A few students were standing there in SA uniform," that's Sturmabteilung uniform, "straddling the doorway in their jackboots as only they could, not allowing anyone to enter, saying, Leibholz must not lecture. He is a Jew." The lectures are not taking place. So it's not just don't buy at the Jewish stores, don't attend the lecture of a Jew.
- 4.59 Now, again, this is cultural bullying. It's basically saying to people, you want to be popular, you want to get along, you better go along with what we're telling you. Don't do this. You can't say this. You can't talk about that. If you talk about that, you'll be ostracized. We've seen that in America in very recent years. It's ugly and it works because many people are like, I don't want any trouble. Okay, I'm not going to go to the lecture. But Bonhoeffer, this comes home to him. This is his sister's husband. So his nieces are being treated as dirty Jews. They're hearing this in school. So this is very personal for him. Now, it's not merely personal. If he didn't have any Jews in his family, it wouldn't make any difference. Bonhoeffer was logical, but it's just interesting that it is this kind of stuff.
- 4.60 I want to go back to—or I want to touch on—we can call it Nazi theology, just so that we understand what the Nazis actually thought of Christian faith. Now, we know that they often would talk about Christian faith in a positive way. We know this. But what did they really think? In the book, I've got all these different quotes. I'll just read one. Adolf Hitler at one point says, "It's been our misfortune in Germany to have the wrong religion. Why didn't we have the religion of the Japanese, who regard sacrifice for the Fatherland as the highest good? The Mohammedan religion"—Islam—"also would have been much more compatible to us than Christianity. Why did it have to be Christianity with its meekness and flabbiness?"
- 4.61 Now, imagine this gives you an I find this funny that Hitler is such a megalomaniac lunatic that he thinks of religion as the state bird. Why can't we have a different state bird? It's just this little thing that he doesn't take at all seriously, and he's annoyed. He's peeved that the virtues of the Christian religion are antithetical to national socialism. He gets it. He understands. He's not saying it publicly, but he knows privately that what they're dealing with, they're going to have to play along with the church. But the ultimate goal is to co-opt the church, to keep the church sleeping. I want to be real

clear. So the Nazis don't want to wake up the church. They want to play along, keep the church sleeping. Don't let them know what we're really doing.

- 4.62 Every day that people aren't doing what Bonhoeffer says and standing up against this, the Nazis are getting more power, more power, more power. And Bonhoeffer sees the window closing and he's like, "Church, you got to wake up. You got to wake up. You got to wake up now. You got to stand up now. If you keep sleeping, it's going to be over." I often think of the image of Gulliver being tied down by the Lilliputians. The tiny Lilliputians are tying Gulliver down. He's asleep, and they're tying him down with dental floss or twine or something like that.
- 4.63 If he wakes up, he can rip up the stakes and crush the Lilliputians. But if they keep him sleeping, at some point, there's enough twine that he'll wake up and he can't move. It's over. That's precisely what the devil and the National Socialists under Hitler were trying to do with the church: keep sleeping, keep sleeping. We don't want you to notice that we're tying you down. We don't want you to wake up too soon. We're going to institute laws and regulations and threats. At some point, boom! We got you. That's exactly what happened.
- 4.64 Bonhoeffer could see this happening, and he's trying more and more desperately to wake up the church. Hitler's architect, Albert Speer, commented on this. He says that in 1937, Hitler—this is we're getting ahead of ourselves—but how Hitler's lieutenants are basically saying let's knock out the church. Hitler said, "No, not yet. We've got to keep this illusion going that we're Christians. I was baptized as a Catholic. Let's keep the illusion going." Bormann, who was one of Hitler's lieutenants, recalls Hitler saying, "Once I have settled my other problems"—in other words, once I get enough power, whatever—"I'll have my reckoning with the church. I'll have it reeling on the ropes."
- 4.65 In other words, not yet. We'll keep the jug-headed theologians in the dark. We're not going to reveal how we feel. Not yet, not yet, not yet. But just wait. That's exactly what happened. I want to say that, speaking of the Nazis, Himmler was the head of the SS. He was aggressively anti-Christian. In my book, I mentioned this, I can read this: "Early on, he barred clergy from serving in the SS." Now, the SS, of course, is the elite Nazis, dedicated Nazis. Himmler is like, okay, you want to be in the SS? No clergy allowed.
- 4.66 Now, why would he do that in 1934 if he was not aware that the Christian faith is antithetical to being a true Nazi? In 1935, Himmler ordered every SS member to resign leadership in any religious organizations. In '36, he forbade SS musicians to participate in religious services, even out of uniform. Imagine this. You want to be in the SS? You're a musician? Even out of uniform, you can't participate in any church services. Soon afterward, Himmler forbade SS members even to attend church services. Himmler was deeply involved in the occult. We don't have time to get into that, but he wasn't just anti-Christian. He was Satanic, very dark, pagan religion.

- 4.67 There's another figure who should be mentioned just to get clarity on where the Nazis stood with regard to the church because there are some people, ignorant enough, who claim that Hitler was some kind of a Christian. It's so preposterous. But Rosenberg is one of these Nazi figures who drew up plans for the church in Germany. Part of his plans, he says, "the National Church"—because they were going to have a Reichskirche, they wanted to have a nazified church, right?
- 4.68 "The National Church demands immediate cessation of the publishing and dissemination of the Bible in Germany." Now, again, they don't reveal this till the '40s. "The National Church declares that to it, and therefore to the German nation, it's been decided that the Führer's Mein Kampf is the greatest of all documents. It not only contains the greatest, but embodies the purest and truest ethics for the present and future life of our nation." So they are subverting the church, the plans from within.
- 4.69 He writes, "On the altars, there must be nothing but Mein Kampf. And to the left of the altar, a sword. On the day of its foundation"—this is when they finally established this nazified Reichskirche, this German church—"The Christian cross must be removed from all churches, cathedrals, and chapels. It must be superseded by the only unconquerable symbol, the swastika." Most people have no idea of how devotedly anti-Christian the Nazis were. There's many reasons that many people saw Hitler as an Antichrist figure.
- 4.70 In the midst of all this, Bonhoeffer is trying to get the church to understand what is happening, to understand who the Nazis really are, and that if you don't stand up, if you don't live out your faith, faith in action now, it's going to be too late. There's a lot to talk about. They call the church battle the *Kirchenkampf*, the church struggle, the church battle. There weren't enough enough pastors who really understood this. Bonhoeffer tried over and over, as we've said, to get enough people finally to rally around to stand up.
- 4.71 I should say that there was a group called the German Christians. Now, this is a made up term, right? The *Deutsche Christen*, the German Christians, they were really anything but Christians, but they were the ones behind Hitler who wanted this state church made in the image of Adolf Hitler and who believed, this is the key, that somehow you could reconcile Christian faith with Nazism. So they were behind this. They called themselves the German Christians.
- 4.72 One of their leaders was a guy named—a former military chaplain called Muller—and he was appointed by Hitler as the *Reichsbischof*. So they're enacting this German state church, and Bonhoeffer is ahead of those saying, this can't happen. There can't be a state church. The bottom line is that Bonhoeffer is now seeing where things stand, and he's becoming increasingly frustrated by the inability of most German Christian leaders to see what is at stake and to stand, to see that getting political is your duty when the state is politically trying to swamp the church and take over the church.

- 4.73 One of the examples of the good guys in this story who was a friend of Bonhoeffer and who was fooled by the Nazis, just so you understand, good people can be fooled, was Martin Niemöller. Niemöller was a decorated hero in the first war. He was a respected pastor of a huge church in Dahlem. He got assurances from Adolf Hitler in person in a meeting. This is before Hitler takes power, so this is the end of 1932. Hitler personally met with him and—surprise—I lied. Can you imagine Hitler telling a lie? Telling him if I'm elected Chancellor, we will not go after the church. You have my word. If I'm elected Chancellor, we will not go after the Jews. We will not institute pogroms against the Jews. You have my word.
- 4.74 Niemöller, and this is the case with many Christians, is naive. He doesn't remember that Jesus said, "We are to be wise as serpents." We are to understand the wickedness in the world. Then it's a temptation among many Christians to be naive, to be overly innocent in a way that Jesus commands us not to be. Jesus commands us to be wise as serpents and to understand the nature of evil, the evilness of evil. But Niemöller, in the meeting with Hitler, thinks, well, I'm a patriotic German. Hitler is a patriotic German. We don't see eye to eye and everything, but he gave me his word. Well, obviously, Hitler takes power and instantly starts instituting all kinds of things that he didn't believe.
- 4.75 And Niemöller still believes that it's not Hitler, it's the people around him. Now, there's a little truth to that, but basically, that's not true. Hitler, of course, was very convenient to farm these horrible things out to people around him so that your average German, including Martin Niemöller, would be the impression that—well, Hitler's still a good guy. So Niemöller, he writes a famous poem. Most people are familiar with it because he didn't stand up in time. He kept thinking, No, I think we're good. I think we're good. I think we're good.
- 4.76 It makes me think of the cancel culture. They go after somebody and you're like—yeah, that somebody had it coming. So I'm not going to say anything. I don't agree with that somebody anyway. They pick people off. That's what the Nazis were doing. They come after that group and they're like, everybody good? You're not part of that group, right? So shut up and we're going to go after the communists. You're not a communist, Bolshevik communists, right? So shut up and we're going to go after our enemies, the communists. And you say nothing. Then we're going to go after our other enemies, the trade unionists. You're not one of those, are you? So we're going to go after them. They're picking people up. That's kind of the cancel culture idea in the 1930s.
- 4.77 So Niemöller writes a famous poem. He says, "First they came for the Socialists, and I did not speak out because I was not a Socialist. Then they came for the Trade Unionist, and I did not speak out because I was not a Trade Unionist. Then they came for the Communists, I did not speak out. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not speak out because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me, and there was no one left to speak for me." That's the way it goes. If you don't stand up in principle for what is right, you are

already working with evil. That's one of the ways evil works. That's the way the Nazis were able to silence the church.

- 4.78** They thought like, well, we got no problem with you. Oh, yeah, we're pro-Christian. We're just going after the Jews a little bit. It's none of your business. Bonhoeffer and actual Christians understood, Oh, it is my business. There's a principle here. There's a principle here, and we have to stand up. But a lot in the church were fooled, and a lot in the church thought, I don't know if it's my business to speak up, I'll be quiet. So Martin Niemöller is the classic case.
- 4.79** Niemöller thinks, "If only I can get a meeting with Hitler." Personal meeting. I talked to him eye to eye in late '32 before he took to power. Now it's been almost a year. I need to have a meeting with him and say, "Mein Führer, we have some issues with this and this and this." So he tries and tries and tries to get a meeting with Hitler. And of course, do you think Hitler wants a meeting with Niemöller? No. He just wants Niemöller to keep his mouth shut and do as he's told. Well, eventually, finally, Niemöller, I think this is January '34, he gets a meeting with Hitler.
- 4.80** In this meeting, this is like a nightmare. He sees what he's been dealing with. The mask is now off. He sits in the meeting with Hitler, and Hitler, who doesn't need his vote anymore, suddenly is himself. The meeting opens up where Goebbels reads from a transcript—Niemöller's phone had been tapped. Surprise! The Nazis tapped your phone. They caught you in a conversation making light of the Führer of Hindenburg or something like that. They read this in front of him. Now, what's the point to do this with Hitler there? It's a chilling effect to let you know, "Listen, pastor, you're lucky you're not in a concentration camp right now. You better keep your mouth shut. This is what we have on you."
- 4.81** Hitler fulminates, rages in the meeting that this is an outrage. How dare you? So Niemöller is like, whoa, I didn't see this coming. He then does what anybody would do. He tries to say, "Wait a minute, there's a misunderstanding. Mein Fuhrer, I care about the Third Reich. I'm a patriotic German. I got the Iron Cross in World War I. I care about Germany. I care about the Third Reich. Wait a minute." Hitler says, and this is like it's not in the movie, but it's like a line from a movie, but it actually happened. Hitler says, "I built the Third Reich. You just worry about your sermons."
- 4.82** Now, right there, you have the devil's view of the church, Hitler's view of the church, the view of any totalitarian or big government of the church. What's their view? The church is a little nothing. You stay in your little religious corner, you preach your little meaningless sermons. What do we care? It has nothing to do with the affairs of state, with the culture. Keep your mouth shut and we'll let you do your little church on Sunday. That's what Hitler, in a nutshell, communicates: "You just worry about your sermons."

- 4.83 In other words, your useless sermons that have no bearing on any of the stuff that's going on right now. You just talk about your little Jesus and your little Bible, whatever. You have nothing to say about the Third Reich. I built the Third Reich. In effect, I am God. I determine the reality in which we live. You get to do your little religious rituals in that building on a Sunday morning. If you're lucky, if you play ball, we'll let you do that. When you leave that building, you will bow to the secular authority of the state. That is the church they have officially in China today. You want to go to an official church? Be our guest. Go to that church there, do your little weird religious stuff, but it cannot have any bearing on what we're doing here.
- 4.84 This is what Hitler lays out. So suddenly the scales fall from Niemöller's eyes. He thinks, oh, my goodness, what has happened. I have enabled Hitler to gain power. I have been foolish. I have been naive. It is really a horrifying moment. From this point on, Niemöller is very, very brave in speaking against the Nazis. Incredibly brave, as we'll see. But as Bonhoeffer warned, it is now too late. If you had spoken up six months ago, Niemöller would have led the battle against the Nazis, but it is now essentially too late. We'll end there. Midterm is tomorrow. Good luck. Thank you.
- 4.85 I'm a J6er. Do you see any parallels between the Reichstag fire and what happened on J6? I was so upset. I cut my cable at the distorted news.
- 4.86 I'm sorry to say I do. I think it's important for us to think about that stuff, about when the government seizes control of a narrative. Because sometimes governments will do it aggressively when they can get away with it, but they can only get away with it if the people let them get away with it. I think this— really, for me, it's about the role of the church. Bonhoeffer said, "It is the role of the church to hold the state to account." In other words, if they're getting out of line or they're doing something, even that you're thinking, I don't know what I think, but it looks troubling to me. It is the role of the church, first and foremost, to say, "Excuse me, I have a question. Excuse me, what about this? What about this? Are people being treated right?" That's the job of the church.
- 4.87 When the church goes along with the government, great dangers are possible. I think that we've seen that more in the last few years where this—people say, "No, it's not the job of the church to speak up or to ask questions." I would strongly dissent. I think that the case of what happened in Germany, it makes the case crystal clear. I should say I wrote a book called Letter to the American Church, and I wrote a subsequent book called Religionless Christianity. That's a Bonhoeffer term. I deal with this issue, not really extremely specifically with political stuff, but I'm saying that it's important for us to think through what does it mean for us today?
- 4.88 It's one thing to say—well, the Nazis did this, and Bonhoeffer tried to get the church to stand up. What does it mean today? Does it mean anything today? Maybe not. I think it does. I wrote the Bonhoeffer book. This is the longest book I ever wrote. The shortest book I ever wrote is the one I just mentioned, Letter to the American Church, and also

almost as short as Religionless Christianity, where I unpack this stuff. So I don't want to say more about it right now. But I think it's very important. The whole point of Bonhoeffer is to get us to think about— what does it mean for me today to be a Christian? What does it mean for me today to speak against the state or to question the government? This is not just history. This is the whole point Bonhoeffer says is that we're supposed to think about what does it mean for me today? And that applies to us. So thank you for that question.

- 4.89 It's very simple. What is the trick to navigating between naivety and dogmatic pathology.
- 4.90 Say that again.
- 4.91 The trick to navigating between naivety and dogmatic pathology.
- 4.92 Well, it's a question that no one can escape. In other words, when people say that—when Jesus says, "Be wise as serpents and innocent as doves." He's basically making every person think for themselves about, okay, I've got to try to get that right. He's telling me, be wise as serpents. There's evil in the world. There's a temptation to see evil everywhere and to be so hard-hearted that you forget about grace, you forget about love, you forget about innocence, you forget about giving somebody the benefit of the doubt. That's a big problem.
- 4.93 The other problem is to be so full of—quote, unquote—"grace" that you don't understand God's idea of justice. This is something that is perennial for anybody that wants to say, I want to know what does God want from me? What God wants from you is to think deeply about this stuff and to not err easily in this direction or this direction. There's some people, their instinct is toward what you call dogmatic pathology. It's very easy to just be scorched earth constantly and wanting to go after people. That can be a problem. Some people have that tendency.
- 4.94 Other people have the tendency of being naive. We are asked by God to examine our own hearts. What is my temptation? My temptation maybe is to look the other way when I should see a problem. My temptation is maybe the opposite, to be harsh when I should say, "Well, wait a minute. I mean, yes, this is true, but God calls me to pray for my enemies." So even though I see somebody doing wrong, they are my enemy, they're doing evil, God commands me to pray for them. Why? Not so they can keep doing evil, but so maybe God can reach them. Maybe God can have a reckoning with them and get them to stop doing what they're doing.
- 4.95 This is the perennial question. This is what God asks of us at all times. What is your temptation to be this or to be this? And then to deal with it. Everybody, as I say, people are different. There are plenty of people I know that are like, they've made an idol of niceness. I always want to be nice. But what if God is not calling you to be nice? What if God's calling you to be a warrior right now? Are you able to do that? Then there are plenty of people that they only want to be warriors. If God says, you need to tone it

down, have some grace, and they're like, "No, I just want to—" We have to be honest with ourselves. We'll leave it there. Thank you very much.

Lecture 5: Discipleship and Defiance

At a glance — Discipleship and defiance.

- 5.1** Welcome to lecture five, or as the Germans call it, Fünf. Thank you. We're at that point now where Bonhoeffer basically sees the handwriting on the wall. It's hard to say how he sees it or what he sees, but he knows somehow that the German church lost this opportunity to effectively stand against the Nazis. Things keep changing. The Nazis get more and more and more power.
- 5.2** As that happens, you see this through the course of Bonhoeffer's life, from here on out, he keeps changing, reacting, in a sense, to changing circumstances. His Christian faith is the same, but this is an important dynamic. God is alive, and we have a relationship with God. What God tells me to do now may be different than what God tells me to do yesterday or tomorrow. And Bonhoeffer is constantly asking God to lead him. The first idea was if we can get the church to stand—this is him being a prophet, right?—to stand against the Nazis vigorously, then we can win.
- 5.3** But by '34, '35, he sees that's not really happening. He thinks, "Okay, what do I do now?" He's fed up with how the church did not do what he knew that they could do. Effectively, what does he do? He goes to London. He goes to London because he just doesn't know, "What can I do in Germany anymore?" As I said, he gets fed up. He's invited to pastor two German-speaking congregations in London, one in Sydenham, and he decides to do that.
- 5.4** He writes a letter to his friend that he made at Union, Erwin Sutz, and in it, he says—he kind of wonders where this is going. He says, "Simply suffering—that is what will be needed then—not parries, blows, or thrusts such as may still be possible or admissible in the preliminary fight; the real struggle that perhaps lies ahead must simply be to suffer faithfully. For some time, [the church struggle] hasn't even been about what it appears to be about. The lines have been drawn somewhere else entirely."
- 5.5** That gets a little vague, but the point is, he's really wondering where this is going and what do I do now. Practically speaking, he goes to London. He accepts this invitation. His mentor, his friend Karl Barth, he doesn't tell him because he knows Karl Barth is going to say, "How dare you leave your post. Stay in Germany. You're fighting bravely." Bonhoeffer has different ideas.
- 5.6** He preaches a sermon in London in 1934. Now, I want to be clear, Bonhoeffer, I've said it before, that whatever he does, he's doing 10 things at once. When he goes to America, he goes all over America, he goes into Mexico. When he goes to Barcelona, he travels to France. He's always doing a million things at once. He goes to London, but he does not cease to be involved in what's going on back home in Germany.

- 5.7** So, the church struggle—he's still intensely involved in that. He's on the phone constantly with his mother, Paula Bonhoeffer. You think about that again, who is this woman? She's an amazing woman, and she is part of galvanizing her son to stand firm, to take action, to live out your faith, to get these other pastors to live out their faith. She's giving him the background on the phone. At one point, his phone bill was so high that I think the post office—where you made the phone calls—they gave half of it back to him. They thought, "It's got to be a mistake. Nobody could be on the phone this much from London to Berlin."
- 5.8** He also traveled back and forth. He went back to Berlin. Even when he's in London, he's not always in London. But basically, during this period, he's in London. He preaches a sermon in London. Again, this gets back to Bonhoeffer—Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy—the prophet. He preaches a sermon. Imagine you go to a Lutheran church in London, you're German, and this pastor preaches a sermon which—it's not exactly a fun sermon. He's preaching about Jeremiah, and he writes, he says, "Jeremiah"—he speaks—"Jeremiah was not eager to become a prophet of God. When the call came to him, all of a sudden, he shrank back. He resisted. He tried to get away." It seems like Bonhoeffer is talking about himself, that God has put this calling on his life, and he says, "Well, I don't want this calling, but yes, Lord, I will do it."
- 5.9** Bonhoeffer, in the sermon, says, "This path"—of the prophet—"will lead right down into the deepest situation of human powerlessness. The follower of God becomes a laughing stock, scorned and taken for a fool, but a fool who is extremely dangerous to people's peace and comfort, so that he or she must be beaten, locked up, tortured, if not put to death right away. That is exactly what became of this man, Jeremiah, because he could not get away from God."
- 5.10** It's really fascinating how deep this is. Most sermons are nothing like this. He's talking about what it means to be a dedicated, radical follower of God, and how often that doesn't look so great, doesn't look so wonderful. It may lead you into some dark places, but you have no ability to do anything but to follow God. He really seems to be speaking about himself.
- 5.11** Going on, "Jeremiah was upbraided as a disturber of the peace, an enemy of the people, just like all those throughout the ages, until the present day who have been possessed and seized by God, for whom God had become too strong, how gladly would he"—Jeremiah—"have shouted peace and Heil with the rest?" He uses the word "heil." In other words, the temptation to go with the crowd, to say I just don't want this battle anymore. Leave me alone. I just want to say Heil Hitler and go to have a nice church service on Sunday. But Bonhoeffer is saying, yeah, but sometimes you don't get to do that. Sometimes you have to be that bold, prophetic voice.
- 5.12** He ends with, "the triumphal procession of truth and justice, the triumphal procession of God and his Scriptures through the world, drags in the wake of the chariot of victory, a train of prisoners in chains. May he, at the last"—God—"bind us to his triumphal

carriage so that, although in bonds oppressed, we may participate in his victory!" That is heavy stuff. I just want to be clear: heavy stuff.

- 5.13** Okay, so Bonhoeffer is in London. One of the main things that comes out of his time in London is his friendship with Bishop Bell. Bishop Bell is a big deal. He's a member of the House of Lords. He and Bonhoeffer become friends. Early in 1934, we come to—this is a signal moment in the story of Bonhoeffer and the story of Germany during this period, the writing of the Barmen Declaration and the birth of the Confessing Church. There have been a number of efforts, I didn't get into them, but where Bonhoeffer and others are trying to create a document to say we're going to stand here, we're not going to do this, we're not going to do that. There's something called the Bethel Declaration. None of it is really strong enough.
- 5.14** Now it's May 1934, and a group of the heroic pastors, they came to call themselves the Pastors Emergency League, Pfarrernotbund, they decide to gather and to create a document, and they do it in Barmen, and so it's called the Barmen Declaration. The purpose of the Barmen Declaration was to state what the German church had always believed, to ground it in Scriptures, to differentiate it from the bastardized theology that had been coming from the Nazified German Christians, the Deutsche Christen.
- 5.15** The Barmen Declaration made clear that the German church was not under the authority of the state, so they're making this official in the Barmen Declaration. The Barmen Declaration repudiated the anti-Semitism and other heresies of the German Christians and their official Reichskirche led by Mueller. The principal author of the Barmen Declaration was Karl Barth, who claimed to have produced the final version of it, "fortified by strong coffee and one or two Brazilian cigars."
- 5.16** What does the Barmen Declaration say? I'll just read two points. One, "We reject the false doctrine as though the State, over and beyond its special commission, should and could become the single and totalitarian order of human life, thus fulfilling the Church's vocation as well. We reject the false doctrine as though the Church, over and beyond its special commission, should and could appropriate the characteristics, the tasks, and the dignity of the State, thus itself becoming an organ of the State."
- 5.17** If you don't have separation of church and state, if you don't have, as we do in our US Constitution, the idea of freedom of religion, at some point, and this is it, May 1934, you're forced to declare this stuff, to say, "Hold on, in case it wasn't clear before, we who are the faithful Christians are coming up with this clear stuff." They publish it on June 4th, just a few days after they put it out, thanks to Bishop Bell and Bonhoeffer, who was causing a lot of trouble for the German church in London.
- 5.18** They published the full text of the Barmen Declaration in the London Times. This was incendiary. It announced to the world that a group of Christians in Germany had officially and publicly declared their independence from the Nazified Reichskirche. This is a big deal. Now, Bonhoeffer, those who signed the Barmen Declaration, those who

are willing to go along with these ideas, it was probably around 6,000 pastors. There were 18,000 Lutheran pastors in Germany at this time, about 18,000. So only 6,000 signed the Barmen Declaration, were brave enough to do that. They effectively become what was called the Confessing Church, the Bekennende Kirche.

- 5.19** Now, confessing, it has this concept. We don't mean confessing like a confessional booth, confess your sins. The German Christians of the time, the real German Christians, not the so-called German Christians but Bonhoeffer and others and the Lutherans, had this idea of confessing, to confess your faith, to speak out your faith, to live out your faith boldly. They call themselves the confessing Christians. They're not going to go along with the Nazified Reichskirche. So they call themselves the Confessing Church. Now, Bonhoeffer, because of this Barmen Declaration and because of the emergence of what we're now calling the Confessing Church, he knew that the Confessing Church, he believed, that the Confessing Church was the actual German church. So the Reichskirche is this false apostate German church, heretically giving fealty to Adolf Hitler.
- 5.20** So Bonhoeffer thinks, okay, we've written the Barmen Declaration. Those who have signed it constitute the Confessing Church, this is the true German church. And he believed that all true Christians in Germany would recognize that the Reichskirche was officially excommunicated. But as it turned out, not everyone saw things in the way that Bonhoeffer had hoped. It's interesting. Bonhoeffer became—I mean, the theme maybe of this period is Bonhoeffer's frustration. Again, he was looking for Christians to put their faith into action clearly, strongly, decisively. This was the time to do that. And they constantly refused. Not yet, not yet.
- 5.21** He thinks surely we've done it now. We've created the Barmen Declaration, so it's late. It's May, June, 1934. But there it is, 6,000 pastors sign it. This is the Confessing Church. This is the true church in Germany. Anybody not going along with us is part of the apostate, Nazified church of Archbishop Müller, the Reichskirche. But a lot of people just said, "Well, I don't know. We don't know."
- 5.22** The biggest problem he had was he made a lot of friends in what we call the ecumenical movement. I mentioned a few lectures ago about his friend, Jean Lasserre, this Frenchman who makes him understand that Christians anywhere in any country have more in common with each other than we do with people in our own country who don't have the Christian faith. Bonhoeffer saw hope in the ecumenical movement around Europe, that they might stand against the evil that's happening in Germany. But even in the ecumenical church, he found this dithering that they weren't necessarily willing to recognize the Confessing Church as the true church in Germany. They were like, well, we don't see that.
- 5.23** Bonhoeffer's frustration, there are many quotes, but here's one. He writes, "It is high time we broke with our theologically-based restraint toward the state's actions—which, after all, is only fear. 'Speak out for those who cannot speak'—who in the church today

realizes that this is the very least that the Bible requires of us?" He's amazed. He's dismayed by the lack of decisive action, and he calls it theologically-based restraint. In other words, they're giving religious excuses for doing nothing. He was furious about this.

- 5.24** It leads him eventually to use the term religionless Christianity, which we'll get to later. But he's thinking, all this theological talk, religious talk, and yet you're not doing what God is asking you to do. You're hypocrites, you're religious hypocrites. How complicated is it, he says, to speak out for those who cannot speak? This is complicated? We have to have meetings and— do we not understand this is basically what it means to be a Christian? How much more basic does it get?
- 5.25** At this point, he still isn't sure what to do, but what does he do? He is offered an invitation. So let's be clear, there's this thing called the Confessing Church, the Nazified Reichskirche, and the German government, Hitler and the Nazis, are offended by the concept of the Confessing Church. They say, "No, no, the official German church is the Reichskirche led by Müller." Obviously, you have real political dissent. You have political resistance. People in the Confessing Church are standing against it. So Bonhoeffer's frustration had led him to lead Germany for London.
- 5.26** But now, about, I guess about 18 months after that, he is persuaded to go back to Germany by the offer of an invitation to lead an illegal seminary for the Confessing Church. A lot of the leaders of the Confessing Church have this idea that we need to train these young men who are being trained for the ministry. They can't go to the seminaries that are allowing Nazi doctrine in, we've got to start our own seminary. In the outpost of Pomerania, this is up on the today would be Poland, but which was then still Germany. Bonhoeffer is persuaded to lead this illegal seminary. First, it's at a place called Zingst, and then for a much longer time at Finkenwalde, and Bonhoeffer is going to be their leader.
- 5.27** Before he makes the decision, though, he writes a letter. I think this one to his grandmother. I'm not entirely clear. He writes, "I'm hopelessly torn between staying here"—which is to say in London— "going to India and returning to Germany to take charge of a preacher's seminary shortly to be opened there. I no longer believe in the university and never really have believed in it." Now, again, he was even thinking, do I go back to the academic world?
- 5.28** He writes, "The entire education of the younger generation of theologians belongs today in church, cloister-like schools in which pure doctrine, the Sermon on the Mount, and worship are taken seriously—as they never are (and in present circumstances) couldn't be at the university." He's basically saying the Nazis have taken over the universities, the Nazis have taken over the official seminaries. So, we know that he eventually accepts this idea. But he understood that what's really missing, and this gets back—we've mentioned this a number of times—the idea of what does it really mean to be a Christian?

- 5.29 He sees that the basics are not being taught even to these would be pastors, the basics of what does it mean to be a disciple of Jesus? What does that mean? He wrote a letter to his brother, the physicist, Karl-Friedrich. Karl-Friedrich was not a Christian, and it speaks to Bonhoeffer's openness, the idea that he can speak to people that totally disagree with him. He respects them. In fact, his brother, Karl-Friedrich, had been for some time a socialist in his thinking and his politics.
- 5.30 But Bonhoeffer writes a letter to him, "Perhaps I seem to you rather fanatical and mad about a number of things. I myself am sometimes afraid of that. But I know that the day I become more 'reasonable', to be honest, I should have to chuck my entire theology. When I first started in theology, my idea of it was quite different— rather more academic, probably, now it has turned into something else altogether. But I do believe that at last I am on the right track, for the first time in my life. I often feel quite happy about it. I only worry about being so afraid what other people will think as to get bogged down instead of going forward. I think I am right in saying that I would only achieve true inner clarity and honesty by really starting to take the Sermon on the Mount seriously. The restoration of the church must truly depend on a new monasticism, which has nothing in common with the old"—monasticism—"but would be a life of uncompromising discipleship. Following Christ according to the Sermon on the Mount. I believe the time has come to gather people together and do this."
- 5.31 It's an amazing thing. He now has an opportunity to live out what he's been thinking about—that we need to go back to basics. I need to school this group of young people, these young men, not much younger than Bonhoeffer, of course, because he's still young, in what does it mean to be a disciple? We know that a couple of years after this, he writes his book, *Nachfolga*, the Cost of Discipleship. What does it mean? He's been thinking about this for years. Now comes this point where he gets to actually live it. He's being invited and he accepts to lead this illegal seminary.
- 5.32 Now, I want to be clear, he gets pushback from some people. Here he's writing to his brother who's not a Christian, who's probably thinking, "My brother's nuts." But he gets pushback from Karl Barth. Karl Barth is concerned that Bonhoeffer has gotten a little bit—I don't know—it's like Karl Barth is worried that what is Bonhoeffer becoming a Catholic? That won't do. He gives him some pushback. Bonhoeffer then writes to Karl Barth, and he tries to explain himself. He says, "It is certain that both theological work and real pastoral fellowship can only grow in a life which is governed by gathering round the Word"—capital W—"the Word of God, morning and evening and by fixed times of prayer."
- 5.33 He's saying this to Karl Barth, knowing Karl Barth doesn't agree. He says, "The charge of legalism does not seem to me to fit at all. What is legalistic in a Christian setting to work to learn what prayer is and in spending a good deal of time in this learning? A leading man in the Confessing Church recently said to me, 'We have no time for meditation now. The ordinands should learn how to preach and to catechize.' That seems to me

either a complete misunderstanding of what young theologians are like today or a culpable ignorance of how preaching and catechism come to life."

- 5.34 "The questions that are seriously put to us today by young theologians are: How do I learn to pray? How do I learn to read the Bible? If we cannot help them there we cannot help them at all. There is really nothing obvious about it. To say, 'If someone does not know that, then he should not be a minister' would be to exclude most of us from our profession. It is quite clear to me that all these things are only justified when alongside them and with them—at just the same time—there is really serious and sober theological, exegetical and dogmatic work going on. Otherwise, all these questions are given the wrong emphasis."
- 5.35 So Bonhoeffer is getting radical. He's going to teach these men to pray, to meditate on the Word of God. And this he does first at Zingst, and then when they get this location at Finkenwalde. One of his students there remembered that Bonhoeffer would often talk about these different things "while sitting on the large staircase in the main manor house at Finkenwalde, holding a cigarette and a cup of coffee. Another lasting impression made upon me"—wrote, remembers—"was Bonhoeffer's complaint how much we lacked the "love" of Jesus."
- 5.36 Again, you're not hearing this—you're not going to hear this in other seminaries. You certainly weren't going to hear it at Union Theological Seminary. Bonhoeffer is being very, very radical. This is a famous quote from Bonhoeffer. He said, "Only he who cries out for the Jews may sing Gregorian chants." In other words, don't sing your worship, your hymns to God, if you're not doing what God asks of you. That should be at the heart of what it means to be a Christian. Don't try to fool God with your liturgy and you're going through the motions. Are you doing what God asked you to do? That's one of the rather famous quotes.
- 5.37 Another is, he says, "The proclamation of grace has its limits." This is key. "Grace may not be proclaimed to anyone who does not recognize or distinguish or desire it. The world upon whom grace is thrust as a bargain will grow tired of it, and it will not only trample upon the Holy, but will also those who force it on them." Of course, he is alluding to Jesus saying, "Cast ye not your pearls before swine, lest they turn and rend you." Bonhoeffer sees a lot of this, and we see this in the American church. It's all about the love of Jesus. It's all about love. It's all about grace.
- 5.38 Bonhoeffer is saying, what do you mean by grace? Do you understand what grace is? Do you understand what the love of God is? Do you understand the holiness of God? Do you understand the fear of God? This blather about the love of God or grace, he sees how for many German Christians at the time, it's just an excuse to do nothing. It's like, well, we don't want to be warriors. We don't want to fight against evil. We just want to preach grace. Of course, he famously writes a book, I keep mentioning it, *The Cost of Discipleship*, where this is the central issue in the book, *The Cost of Discipleship*.

Absolutely the central issue. He calls this over-proclamation of grace, cheap grace. There's nothing worse than cheap grace. It's fake grace. It's simply not real grace.

5.39 In 1935, just to give you a picture of things in Germany, the Nazis, now they've gained more and more power. They announced the Nuremberg Law on September 15th, 1935. Just think it—they're totally racial, racist, and they were laws for "the protection of German blood and German honor." Imagine now, these are laws in Germany because the church has not stood up, the Nazis have pushed forward and pushed forward and pushed forward; September 15th, 1935: boom!

5.40 Here are the Nuremberg laws. These are laws, laws in Germany. I'll read a little bit. "Entirely convinced that the purity of German blood is essential to the further existence of the German people, and inspired by the uncompromising determination to safeguard the future of the German nation, the Reichstag has unanimously resolved upon the following laws which are promulgated herewith:"—number 1—"Section I. 1. Marriages between Jews and citizens of German or kindred blood are forbidden. Marriages concluded in defiance of this law are void, even if, for the purpose of evading this law, they were concluded abroad. Proceedings for annulment may be initiated only by the Public Prosecutor."

5.41 "Section II."—This is amazing—"Extramartial intercourse between Jews and subjects of the state of Germany or related blood is forbidden. Section III. Jews will not be permitted to employ female citizens of German or kindred blood as domestic workers under the age of 45. Section IV. 1. Jews are forbidden to display the Reichsflagge or the national colors. On the other hand, they are permitted to display the Jewish colors. The exercise of this right is protected by the State."

5.42 It's astonishing to think—again, this is just part of what is happening—Bonhoeffer never said the following quote, but it's often been attributed to him, or at least I couldn't find anywhere that he actually said it, but it applies to his thinking. And so we can use it to sum up his thinking. It's a famous quote, "Silence in the face of evil is itself evil. Not to speak is to speak, not to act is to act. God will not hold us guiltless."

5.43 This is the idea, and Bonhoeffer said it in a hundred other ways, that for the church to be silent in the face of these evils, there's no religious carve out. You don't get a pass. You can't say, well, we don't want to do politics. We're just going to do church, whatever. Bonhoeffer over and over says if you have been silent in the face of these evils, if you have not spoken up for the Jews, if you have not spoken up for the church against the state, which is trying to take over the church, if you have been silent, you are participating in evil, if you haven't done anything, you are guilty. God will not hold us guiltless. Again, he says this over and over.

5.44 But as we know, the Confessing Church was slow to act. Now, imagine—the Confessing Church, these are the good guys. These are the 6,000 pastors that signed the Barmen Declaration. There are 12,000 that didn't. There are plenty that say, well, we don't want

any trouble. Bonhoeffer was always trying to reach those who hadn't signed the Barmen Declaration. But the point is, even within the Confessing Church, he sees people dithering, unclear, unable to decide what to do. And following their theme is the Nazis are getting stronger and stronger and stronger. They're getting more and more power.

- 5.45** By 1937, they abandon all pretense of being even-handed, and they come down to crush the Confessing Church. So this is a warning, right? If you don't stand up when you have the opportunity to stand up, and again, this is Martin Niemöller's quote, his poem, "They will come for you." You think they won't? If you want to keep your nose clean, you want to stay out of trouble—they're going to come for you eventually. So you better fight now or they're going to get you later, and they'll be much stronger later.
- 5.46** This reminds us of the Book of Esther. In the Book of Esther, Mordechai says to Esther, "You think you can keep your mouth shut, you don't want any trouble? You are a Jew. They're going to come for you eventually. So, better speak up now and risk your life now because they're going to come for you and your life a little later on. So you could do nothing now and participate in evil, and they're going to get you anyway. Or you could speak up now, cast your cares on God, ask him to be with you."
- 5.47** That's what Bonhoeffer did. I want to be clear. That's what Bonhoeffer did. That's why he's such a heroic figure. He understood, I could die at any time, maybe I'll die. I don't care. He really believed Jesus defeated death on the cross. He was all in, and he was a little shocked to see so many in the German church who were not all in, who were timid.
- 5.48** In 1937, the Nazis decide, we're going to crack down. That year, more than 800 Confessing church pastors and lay leaders were imprisoned or arrested. Here it is. They didn't speak up. Now the Nazis have their opportunity. Boom! They arrest Martin Niemöller. Now, I said when he finally understood what was going on in that meeting with Hitler that I spoke about at the end of the last lecture, he becomes very bold. Martin Niemöller is very bold. He's preaching fire against the Nazis from his pulpit.
- 5.49** But in 1937, they arrest him. It's extraordinary. From the pulpit, Martin Niemöller declared, "We have no more thought of using our own powers to escape the arm of the authorities than had the Apostles of old. No more are we ready to keep silent at man's behest when God commands us to speak. For it is, and must remain, the case that we must obey God rather than man." That was his last sermon preached, June 27, 1937. That Thursday, he was arrested.
- 5.50** I mentioned Bonhoeffer's very dear friend, Franz Hildebrandt. Franz Hildebrandt was ethnically Jewish. He was a pastor. He was arrested during this time. The Bonhoeffer family made a huge effort because remember—they had power. They were part of the elite world, Karl Bonhoeffer. They got him released two days earlier than he should have been. That enabled him, this is Franz Hildebrandt, to escape to Switzerland. Now,

this is 1937. If he had been stuck in Germany, he would have probably been sent to a concentration camp and killed, obviously. From Switzerland, Hildebrandt goes to London, where, of course, Bonhoeffer has all these contacts from the time that he spent there, and Hildebrandt survives the war.

- 5.51 There's much more to be said, but I think I just want to touch quickly on the idea of we can see Bonhoeffer trying to process things. Things keep changing. Finkenwalde is his response to teach these ordinands. But of course, eventually, the Nazis shut down Finkenwalde. I think that's 1937.
- 5.52 At that point, Bonhoeffer, in case it's not been clear, Bonhoeffer is good with subversion. He's good with deception. His concept of ethics doesn't mean "I'm going to go along with the Nazis." If I have to be subversive, I will be subversive. So when they shut down Finkenwalde, he creates a situation where he's able to continue doing this teaching, but he does it underground. It's no longer at Finkenwalde, but it's in other parishes scattered around Pomerania.
- 5.53 He really keeps changing things, and the Nazis keep tightening the noose and tightening the noose. Eventually, they forbid him from speaking. They forbid him from preaching. The noose gets tighter and tighter. Bonhoeffer keeps looking to God. In the sermon that he preached in London about Jeremiah, you just get the idea that he is all in, and he's saying, "Lord, lead me. I don't like it, but I will follow. I will lead where you go." The farther out on the limb he goes, the fewer who are willing to follow.
- 5.54 As we'll see in the next lecture, when he gets involved in the Abwehr, a lot of people were just completely mystified— what in the world is Bonhoeffer doing? But he was not afraid to go where he thought God was leading him. He is canny, he's clever. He is the definition of wise as a serpent. It's extraordinary to see because as we said in the last lecture, a lot of Christians have this false idea that we're supposed to be "wise as doves and innocent as doves." It's like, no, that's wrong. Jesus said "serpents." There is evil. You've got to be canny. You've got to respond to the evil.
- 5.55 One of the reasons I love Bonhoeffer, one of the reasons I wrote the book about Bonhoeffer, one of the reasons I recommend Bonhoeffer to you is that he is a rare model of someone who lived out his faith utterly, who understood what was at stake, and who was willing to go out on a limb to follow God, even when other people thought, you're a little radical, you're a little crazy. He really was heroic in that sense. We'll get more into that in the next lecture. I wanted to leave a little time in this lecture for some questions. I'll stop the official talking and we'll get to some of your questions.
- 5.56 As Bonhoeffer kept ducking, diving, and dodging, continuing to do whatever he could, what is your favorite anecdote about this time in his life where the noose kept tightening, but he just kept getting away from it.
- 5.57 You are forcing me to say now what I think I was going to say in the next lecture, but who cares? My favorite story about Bonhoeffer, and I will talk about it more in the next

lecture. But again, this is getting ahead of ourselves. This is probably sometime—I guess it's 1941. The Nazis have taken Paris. Again, from the point of view of your average German who's not in on this and who doesn't understand everything we've been talking about, they're just living in Germany, life was horrible under the Weimar Republic. The economy was terrible. They were humiliated because of the loss in the First World War. Finally, Hitler brings them back and gives them victory after victory. And now they take Paris. Holy cow! They lost to the French. Now the Nazi swastika is hanging in Paris.

- 5.58** And your average German, and it's very easy for us with 2020 hindsight to think, how ridiculous. But that's not fair, given what most of them knew. They were thrilled. My goodness. First of all, most of them didn't know about the death camps. I mean, this is before the death camps. They just think— isn't this great? How wonderful. I say this because Bonhoeffer and his best friend, Eberhard Bethge, they were someplace, I forget where, I think in Pomerania, someplace pretty far northeast of Berlin. This news comes on the loudspeaker. They're at an outdoor café. The news comes on the loudspeaker, and every German around them is freaking out. This is the greatest thing: Celebrate! Celebrate! We have just, in a sense, relitigated World War I. Just tremendous joy and triumph. Bonhoeffer does the Nazi salute and says, "Heil Hitler! Heil Hitler! Heil Hitler!"
- 5.59** His friend, Eberhard Baker, looks at him like, "Are you out of your mind?" What is going on here? Bonhoeffer says to him something along the lines of, "Listen, we've got bigger fish to fry." He's crossing a line, and we'll get into this in the next lecture, but he's crossing a line where he's now going to be defiantly deceptive. He's going to pretend to be on board with the Nazis. Why? Because he wants to defeat the Nazis. And so he's willing to look like a good Nazi: "Oh, we're at war? Of course. Heil Hitler. God bless Germany! Everything is great. This is great!" Because he wants people to look at him and think, "Oh, we could trust him. We don't have to worry about him." Meanwhile, he is working every day for the defeat of Adolf Hitler.
- 5.60** That, to me, is a moment. It's a moment because it really shows you the depth of his theology, that he's willing to go there because many hidebound pietistic Germans would say, "How can you—this is deception. You can't be a Christian and be deceptive." He would say, That's incorrect. They're examples from the Scripture. God looks on your heart. What are you really trying to do? So outwardly, there's deception, but in his heart, he's trying to do the right thing for the Jews who are being killed and on and on. That's just one of my favorite examples of how suddenly you see him shift and you think, wow, he's fearless and he's really dedicated theologically to what he thinks is the right thing.
- 5.61** My question has to do with Bonhoeffer's view of the Holy Spirit. If I could frame the question: his experience in the Harlem Church, obviously, he saw the Holy Spirit in action. But being a North German, it was something he would admire more than

embrace himself, probably. I don't see too much in his writing speaking explicitly about the Holy Spirit. We know that Jesus said to his Disciples, warning them when he left, that he would leave them the Holy Spirit. I noticed in your book, *Seven Women*, you kick it off with Joan of Arc. She obviously felt very close to the Holy Spirit. Otherwise, she couldn't have done the things she did or suffered the things she suffered. I'm just wondering if there's some writing or some comments that he has made that emphasize more that it's the power of the Holy Spirit that allows us to live out our faith.

- 5.62** Have I not brought up his extensive correspondence with Smith Wigglesworth? That was a joke. Thank you, ladies and gentlemen. Bonhoeffer is so funny because Bonhoeffer and Wilberforce, the subjects of my two biographies, they're such heroes to me, heroes of the faith. But neither of them really goes in the direction of what you're describing. Look, there's no doubt that they "believed" in the Holy Spirit and so on and so forth. But it wasn't experiential. You don't get even a hint of leaning toward what we would today call Pentecostalism or the Charismatic. You don't get a hint of it. I find that interesting.
- 5.63** It's obvious, though, Bonhoeffer in his doctoral dissertation, *Sanctorum Communio*, he is still saying, though, that—what is the church? The church is God present on Earth. In other words, because of the Holy Spirit, we the Ecclesia, animated by the Holy Spirit, we're God's hands and feet here on the Earth. So he clearly recognized the reality of the Holy Spirit, the reality of God moving, but not in any ways that would seem particularly mystical.
- 5.64** But I think we've got to be clear—you couldn't do what he did, and I just was giving an example of it. He's being led by the Holy Spirit, and it's not only because of what the Scripture says. In other words, the Holy Spirit is not going to lead us contrary to what the Scriptures say. But at the same time, there are a lot of people familiar with the Scriptures who are not really being led by the Holy Spirit. There has to be an openness, a willingness, even a willingness to make mistakes. To say, I think God is leading me in this direction, and to trust God and to go in that direction.
- 5.65** There's a quote. It's not a Bonhoeffer quote, but it's really my quote, but it sums up Bonhoeffer's theology, where I guess I think I say, "Being a Christian is not so much about avoiding sin as it is about radically and obediently following the Holy Spirit"—and being obedient to God. In other words, a pietistic or religious view of the faith is, "I've got to avoid sin." Bonhoeffer, and I think any real, true, mature Christian says, "It's not about avoiding sin. It's about following God." In the course of following God, you will avoid sin, but you're getting it backwards because then it's just moralism. It's about avoiding sin.
- 5.66** You've got to be led by God. You've got to have a direct relationship with God, and that's what God wants for you. In the course of having that relationship with Him, communing with Him in prayer, inviting Him to lead you, you avoid sin. And if you make

a mistake, if you do something wrong, you look at God as a benevolent Father, and you ask him for grace, you understand that he's looking on your heart.

- 5.67** In other words, I think that a lot of people have a fear-based thing toward God. They think God is a harsh master. It's like the Scripture of the talents. You're a harsh master. I don't like you very much. You give me the talent, I'm going to bury the talent. When you come back, I'm like, "Here's what you gave me. Now leave me alone. I did my job." In other words, your view of God is negative, and God wants our view of him to be positive and to say that I'm going to take the talent and I'm going to do with it what I think might bless the master when he comes back. If I lose it, well, that's bad, but I think the master would rather that I try to bless him and to multiply the talent than to hide it.
- 5.68** This is a fundamental theme when we're thinking of Bonhoeffer, that he's radical in saying that I want to be led by God, which, of course, is being led by the Holy Spirit. I'm not afraid of making mistakes. I don't want to make a mistake. I don't take it lightly. But when he gets involved in the assassination, that's the classic example, and we'll get to that. But where he is really saying—I desire to do what God is calling me to do.
- 5.69** Even if I'm getting it wrong, I cast myself on the grace of God. He's a good God, and I would rather try to please him to the best of my ability. Even if I fail, I trust God. Rather than—I don't want to make any mistakes, better not get involved, better not get involved in the plot to kill Hitler because that's—he has an open-heartedness, which I think bespeaks his devotion to following the Holy Spirit. But you're right, you don't get ever in anything that I've seen from him, anything particularly mystical.
- 5.70** In the next lecture, I'll talk a little bit about that because— he would daily read the Moravian texts. They call them the Loosungen. As part of his devotions, the Moravians—I mentioned Zinzendorf and the Herrnhuter—they would publish, and they still to this day, publish daily Bible texts. He would read them every day. He would take it seriously—God is speaking to me through this text. That can become like using a Magic 8 Ball or like using the horoscope in the newspaper. What does it say today? What should I do today? Clearly, that's not the idea. But Bonhoeffer really was looking for God to lead him through these biblical texts. What is God saying to me?
- 5.71** I mentioned Zingst and Finkenwalde he was teaching these ordinands to meditate every day, every week, on a Bible text and to ask God to speak to them personally through that text, through the Word of God, through the Bible verse. That involves an element of what, on some level, seems mystical. How do you know God is speaking to you? He was trying to train them, teach your inner man to hear the voice of God. Some of us will hear it differently than others.
- 5.72** Joan of Arc hears it in a certain way that we might not. But I think God wants us to be ambitious. That's the Scripture, desire the spiritual gifts: "Lord, help me to hear more clearly." Some people have a particular gift in hearing. Some people don't. Some people

move in the gifts of the Spirit. Bonhoeffer doesn't seem to have done so, but I think he would be the first to say that he was led by the Holy Spirit, and particularly, as we'll get to in the next lecture, in big decisions. Really saying, "Lord, you have to speak. You have to speak. If you don't speak, I don't see the right answer in the book." You've got to speak to me individually. Final question?

5.73 Eric, is there any evidence that Dietrich was influenced by Hitler's writings? Did he get a head start in understanding the nature of evil? Because as you were mentioning, things were—morphed very quickly. The evil morphed very quickly. So when he penned the Jewish question—I don't know, any explicit evidence of Mein Kampf or aware of his writings?

5.74 As much as I would like to think that I know everything about Bonhoeffer, I know that I don't. Bonhoeffer wrote so much. There are like 16 volumes of his letters and diaries and writings or whatever. Then, of course, there's tons of stuff in his life that he didn't write about. It is my guess, my educated guess, that Mein Kampf comes out in the mid '20s, and that the Bonhoeffer family would have been very familiar with what it said.

5.75 I cannot recall any instance in which he refers to it. But as I said at some point earlier, the Bonhoeffer family knew better than almost anyone who Hitler was and who the Nazis were because they lived in Berlin at that time. They knew with whom he consorted with crazies and criminals. I mean, he surrounded himself by questionable figures, to put it really kindly. So they knew who he was, and I can only assume that they followed all of his speeches and that the Bonhoeffer family would have been familiar with Mein Kampf. But I can't offhand think of any example where he mentions this specifically. I think we'll leave it there. We'll see you in lecture number six.

Lecture 6: Bonhoeffer's Return

At a glance — Bonhoeffer's return to Germany.

- 6.1 Welcome to lecture number six, or as they say in Germany, Willkommen. Please come in. We're—it gets more and more exciting in good ways and bad ways. We come to the point now, I have to say, for me, this really grabbed me. When I first heard about Bonhoeffer in 1988, and my friend Ed told me that Bonhoeffer was speaking out against the Nazis, and then war was coming, and he decides that, "I can escape to America where I'll be safe." And he escapes to America and then decides, "No, I have to go back."
- 6.2 I was stunned at the courage involved in that. I thought what kind of a man is this? Who is this—that he would do this? And of course, knowing that he's eventually killed by the Nazis, it's a chilling thing. The chapter in my book, I call it "The Great Decision." It's 1939 when the war comes. It's just a major moment in his life. It's a major episode, and it bears explanation.
- 6.3 But before we get to that, we're still in 1938. This is when pretty much everyone knows, has known for some time, Hitler is bringing Germany to war, but now it's 1938, they can see it happening. There were many generals and others involved in the conspiracy against Hitler. Behind the scenes, they haven't done much about it yet. They're trying to figure out, what do we do? We cannot stand by while Hitler takes us into war. This is a suicide mission.
- 6.4 It was May 28th of 1938 that Hitler informs his military commanders of his plans to march into Czechoslovakia. Take it over. Compulsory civilian service was enacted in June, and throughout that summer of 1938, Germany leaned toward war. The time for the generals to stage their coup had arrived. That August, Ewald von Kleist-Schmenzin, whom we'll meet later related to the woman whom Bonhoeffer becomes engaged to Maria von Wedemeyer. He, Ewald von Kleist-Schmenzin, met with Winston Churchill, who was at that point still a member of Parliament, not the Prime Minister yet. But he met with him to discuss whether England could help the Germans in trying to bring about a new government.
- 6.5 You have Germans inside Germany jockeying to figure out, what are we going to do? Let's see if the English will help us. Again, this is a year before war comes. What was Hitler's—what was Churchill's response to this overture? "We will give you everything"—Churchill said—"but first bring us Hitler's head." The generals were working on that. We'll see how that plays out. But you could feel in Germany in 1938, things are coming to a head. The Leibholzes—you'll remember Bonhoeffer's twin sister Sabina marries Gerhard Leibholz, who is ethnically Jewish. He and Sabina and their two girls, who are also ethnically Jewish, think, "Is this the time for us to get out of Germany?"

- 6.6 They can see what is coming. If war comes, the borders are shut, you're trapped, you're a Jew in Germany, you'll never get out. You'll probably be sent to a death camp. Now, there were no death camps yet, but Bonhoeffer and his friend Eberhard Bethge help Gerhard and Sabina and the two girls escape. So they didn't know how long they would be away. They would essentially be away forever. We now know, but they didn't know how long they would be away. But people are getting out.
- 6.7 Now, I want to be clear, the army generals, so this is the German army, they were hoping that Hitler would march on Czechoslovakia. Why? They thought it was so patently crazy that it would give them the opportunity they'd been waiting for for some time. Their plans were to seize Hitler and take over the government. They had a number of plans. One was to declare Hitler insane and unfit for leadership. The first piece of evidence would be his insistence on invading Czechoslovakia, which pretty much everybody knew is suicide for Germany if he does it in 1938.
- 6.8 But the German generals also had connections to a highly esteemed German psychiatrist who happened to share their diagnosis of the nation's leader and who also shared their political views. His name was Karl Bonhoeffer. This is Dietrich Bonhoeffer's father, once again, ready to weigh in to offer his expert testimony, if possible. But we know that didn't happen. Later on in 1938, famously, November 9th, 1938, today we call it Kristallnacht, happens.
- 6.9 Bonhoeffer, at that time, now, just to be clear, so he'd been spending most of his time, '35, '36, '37, '38 in Pomerania, so quite far away from Berlin. November 9th, 1938, Kristallnacht happens, and Bonhoeffer reads in his Bible that day, Psalm 74. He happened to be meditating on that text. We mentioned at the end of the last lecture that Bonhoeffer every day would meditate on these Moravian Loosungen. These are Bible texts that they would give out every day.
- 6.10 The text for this day happens to be Psalm 74. And it says in German, "Sie verbrennen alle Häuser Gottes im Lande" — "They burn all of God's houses in the land." Kristallnacht has just happened. What happens on Kristallnacht? Synagogues are burned. Houses of God are burned. That day, Bonhoeffer reads, "Sie verbrennen alle Häuser Gottes im Lande." He reads this, the second half of verse 8 in Psalm 74. He believes, and this gets back to a question at the end of the last session, he believes the Holy Spirit is speaking to him. He believes God is speaking to him right now and to the Christians in Germany and telling him something through the text.
- 6.11 In other words, he's not just reading the text and goes—here's a great text. He's saying, "God is speaking to me and to the Christians in Germany through this piece of Psalm 74"—that what has just happened throughout Germany is the houses of God are being burned. So Bonhoeffer is in a slightly different way than he has heretofore, making a connection between the Jews, the people of God, the chosen people, and the church. He's basically saying burning the synagogues—this attack on the Jews is an attack on the people of God. It is an attack on any people of God—on Christians, on Jews.

- 6.12** He really perceives this clearly in this way for the first time. I forget which friend of his said it—that Bonhoeffer never wrote in his Bible, but with a pencil, he made a mark a vertical line next to this part in his Bible, and he wrote 9/ 11/38. In Europe, they put the month second. We would say 11/9/ 38. But it says, "They burn all of God's houses in the land." And he writes the date of Kristallnacht. Here it is. He's making this dramatic connection that the Jews in Germany were God's beloved children. So for him, it was a real revelation at that moment.
- 6.13** Well, so okay, we've said war is coming. It's clearer and clearer and clearer. I should say that Bonhoeffer, I hadn't said it up till now, but he has been involved in the wider conspiracy against Adolf Hitler. In other words, since 1933, when Hitler takes power, since before 1933, the Bonhoeffer family is a center of resistance. They have friends in elite circles, their own family, their sons-in-law are elite figures in government in the Justice Department of Germany at that time, they know what's going on, and they're having conversations about—what do we do? What do we do?
- 6.14** Their house was—they were having these secret conversations—they would often close the door so that the maids would not hear what they're saying. I haven't mentioned this, but this is going on through the '30s that these conversations are happening. They know where they stand. This is the whole family, not just Dietrich Bonhoeffer. Bonhoeffer, Dietrich Bonhoeffer, is involved in many of these conversations. He's clearly tracking with them. He doesn't say, "Oh, we just got to follow the government"—Romans 13. He doesn't say, "Oh, it's not for us to be political." He's right there with them. He's giving them moral justification for what they're doing.
- 6.15** But he's, of course, not yet officially involved. Even before he officially joins the conspiracy, he's providing counsel to them, to his brother-in-law, Hans von Dohnanyi, who's a major figure in the Abwehr. The Abwehr is German military intelligence. So Bonhoeffer is not quite sure what he's going to do. It's 1938. His options are being winnowed down. The noose is tightening. What to do? What to do? What to do? The war is coming. He's not quite ready to officially enter the conspiracy. Before that happens, he goes to America.
- 6.16** Okay. Why does he go to America? He wrote a letter to his friend in London, Bishop Bell. He writes, "I am thinking of leaving Germany sometime. The main reason is the compulsory military service to which the men of my age"—born in 1906—"will be called up this year." He knows now this is in '38 already, there's a compulsory military service. Now, I guess, '39, it's going to be his turn. What does he do? The war is coming, he's going to be drafted. He writes, "It seems to me conscientiously impossible to join in a war under the present circumstances."
- 6.17** I have to explain this. He's processing this. He's not a pacifist. We've established that. He doesn't say war is wrong or it's wrong to fight in a war. No. But this war, Hitler's war, a war of aggression, he knows he cannot participate. He goes on in this letter to Bishop

Bell, "On the other hand, the Confessing Church"—these are all his friends— "as such has not taken any definite attitude in this respect and probably cannot take it as things are. So I should cause a tremendous damage to my brethren if I would make a stand on this point"—he means a public stand—"which would be regarded by the regime"—the Nazis—"as typical of the hostility of our church toward the state."

- 6.18** So again, he's still worried about what they think. He's playing this game. He feels that he can say I'm not going to fight in the war. But if he does that, all of the members of the Confessing Church are going to be tagged with, "Oh, your leader is telling you you shouldn't be a patriotic German." So he writes, "Perhaps the worst thing of all is the military oath which I should have to swear. So I am rather puzzled in this situation, and perhaps even more because I feel it is really only on Christian grounds that I find it difficult to do military service under the present conditions, and yet there are only few friends who would approve of my attitude."
- 6.19** So this is amazing. I just find him—he's writing this letter to Bishop Bell. He's reasoning with him like—I'm not sure what to do. And it seems clear to me that on Christian grounds, I could not participate in Hitler's aggressive war, but many Christians, including in the Confessing Church, would not agree with him. They're like, "What are you talking about? We're patriotic Germans. Yeah, we've got problems with Hitler, but we go to war. Of course, we have to go to war."
- 6.20** He says, "In spite of much reading and thinking concerning this matter, I have not yet made up my mind what I would do under different circumstances. But actually, as things are, I should have to do violence to my Christian conviction, if I would take up arms here and now. I had been thinking of going to the Mission Field, not as an escape out of the situation, but because I wish to serve somewhere where service is really wanted."
- 6.21** "But here also, the German foreign exchange situation makes it impossible to send workers abroad. With respect to British Missionary Societies, I have no idea of the possibilities there. On the other hand, I still have the great desire to serve the Confessing Church as long as I possibly could. This is a classic case. He does not know what he's going to do. He's asking God to lead him. Again, he's asking the Holy Spirit, "Lead me, Lord. I want to do what you want me to do, but I don't know what you want me to do."
- 6.22** Finally, a number of his friends in America, friends that he made in '30 and '31, they have been trying to figure out. They know this guy is in trouble. He's been outspoken. If the war comes and he's a conscientious objector, whatever it is, he's going to end up in a concentration camp. We need to help him. A number of them do what they can. They pull strings. They try to figure out—how can we get him here? So they offer him, I forget the details—obviously, I hope you'll read my book and get the details. But number one, he has some affiliation with Union Theological Seminary. He can lecture at

Union Theological Seminary. So somebody like Reinhold Niebuhr is going to pull some strings, come over.

- 6.23** Now, he has to do this before the war starts. This is the summer of 1939, spring/summer of 1939. The war doesn't start till the end of August-September. He doesn't know when the war starts, but he knows that if he's going to get out of Germany, he needs to get out before it starts because once it starts, it's over. Reinhold Niebuhr invites him to Union. His friend Paul Lehmann, this is one of the four friends that he makes at Union in 1930 and '31. He had all kinds of connections. He writes letters all across America trying to get Bonhoeffer lecturing offers.
- 6.24** Henry Leiper, who is in New York City, he's, I think, with the World Council of Churches or whatever it was called before it was called that, invites him to give him a job. Bonhoeffer is persuaded by all of his dear friends in Germany, so his closest circle of friends, Eberhard Bethge and all of those students in Finkenwalde, these people with whom he's come close, they persuade him, "You need to go to America. You're going to be in danger here. This will preserve your life. Then when the war is over, you can help us rebuild Germany."
- 6.25** Right before he leaves, it's a real window. Again, there are more details in my book, but just to give you a little picture, he's puzzling through everything simultaneously. He knows that members of his family and others are involved in the plot to kill Hitler. This is on the table already. Bonhoeffer, at some point, right before he leaves for America, he's meeting with his students. One of his friends, one of these students, Otto Dutzus, remembers that he says, "We talked about how to continue his work and the work of Finkenwalde after he leaves for America."
- 6.26** The seminary was outlawed, as we know, but it existed illegally in the forms of these underground meetings. Dutzus says, "We spoke about how that should be pursued, discussed many necessary things with each other. At some point during the discussion"—Bonhoeffer—"asked us quite unexpectedly if we would grant absolution to the murderer of a tyrant." Just out of the blue, he's like—he throws out this philosophical question. "What do you think, guys? Let's put our heads together. What does the Scripture say? What do you think? If somebody's involved in the plot to kill a tyrant (Adolf Hitler), would God say that's okay?" He's clearly been thinking about this for some time. At this time, no one but Eberhard Bethge knew of Bonhoeffer's role in the resistance, that his family is having these conversations.
- 6.27** Later on, Bonhoeffer would use the example of a drunken driver killing pedestrians on a main street like the Kurfurstendamm in Berlin. Bonhoeffer said, "It would be the responsibility of everyone to do all they could to stop that driver from killing more people." It's the classic case. Bonhoeffer brings us up a few times. There's a driver driving down a main road, killing people deliberately with the car. What is your responsibility as a human being, as a Christian? If you could shoot that driver and prevent that driver from killing more pedestrians, is it the right thing to do? He's

thinking about this. Bonhoeffer, again, is thinking about the ethics of all this stuff. He doesn't have easy answers, but neither does he shrink from asking the questions.

- 6.28** In any event, on June 4th, 1939, Bonhoeffer sails for America. The plans are for him to stay two or three years, to be out of harm's way. As I said, many people pulled a lot of strings for this to happen. His colleagues in Germany pushed him to accept this. He accepts it. He gets on the boat. No sooner is he on the boat than he's troubled. This is an amazing thing. This is leading up to this big decision, what to do. No sooner does he get on the boat with the plan I'm going to be there two or three years than he's already feeling unsettled. He's asking the question, again, this gets to the question of, "Is God speaking to me? Is this just my emotions? What's going on?" But he doesn't quite feel right. He doesn't feel like, "Yes, God has called me to leave." He's starting to feel like, "Did I make a mistake? What's going on? What's going on?"
- 6.29** So he arrives June 12th, and it's a strange experience that he has in New York at this time. We just did a Bonhoeffer New York tour recently that I led. We videotaped a lot of it. To go to these spots where Bonhoeffer was in 1939 and to try to think what he's thinking. The overall picture you get is of somebody who is at odds with his situation. He arrives at a time when all his old buddies are not in New York. He's lost. He wanders New York like a ghost, almost, like he's divided from himself. It's like his real self is left back in Germany with the brethren.
- 6.30** He's clearly confused. He's really wondering—maybe I made a mistake. Maybe I shouldn't stay more than a year. He makes that statement. I forget if he makes it to Reinhold Niebuhr or to Henry Leiper, who's the head of the National—I always forget the name of the organization, but it's like the National Council of Churches today—but what there was, it was this ecumenical thing.
- 6.31** But they were shocked. They're like a year? We just like we've made all these plans for you to be here 2-3 years, and we think the world of you as a theologian. We're thrilled to have you and stuff. But he already, no soon as he's there, just a couple of days, he's like, "No, maybe I'll stay a year." Every day passes, he becomes more uncomfortable and is shortening his trip further. He's beginning to think, "Well, maybe not a year, maybe just till the end of this year, maybe six months, maybe"—he's clearly troubled.
- 6.32** So he starts reading again. I shouldn't say he starts reading. He's always reading the text. He's reading the Bible text of the day and trying to puzzle out "What is God saying to me?" He really expects to hear from God. Now, again, this goes way back to in the early '30s, he has this practice of meditating on the Scriptures and saying, God, speak to me through the Scriptures. On June 24th, he reads Isaiah 28:16. It says, "The one who believes does not flee." He thinks, "It seems that God is speaking to me. God is saying that if you really believe, you do not flee." You ought not to have fled Germany.
- 6.33** Two days later, he reads 2 Timothy 4, "Do thy diligence to come before winter." This is Paul speaking to Timothy: "Come before winter." Timothy, in this case, is to share the

suffering of the apostle, not to be ashamed, come before winter. So Bonhoeffer is thinking, is God speaking to me? Should I go home before winter? He also is trying to puzzle that, and this is, again—this is why I love Bonhoeffer and why I recommend him to everyone because he is really being rigorous about thinking, what is the will of God? He doesn't have easy religious answers. A lot of people who call themselves Christians have very easy, hidebound religious answers.

- 6.34** Bonhoeffer says, no, I've got to wrestle with God. I've really got to ask, what is the Lord saying? Maybe the Lord is saying something I don't want to hear. For example, he's even asking, and this is something I think a lot of Christians say, "God said this to me or God said that to me." You get some Christians that don't believe God speaks. Then you have Christians that think God speaks when he didn't speak. It was their emotions. Bonhoeffer is trying to determine, "Is this my emotions? Am I just homesick for Germany and my emotions are leading me back to Germany? Or is this God speaking?"
- 6.35** But then he says—he writes, "God acts not only by means of pious emotions, but also through vital ones." In other words, his homesickness for Germany, which he feels intensely in New York during this time, he thinks, yes, it's perfectly possible for God to speak through me through my natural homesickness, that this homesickness I'm experiencing is God speaking to me through my emotions. But he takes all of this seriously. He doesn't have easy answers. He's trying to figure it out.
- 6.36** The days pass, he's in New York, and as I said, every day that passes, he thinks more and more, okay, "I'm going to go back in August. I'm going to go back in September. I'm going to go back in August." He has an important lunch with this figure, Henry Leiper at the National Arts Club on Gramercy Park. We were just there as part of this Bonhoeffer tour. We just sat in the very room under the same tiled ceiling. It was the Samuel Tilden mansion on Gramercy Park. It's now the National Arts Club. We were just there in the very room.
- 6.37** Bonhoeffer has lunch in this room with Henry Leiper, and he says in his diary that day, "The decision has been made. I have refused"—in other words, I'm not accepting this gracious invitation. I'm going back. He writes, "They were clearly disappointed, and rather upset. It probably means more for me than I can see at the moment. God alone knows what." You're not kidding, right? It's a big deal. He's decided he's going to go back.
- 6.38** In the end, his brother Karl-Friedrich, we mentioned he spent a lot of time in America. Karl-Friedrich is going back to Germany. He comes, I think, from Chicago through New York. Bonhoeffer hangs out with him on July 4th. They go to Radio City Music Hall. They go to the Empire State Building, and they're going to get on a ship in three days. Bonhoeffer has decided that after 26 days, he's going back. It's an amazing thing. First three years, then maybe two, one, maybe by winter. Suddenly, 26 days after he arrives in New York, he gets on a ship to go back. So it's a big deal.

- 6.39 He writes a letter to Reinhold Niebuhr. Now, Niebuhr is this major figure at Union and in America. He writes, "I've had the time to think and pray about my situation and that of my nation and to have God's will for me clarified. I have come to the conclusion that I have made a mistake in coming to America. I must live through this difficult period of our national history with the Christian people of Germany. I shall have no right to participate in the reconstruction of Christian life in Germany after the war if I do not share the trials of this time with my people.
- 6.40 My brother in the Confessing Synod wanted me to go to America. They may have been right in urging me to do so, but I was wrong in going. Such a decision each man must make for himself. Christians in Germany will face the terrible alternative of either willing the defeat of their nation in order that Christian civilization may survive or willing the victory of their nation and thereby destroying our civilization. I know which of these alternatives I must choose, but I cannot make that choice in security." It's absolutely extraordinary. He makes this decision.
- 6.41 I want to say quickly, one Sunday that Bonhoeffer was in New York, while he's trying to figure this out before he makes the decision, he decides to visit Riverside Church. Now, Riverside Church was the center of what we would call ultra-liberal theology. But Bonhoeffer really believes God can speak through anything and through anyone, and I'm just going to go there.
- 6.42 He writes in his diary that the sermon was "quite unbearable." He says, "The whole thing, the whole service was a respectable, self-indulgent, self-satisfied religious celebration. This idolatrous religion stirs up the flesh, which is accustomed to being kept in check by the word of God. Such sermons make for libertinism, egotism, indifference. Do people not know that one can get on as well, even better, without religion?"
- 6.43 So he goes to this church while he's in New York trying to puzzle this out, thinking, "Oh, God can speak to me. I'll go to—" and he is just disgusted. He says the preacher spoke from James, not the Book of James, but from the American philosopher, Henry James. He was really scandalized. This was the worst example of bad American liberal theology. Later that day, the same day, he walked seven blocks south on Broadway because he was staying at Union Theological Seminary for these 20-something days. He walks down to a church headed by Dr. Macomb, a pastor known as an "arch-fundamentalist." Again, you see this battle in America between Fosdick and the theological liberals about whom we talked in discussing Bonhoeffer's year in New York in '30 and '31 and how they hated the fundamentalist.
- 6.44 So Bonhoeffer goes to Riverside, is really disgusted, writes about it in his diary, and later the same day goes down the block, goes down Broadway, seven blocks to the church of Dr. Macomb, this arch-fundamentalist. Of course, he's just an actual Christian, a Presbyterian, but he's derided by the theological liberal as an arch-fundamentalist. And Bonhoeffer writes, "Now the day has had a good ending. I went to

church again. It is a great help after a couple of quite lonely days to go into church and there pray together, sing together, listen together. The sermon was astonishing on our 'likeness with Christ'. A completely biblical sermon. The sections on, 'we are blameless like Christ' and 'we are tempted like Christ' were particularly good."

- 6.45 So Bonhoeffer here is openly identifying with the "fundamentalists," the born-again believers of 1939 in America and against the theological liberals. That, for many, many years, really until the publication of my book, it was unclear where Bonhoeffer stood. But when you read his words in many cases, but in this case, particularly dramatically, the contrast, it couldn't be clearer. Bonhoeffer goes on to write in his diary, referring to Macombe's church, he declared, "This will one day be a center of resistance when Riverside Church has long since become a temple of Baal. I was very glad about this sermon. This sermon opened up to me an America, of which I was quite ignorant before." We'll remember that he had only seen anything like this in the Black churches. He was really thrilled to experience this, and he wrote about it.
- 6.46 In any case, we know he goes back to Germany. Basically, when he arrives in Germany, he shocks his friends. They cannot believe—what are you doing here? They're just wondering, what in the world? We all prayed for you to leave and to go and whatever. I'm not sure quite where it is, but they're questioning him like—we're just shocked to see you. Why are you back here a month after we said goodbye? It says Bonhoeffer calmly lit a cigarette and said, "I made a mistake in going to America." That's that.
- 6.47 Okay, so Bonhoeffer is back in Germany. Now what? That's always the question. Now what? Well, that's where it gets even more interesting. Bonhoeffer isn't sure exactly what to do. It's hard for us to know what conversations he's having with his family. I quote a lot of that in my book, but you still aren't 100% sure how that plays out. But he is clearly thinking on a complex deep level about what is ethical, what is the right thing to do.
- 6.48 He's somehow involved in this conspiracy, as we've said. But here's where it gets interesting, at least for me. I'm reading from my book: "It must have been sometime during this period that his sister-in-law, Emmi Bonhoeffer"—this is the wife of his brother Klaus—"provocatively tried to prod him toward more serious involvement. Neither Emmi nor Klaus was a Christian, so it was inevitable that when her husband, Klaus, was risking his life, she might think of her pastor brother-in-law, as being too comfortably above the fray."
- 6.49 "Perhaps he had the tendency to be so spiritually minded that he was no earthly good. Emmi thought enough of Dietrich to share her thoughts directly. She says, 'You Christians are glad when someone else does what you know must be done. But it seems that somehow you are unwilling to get your own hands dirty and do it.' She wasn't suggesting Bonhoeffer become an assassin, but his involvement was not what her husband's or Dohnanyi's was. Bonhoeffer carefully considered what she'd said. He

said to her that no one should be glad that anyone was killing anyone else, and yet he knew what she was getting at. She had a point. Still, he wasn't decided on what to do."

- 6.50** You can really see him now being challenged by a member of his own family. The reason I quote this, the reason I put it in my book is because you hear this over and over with Bonhoeffer. We've already heard it. He is—he sees non-Christians doing the right thing and the church sometimes doing nothing. Now he looks at himself and he says, "Am I guilty of this? Am I guilty of hanging back when God would call me to do something?" He'd been thinking about this for years, let's be clear.
- 6.51** His friend, Eberhard Bethge, writes that "Bonhoeffer, in 1935"—so four years earlier—"introduced us to the problem of what we today call political resistance. The levels of confession"—and again, confession is saying, I'm a Christian. I believe in what the Bible says—"the levels of confession and of resistance, so political resistance, could no longer be kept neatly apart. The escalating persecution of the Jews"—and again, that's 1935—"generated an increasingly intolerable situation"—especially for Bonhoeffer. "We now realized that mere confession, no matter how courageous, inescapably meant complicity with the murderers, even though there would always be new acts of refusing to be co-opted, and even though we would preach Christ alone Sunday after Sunday. During the whole time, the Nazi State never considered it necessary to prohibit such preaching. Why should it?"
- 6.52** We said this earlier when Hitler says, "You just stick to your sermons." Think about it. He's saying, "Go ahead. We're not going to forbid you from preaching your little sermons. They're meaningless." In other words, unless your sermons are incendiary, leading your people to take action against the state, which they should have been doing, we have no problem with it. You want to talk about Jesus, blah, blah, blah. Who cares? We're not threatened by that. It's a fascinating thing. Bonhoeffer is facing this. Eberhard Bethge is thinking about this. It's like, "Yeah, go preach your sermons."
- 6.53** So Bethge says, "Thus, we were approaching the border between confession and resistance; and if we did not cross this border, our confession was going to be no better than cooperation with the criminals. And so it became clear where the problem lay for the Confessing Church: we were resisting by way of confession, but we were not confessing by way of resistance."
- 6.54** In other words, at some point, your talk becomes meaningless. At some point, your actions will show what you actually believe. Bethge understands that they're getting to that point. They're getting to that point. Now, Bonhoeffer, it's 1939, he comes back to Germany, and his sister-in-law puts it to him like, "Okay, you don't have a problem giving moral support to my husband who's risking his life and getting involved in a conspiracy to kill Hitler. What about you, pastor?" It's pretty extraordinary.
- 6.55** At this point, and this is a little complicated, but we should say Bonhoeffer's brother-in-law, Hans von Dohnanyi—this is his elder sister Christine's husband—is very involved in

the Abwehr. The Abwehr is German military intelligence. The Abwehr— it's kind of like if you're talking about the CIA or the FBI—it had its own jurisdiction, German military intelligence than the Gestapo. They had their own carve-out, that they could do their own thing. The Abwehr, German military intelligence, was a center of the conspiracy against Adolf Hitler.

- 6.56** What's Bonhoeffer going to do? He's in Germany. The war is coming. His brother-in-law suggests to him, "What if you come to work for me in the Abwehr?" In other words, the war is coming. The narrative we'll put out is, listen, you came to your senses, Germany is at war. You can serve Germany better as a member of the Abwehr. So the title of my book is Pastor, Martyr, Prophet, Spy. This is where the spy part comes in. You—Dietrich Bonhoeffer, theologian, pastor—you will come to work for the Abwehr.
- 6.57** You've got cover so that you can travel to neutral countries. You can look like you're helping Hitler and the Nazis by officially becoming a member of the Abwehr. If you work as a member of the Abwehr, you're not going to have to go to the front lines. You're not going to have to pick up a rifle. You can be much more effective. That'll be the word we put out, that you're now—that war has come—you're going to join the German effort by working undercover for the Abwehr. But what you're really going to be doing—follow this—you're going to actually be working with us in the Abwehr against Hitler and the Nazis. This is a couple of levels of deception. This is confusing. This is complicated.
- 6.58** Bonhoeffer understands that this is an option for him right now because— we've said it earlier—if he says, I'm not going to fight in the war, it's going to tag everybody in the Confessing Church as not patriotic. So he's not telling them not to fight in the war. But what is he going to do? So he decides to escape to America. Now he's come back. Now what's he going to do? The offer by his brother-in-law to work in the Abwehr, to officially join this conspiracy against Hitler, but with the cover of—you're a good German, working for German military intelligence. It's a time of war. We can use you. You have tremendous contacts around Europe.
- 6.59** I mentioned before, he had ecumenical contacts with Bishop Bell, with others. I didn't mention before, but he made trips to Sweden with his ordinands. He knew people all around Europe in the church. The official story is you're going to be used by the Abwehr, use all these connections to further Germany's interests. But we really know you're going to be working against Hitler, against the Nazis from within. This is pretty dramatic. He becomes a spy.
- 6.60** He couldn't tell everybody about this, obviously. Most of his friends, he couldn't tell them, "Oh, by the way, I'm a spy now." So it's a tricky thing. On top of it, as part of the game, he continues to work as a pastor. That's part of his official cover, right? Okay, you're working for—it's like if somebody says, "Okay, you're going to work for the CIA, so you're going to be an English teacher in whatever, someplace in the world. You're going to be an English teacher, but we know you're not really an English teacher. You're

really working for the CIA." Bonhoeffer is like, "Yeah, I'm going to be a pastor. I'm going to be traveling around doing pastoral stuff, but we all know I'm actually working for German military intelligence. I'm actually a spy." Then we know what he's actually doing is not being a spy on behalf of the Nazis, but against the Nazis. It's a little complicated.

- 6.61** To give you an example, February 24th of 1940, I think it's 1940, the Abwehr sent him to Geneva, Switzerland. Of course, the war has now started. Switzerland is neutral. Bonhoeffer was sent there to make contact with Protestant leaders outside Germany to let them know about the conspiracy against Hitler and to ask them to put out feelers about peace terms with the government that would take over. In other words, if they managed to kill Hitler, will these other governments work with Bonhoeffer, Dohnanyi, those who were in the conspiracy to kill Hitler? Will these governments work with the conspirators? That's a big part of what he was doing.
- 6.62** When Bonhoeffer gets to the border of Switzerland, the Swiss border police had a problem. They insisted that someone inside Switzerland vouch for Bonhoeffer entering the country. Who does Bonhoeffer come up with? Karl Barth, who has now moved to Switzerland because he opposed the Nazis, so now he's safely in Switzerland. Bonhoeffer calls Karl Barth, but Karl Barth was like, "What are you doing working for the Abwehr? You're working for the Nazis? What are you doing?"
- 6.63** Bonhoeffer, more and more and more, finds himself misunderstood. He is playing to the audience of one: to God. He's doing his best to follow the leading of the Holy Spirit, to follow God's leading, not sure that he's right, but better than do nothing, which is what a lot of the Christians are doing. Of course, he has a problem with his friend, Karl Barth. But things are so bad in Germany that he knows he has to do something.
- 6.64** In 1942, he visits Bishop Bell, remember the English Bishop Bell in Sweden. He manages to pull that off. He's trying to get word to Bishop Bell that Bishop Bell would get word to Anthony Eden, the foreign minister under Churchill, about the conspiracy. He's being used by the Abwehr, to try to get word to the enemy, to England, that there are Germans inside Germany plotting against Hitler. Will you, Winston Churchill, help us? In a nutshell: no. By this point, Churchill and Anthony Eden really are not interested. It doesn't work for them. There's a lot more to that, I won't get into it.
- 6.65** We know eventually Bonhoeffer is arrested. We'll get to that in the next lecture. But I want to say, why was he arrested? Let's be clear. He's arrested for his involvement in something called Operation 7. What is Operation 7? As part of working for the Abwehr, Bonhoeffer has an opportunity to get seven Jews out of Germany and into Switzerland. He goes to work on that. He's trying to save the lives of seven Jews. The number increases to 14 Jews, but it's still called Operation 7.
- 6.66** It was a little complicated. The Swiss who were neutral which should make you want to spit if you think about the concept of being neutral with regard to Adolf Hitler. They

had a price. They said, "Oh, you want us to take these Jews into Switzerland? Well, you've got to secure some foreign currency. These men and women won't be able to work in this country, so we have a price here. We need money." The Swiss needs some money. Bonhoeffer and others, in the course of getting this money, this foreign currency, suddenly now the Gestapo is tipped off. Suddenly, the hardcore Nazis are tipped off. Something's funny going on with the Abwehr. What is this financial irregularity?

- 6.67** The Gestapo and others were always suspicious of the Abwehr. Now they think we caught something. We found something funny. That eventually leads to Bonhoeffer's arrest and the arrest of Dohnanyi and others. But it's not an arrest for his involvement in the plot to kill Hitler, you understand? It is much more benign than that. It's just some financial irregularities, as we'll find out in the next lecture. He goes to military prison. He's treated fairly well. He has hopes of getting out, of beating the rap. We know that doesn't happen exactly. But it's very different from what you would expect—like, oh! Bonhoeffer is caught involved in the conspiracy to kill Hitler. Nobody knows about the conspiracy to kill Hitler until July 20th, 1944, when the Stauffenberg plot goes awry. That is when finally the Nazis realize, oh—they've been trying to kill Hitler.
- 6.68** I think I will leave it there. We have time for a question or two. I had one other quote I wanted to read. Henning von Tresckow, one of the figures who's involved in the plot—just to show the urgency of those who knew what was going on in Germany. He said, "The German people will be burdened with a guilt the world will not forget in a hundred years." That's prophetic. That's true. What they did— we are how many years later? It's getting close to 100 years. What do we think of when we think of Germany? This is the first thing we think of. The pressure to act to do something, it was felt by many. Bonhoeffer, of course, was right in the center of that. In the next two lectures, we'll find out what else happens.
- 6.69** It sounds like Bonhoeffer had done his best to stay under the radar as best as possible, but at any point was his family completely targeted, financially, legally, for anything that he was participating in during this time?
- 6.70** As you'll see in the next two lectures, they were able to stay under the radar for a very long time. It is amazing. It's really amazing. But again, this is very, very high-stakes poker. To be a high member of the Abwehr, his brother-in-law, Hans von Dohnanyi, he's a major figure. There were all kinds of folks like this involved in the conspiracy, they were extremely careful. It shows you how things are never black and white. In other words, we think like Hitler takes power and everybody who disagrees with him goes to jail and is killed. No, there still was this semblance of legality, this fiction of legality.
- 6.71** I mean, even when Bonhoeffer is murdered, at the end of his life, they have this military court and documents. In other words, they still presented this fiction that we're living under laws and that you've broken laws and you must be executed for the laws.

You see this over and over now. Of course, they didn't do this with the Jews. They didn't do this in Poland. They thought we're under its war, so we can kill. There's a quote. I think I had it on the board earlier—y eah, there it is. Just to give you a picture. On the one hand, they pretend that we're a nation of laws. But when it comes to the war, Hitler said, "You can't wage war with Salvation Army methods." Think of the cynicism of this.

6.72 In other words, when it comes to the war, they are murdering people. Forget about the death camps. We're just talking about they march into Poland and they murder people. They don't just say well, we're going to capture prisoners of war. The SS squads, the death squads, they're murdering people, not just Jews, military leaders. It's hard to take in. Again, the details of a lot of this are in my book. Chilling. It's absolutely chilling. On the one hand, they have this fiction that we're following the rules and we're doing the right thing. So that gave Bonhoeffer and others significant maneuverability, even after he'd been in prison, that there's some legality to it. But anyway, we see the limits to that. One more question before we end.

6.73 Dietrich's dad, Karl—great moral clarity, intellect, right diagnosis with regard to the insanity of Hitler. I'm just curious, your thoughts with regard to Dietrich and his dad's relationship. I can't help but think his dad was, needless to say, a huge influence, obviously, but an encouragement to him, diagnosing the times in which he lived. Just any thoughts about his relationship with his dad?

6.74 There's no doubt that he had a tremendous relationship with his father. Again, this is what's so beautiful, is to see a family operating the way they did, the love and respect they had for each other, the culture of the family. It's just undeniably beautiful. It's one of the reasons that in the beginning of my book, I devote so much time to the family because you have to appreciate how beautiful that is, how rare that is, and how much it meant. And think about it, at the end of the war, Dietrich is executed. His brother Klaus is executed, and two of his brothers-in-law are executed. In other words, in Nazi Germany, to be given all the advantages that the Bonhoeffer family had and to live the right way meant, probably, giving your life.

6.75 But Karl Bonhoeffer, the father, wrote a letter sometime in the summer after the death of his two sons-in-law and his two sons. He says something like, "We are sad but proud." Proud. We're proud. They did the right thing. Now, here's a man, we don't know where he stands on faith, but has enough wisdom and enough understanding of reality to say it is worth living in the right way, even if it leads to death. Rather that you would live that a life, then shrink from doing what is right and preserve your life. The secular scientist, Karl Bonhoeffer, gets that. Many Christians don't get that. That's why the story of Bonhoeffer in so many ways in his life and his theology is a rebuke to Christians who don't actually live out the faith that they claim to have.

6.76 It's why Bonhoeffer had so much respect for people outside of the faith. I didn't mention Gandhi, but he was looking at Gandhi, wanted to visit Gandhi in India and

thinking—these pagans, like Gandhi, seem to get a lot of this stuff better than the Christians do. God shames us. He wanted to spend time with Gandhi at some point. He doesn't do that. But this theme happens over and over again.

6.77 It's like when he's in Karl Barth's seminar in 1931, and he quotes Luther that sometimes the curses of the godless are, I don't remember exact quote, but are better than the hallelujahs of the pious. This theme happens over and over and over again. The way his non-believing family members behaved is a perfect example of that and should be an example to all of us. It's why I push the story of Bonhoeffer as I do. The church needs to deal with these issues. It's very, very important now as it was then.

6.78 So thank you very much.

Lecture 7: In the Face of Evil

At a glance — In the face of evil.

- 7.1 Welcome to lecture number seven, or as they say in Germany, Sieben. Thank you very much. This is one of the more fun topics when you're talking about Bonhoeffer. The title chapter for where we begin today, Chapter 26, is "Bonhoeffer in Love." It's a beautiful story. We'll also get to Bonhoeffer's arrest, which happens during this time, but just to paint the picture. We said at the end of the last course, Bonhoeffer is effectively acting as a spy. He's working for the Abwehr. He's just traveled to Sweden to make contact with Bishop Bell of England.
- 7.2 So he's surreptitiously making contact with the enemy because this is the middle of the war. It's 1942, June. Obviously, if he's caught doing anything like this, he's a dead man. This is really high-stakes stuff what he's doing. This has been going on for some time. I haven't given too many details just because of the time I hope you'll read about it. It's really fascinating. But right now, Bonhoeffer has just come back from Sweden to Germany.
- 7.3 What I haven't really said much either, because I don't want to complicate things, but I mentioned when Bonhoeffer started teaching these ordinands in 1935 at Zingst and Finkenwalde in this illegal seminary for the Confessing Church, all of this takes place in Pomerania. This takes place in, again, today it would be part of Poland, but it is to the northeast of Berlin. So it's quite far from Berlin. While he's there, he's spending years there now because now it's 1942. He starts there in '35. He's making friends there, whatever. When the Gestapo shuts down Finkenwalde, he continues doing the same thing in an underground way. So he's spending tons of time in this area, '38, '39, '40, '41. He's working for the Abwehr, but he's still doing pastoral work there—because remember, his cover as a member of German military intelligence, is that, "Oh, I'm a pastor. I'm doing pastoral work."
- 7.4 So he spends a lot of time up there, and he gets to know the people of that area. These are the so-called Junkers. This is the the landed aristocracy of that area. They were profoundly conservative. It's many members of the Prussian military class. It's just a part of the world, a part of Germany that's very traditional, very Christian. Bonhoeffer is up there at Finkenwalde, preaching, and he meets Ruth von Kleist-Retzow.
- 7.5 I don't know if I've mentioned her before. He meets her. She's 68-70. She is really the matriarch of this extraordinary family. She falls in love with Bonhoeffer. He's the greatest thing she's ever seen. She goes—she drags her grandchildren to hear him preach every Sunday at Finkenwalde at the services, and really forms a friendship with him and asks him—I can't remember if I mentioned it earlier—asks him to catechize her grandkids to prepare them for confirmation. She has a number of grandchildren.

- 7.6 Bonhoeffer takes this on. Now, imagine being mentored in the faith by Dietrich Bonhoeffer. So this grandmother who's very smart, educated, cultured, she knows that this is going to be the greatest thing for her grandchildren to hear about the faith from Dietrich Bonhoeffer. So Bonhoeffer agrees to do this, and this goes over some time. He gets to know the family very well. He gets to know Ruth von Kleist-Retzow's daughter and husband, gets to know the family, obviously gets to know the kids because he's spending time with them. Max is one of the elder boys.
- 7.7 There's an 11-year-old that he meets Maria von Wedemeyer. He rejects her. It's like she's too young and silly. I'm not going to spend time giving her the download on the Christian faith. I don't know that she's there yet. He rejects her. Anyway, the years pass. I mentioned this started in 1935-'36. He's spending a lot of time with Ruth von Kleist-Retzow. He gets to know the family.
- 7.8 Now we come to 1942. I just said he's been in Sweden. He returns from Sweden, comes to Germany, and goes to visit Klein-Krössin. This is where Ruth von Kleist-Retzow lives. June 8th, 1942. One of her grandchildren, whom I just mentioned as having been 11 years old, but who is now 18, Maria von Wedemeyer, shows up. She just finished high school and was going to embark on a year of national service and decided to spend some time visiting family.
- 7.9 Maria von Wedemeyer writes in her journal, she writes "Foremost among these family visits was one to my grandmother, to whom I had always been close. The feeling was mutual, because she thought I resembled her as a young girl. I had been there a week when the celebrated Pastor Bonhoeffer came to stay. I was a bit put out at first, to be honest, but it very soon emerged that the three of us got on extremely well together. The other two conversed in such a way that I not only felt I understood what they were talking about but was cordially encouraged to join in. Which I did. I'm afraid I used to take a cocky tone with my grandmother, which amused her, and which I maintained even when Dietrich turned up. We talked about future plans. Grandmother pronounced my plan to study mathematics a silly whim, but Dietrich, perhaps for that very reason, took it seriously. We went for a stroll in the garden. He said he'd been to America, and we noted with surprise that I'd never before met anyone who'd been there." So this is their first meeting.
- 7.10 She's 18. He's 36. I think I've said that he had pretty much decided he is called, this holy calling of God is on his life, and marriage is not in the cards for him. So he's put that aside. He wrote a letter in 1936 to Elizabeth Zinn, basically saying this. And he's been living this hardcore life as a pastor, as a prophetic voice to the church, and now as a spy involved in the plot against Hitler. But suddenly, he meets this 18-year-old who impresses him.
- 7.11 She's obviously brilliant. We know later on, she ended up having an extraordinary job in the United States with Bell & Howell, running a computer department. I mean, Bonhoeffer couldn't fail to be impressed by her. Suddenly, she's grown up. She's

suddenly a woman, and they're having these wonderful conversations. I think he was really quite surprised by this. He knew the family well. There was no father and mother—Hans and Ruth von Wedemeyer, the parents of Maria and all these kids—there was no couple who was more devoutly Christian and anti-Hitler than the two of them. So something happens in June. And again, this is a few days that he's up there visiting, so there's some overlap with Maria von Wedemeyer.

7.12 Now, I have to say that I think my book is the first book to do justice to this love story. It's an amazing story. There is a book, *Love Letters from Cell 92*, written by Maria von Wedemeyer's—or edited by Maria von Wedemeyer's elder sister—whom I think I mentioned my wife and I had the privilege of spending time with in the summer—or actually spring of 2008—near Hamburg. She puts this book together, and it's just all of these love letters between Bonhoeffer and Maria von Wedemeyer. You have to puzzle through because it's a weird relationship in the sense that he's traveling constantly. His life is in danger. All this is happening. How do they even have a relationship? How does it work out?

7.13 Well, here's how it starts. I just mentioned they have this meeting. It's a surprise to Bonhoeffer. It seems obvious. Again, you have to do, or I did, the work of teasing out what's actually going on here. Because right after this, I find a letter that Bonhoeffer writes to his best friend, Eberhard Bethge. I mean, he's confessing his deepest, darkest thoughts. This is his closest friend. He writes a letter on June 25th, so this is two weeks after he has met Maria von Wedemeyer. It seems to me the first hint we get of what's going on, he writes to his best friend: "I have not written to Maria. It is truly not time for that yet." You're thinking, holy cow, what is going on here? What's been happening in these two weeks that he would write this to his friend? What other letters did he write that we haven't seen? Because obviously, he has shared something of—something's going on, which was completely unanticipated.

7.14 He just did not expect suddenly to meet someone and think, "Gee, I wonder if I'm supposed to marry this person." Now, there's a huge age difference, not so big in those days—I mean, nonetheless, big. He's just turned 36, and she's 18. But she's a young woman. She's very mature. She's sophisticated. She's brilliant. So he writes to Eberhard Bethge: "I've not written to Maria. It is truly not time for that yet. If no further meetings are possible, the pleasant thought of a few highly charged minutes will surely"—"on the other side, I do not see how a meeting could be brought off that would be inconspicuous and not painful for her."

7.15 In other words, he's obviously thinking, "I got to see her again. I think maybe I'm supposed to marry this woman. But how do we pull that off?" He's traveling like crazy. He's thinking, well, we'd like to arrange a meeting, but that's going to be awkward, and she's going to feel—it's going to be awkward. He writes, "Even Mrs. von Kleist"—this is Ruth—"cannot be"—the grandmother—"cannot be expected to arrange this, at least not at my initiation, for I am, in fact, still not at all clear and decided about this."

- 7.16** Now, here you see a picture of the fine mind of Bonhoeffer. He's really processing this clearly. He wants to be decided about this. He's not decided. So he just lets it go. Next thing you know, he flies to Venice, Italy, with Dohnanyi on Abwehr business. A week later, he's in Rome. Can you imagine that we're in the middle of World War II, and he's zipping around as a member of the Abwehr. It's extraordinary. He had no contact with Maria since their meeting in early June.
- 7.17** Then he travels back in mid-August, so they had met two months earlier. Mid-August, he's back in Klein-Krössin with Ruth, the grandmother, and suddenly, tragedy strikes. Maria's father, Ruth's son-in-law, is killed at Stalingrad. He was 54 years old. We can only imagine. This 18-year-old has now lost her dearly beloved father. He was 54 years old, I said. Just devastating. That's August. The months pass.
- 7.18** The next thing, in early October, Ruth, who, as I think at this point is—she's 69 years old—she's having an eye operation at Berlin Hospital. Dietrich Bonhoeffer, of course, spending most of his time in Berlin, pays frequent visits to the hospital. Maria writes, years later, that "his frequent visits at the hospital surprised me, and I was impressed by his devotion. We often had long talks together at this time. It was a reunion under different circumstances than in June. Being still deeply affected by my father's death, I needed Dietrich's help."
- 7.19** They're spending time together, but he's this revered pastor. She hasn't really picked up that he's having other thoughts. He, being Dietrich Bonhoeffer, intensely in control of his emotions, is not about to flirt or hint. He's also aware of the fact she's just lost her father. But nonetheless, they spend time together.
- 7.20** Maria writes that "as a native Berliner, Bonhoeffer played the role of host. One day, he invited her to lunch, suggesting they go to a small restaurant near the hospital. He said, 'Because of the ownership, it was actually the safest place for them to talk freely.'" Now, this to me is like one of the greatest punchlines in my book. When I discovered this, I thought, "Somebody would make this up and it would be cheesy—this can't be right." This is true. This is effectively their only "date" ever. Now, it's not a "date" date because she's unaware of his thinking, but they go to lunch, they go to a restaurant. What restaurant?
- 7.21** It is a restaurant owned by Adolf Hitler's brother. Adolf Hitler's brother? Adolf Hitler has a brother? That's like saying the devil has a grandmother. Excuse me—what are you talking about? Adolf Hitler has a brother? Yes, he has a half-brother. His half-brother owns a restaurant in Berlin. It is frequently, as you can guess, by stormtroopers and ultra-Nazis, and Bonhoeffer takes Maria von Wedemeyer after they leave the hospital nearby to this restaurant for lunch. This is effectively their only date at Hitler's brothers' restaurant. Write it down. It's going to be on the quiz tomorrow.
- 7.22** Then a few weeks later, more horrible tragedy: Maria's elder brother whom she revered, Max, was killed in the war. Hard for us to imagine what life is like for people

going through this stuff. You lose your 54-year-old father. Now you lose your brother. I think he was 19. She loved him. He was one of the grandkids that Bonhoeffer knew very well. He had catechized him for the confirmation a few years before. Meanwhile, during this time, the grandmother, "Tanta" Ruth, as Bonhoeffer calls her—she's a character. She's hard not to admire, very smart. In fact, Bonhoeffer impressed her so much that she decided at age 70 to start studying New Testament Greek. Really amazing woman.

- 7.23** But she's watching the time that Dietrich Bonhoeffer is spending with her favorite granddaughter. She's obviously got some ideas in her head. She noticed their chemistry. Then, being the outspoken type that she was, she foolishly mentions these thoughts that she's having to her daughter, Maria's mother. Maria's mother is stunned, taken aback. She's just lost her husband. She's just lost her son. She's really probably not in the mood for any of this.
- 7.24** As they're preparing the funeral for her son Max, the mother—Maria's mother—sends a letter to Pastor Bonhoeffer asking him not to come to the funeral because she doesn't like the idea of her 18-year-old daughter being drawn into a relationship with 36-year-old Pastor Bonhoeffer, whom she knows to be involved in the plot against Hitler. Of course, she's all on board with that, this whole family is anti-Hitler. But she writes this.
- 7.25** So, imagine that suddenly, boom! The whole thing's in the open because of the grandmother kind of meddling. I find this all funny. I write about it at greater length in the book. It's funny because it's so human, right? That the grandmother is psyched that her favorite granddaughter would marry her favorite person of the world, Bonhoeffer, Pastor Bonhoeffer. She stupidly mentions it to her daughter, and then the daughter goes: That's it. He's not coming to the funeral. This is just awkward, whatever.
- 7.26** Now she writes the letter, as I said, to Bonhoeffer, and now the cat is out of the bag, and it's all really awkward because Maria is thinking, "What?" She's been essentially oblivious to this. So she writes a letter to Dietrich saying she had learned that her mother "had asked you not to come for the memorial service just because of some stupid family gossip which grandmother has rather encouraged." As far as Maria is concerned it's just stupid family gossip. Of course, it's not just stupid family gossip. So what happens next is anybody's guess, but the well-meaning grandmother's big mouth obviously has flushed the bird from its hiding place, and now we've got to deal with this stuff.
- 7.27** At some point, I guess it's November 24th. Now, you can imagine, Bonhoeffer is suddenly now thinking intensely about this. He's been forced to think about this because this is out in the open. He's not invited to the thing. Something's going on. So he has to figure out what he wants to do. On November 24th, he travels to Putzig, which is near Klein-Krössin, to visit with Maria's mother, Frau von Wedemeyer. Suddenly now, November 24th, in this meeting, he tells Maria's mother that he would

like to marry Maria von Wedemeyer, and he's asking her permission to propose. So there we are. Bonhoeffer wants to propose marriage. It's happened.

- 7.28** Maria is not really clear how she feels about Dietrich Bonhoeffer. She certainly likes him and respects him tremendously, and she's been spending this time with him. She's just lost her father. She's just lost her brother. But this is the first she's hearing of his intentions in this way. She writes in her journal, three days after Bonhoeffer makes this announcement to the mother. She says, "Why am I suddenly so cheerful these days? Ever since Mother told me on the phone about her meeting with Dietrich, I feel I can breathe freely again. He made a considerable impression on Mother, that's obvious—he couldn't fail to. The incredible fact remains, he actually wants to marry me. I still fail to grasp how that can be." She is shocked. She doesn't think of herself in the league of esteemed Pastor Bonhoeffer. She is really taken aback.
- 7.29** So this is where it gets weird. The mother thinking, well, that's a nice idea. You're a nice young man, but there's a huge age difference. I don't know. The mother now proposes or really insists upon a year-long separation. In other words, okay, you want to marry her? She's 18. Certainly, you can put your feelings aside for a year and let's see how this goes.
- 7.30** Maria now writes to Dietrich, "Dear Pastor Bonhoeffer"—ok, she writes, "Pastor" Bonhoeffer. "I've known ever since arriving home that I must write to you and I've looked forward to doing so. I recently spoke with my mother and my uncle."—Obviously, your father is dead.—"I'm now able to write to you and to ask you to answer this letter. It is so difficult for me to have to put in writing what even in person can scarcely be spoken, because words are so clumsy and forceful with things that want to be said gently. But because I have experienced that you understand me so well, I now have the courage to write you. Although I actually have no right at all to reply to a question you have not even asked me." Then she writes, "Today, I can say Yes to you from my entire, joyful heart."
- 7.31** I find that really moving because we know how this ends. It's so amazing. When we think of the world we live in and the way people date and interact, there's something so beautiful about this. So beautiful about this—how seriously they take this, how sacred marriage is, how they both understand this. So she says this to him. The grandmother, of course, out of her mind with joy, writes a letter to Dietrich, "You know utterly without saying how I desire to receive you fully as a son"—grandson— "when the time comes. That it should still take so long is probably the decision of Maria's mother and Hans-Jürgen, the uncle, I'm presuming. Perhaps this is the right thing for Maria so that she remains quite clear. And if it appears too long for her and you, then there will be means and ways to shorten it. What does time mean today anyway? Oh, I am happy."
- 7.32** So there things stand. He's proposed, he's been accepted, and the mother has asked for a year-long separation, which is not crazy. This then takes us to—we're now at the

beginning of 1943. We are in the middle of the war, and we get to Bonhoeffer's role in the plot against Hitler. I haven't been clear on this, I don't think, and I want to be clear that there were a number of plots to kill Hitler. One involves an overcoat bomb. If you see the movie, they deal with that. It's actually a thousand times more exciting in reality than even in the movie. It's unbelievable. Somebody plans to give Hitler a tour of some captured Soviet military equipment just to kind of—to show the Führer and some of his top lieutenants, we captured this in Russia. So this is, again, I guess, around, it's '42.

7.33 The plan was that this young man—i t's inconceivable—volunteers to wear a suicide bomb and to detonate it in the presence of Adolf Hitler while he's giving him a tour of this machine. It's one of the most dramatic things. I don't really have time to go into it, but it's one of the most dramatic things you could ever imagine: "I'm going to be giving Adolf Hitler a tour, and while I'm talking about the machinery and the things that we've captured, I hear tick, tick, tick, tick, tick—any minute, my life will end." It's unbelievable. Again, for time I'll just stop there.

7.34 Once the trigger has been detonated with about 10 minutes, and this man, giving the acting performance of a thousand lifetimes, talking about Soviet machinery while he knows the seconds are ticking down before he will leave this world. In the middle of this, Hitler decides like, "You know what? I'm done," gets in his car, and goes. The fuse has been triggered. There are a couple of minutes left. This man—I don't know if he sprints—he hustles to a restroom, undoes the vest, diffuses the bomb in time, and he lives to 1980. Hitler is not killed.

7.35 There's another story where Maria's cousin, Fabian von Schlabrendorff—I had the tremendous privilege of meeting his son when I was speaking about my Bonhoeffer book after it had been translated into German and I visited Germany. Fabian von Schlabrendorff, he gets a bomb—i t is delivered from England because they knew this was the only kind that would work. Again, this is like the Forrest Gump stuff—Eberhard Bethge, whom I keep mentioning, borrows Karl Bonhoeffer's Mercedes to transport the bomb to Fabian von Schlabrendorff. I can't remember where they got it from, but the Bonhoeffer family is involved. They're all involved in this stuff.

7.36 He transports the bomb to Fabian von Schlabrendorff. Schlabrendorff travels to, I forget where, I'm pretty sure it was Wolfsschanze, one of Hitler's lairs or whatever, and says, "Oh, I've got this package of brandy which I'd like to deliver to a friend. I lost a bet. Can I put it on the plane, please?" So he puts it on the plane, and everyone is waiting and waiting and waiting because they know that this plane with Hitler in it is not going to land. They're going to get the message that it's curtains for the Third Reich, but the plane lands. Something goes wrong with the bomb.

7.37 This brings us to the final plot to kill Hitler, which we'll get to in a minute. But so all of this is going on in the background. Meanwhile, we should deal with Bonhoeffer's involvement in the plot to kill Hitler. At some point, sometimes people make too much

of it. But he really had to settle in his mind whether it is a moral thing or what is it to be involved in the plot to kill Hitler. It weaves in and out. Throughout the book, I mention a number of these conversations.

7.38 At one point, Werner von Haeften, who actually is close to the Führer—I don't mean he likes the Führer, but he's one of these military figures who knew Bonhoeffer. At one point, he gets close to Bonhoeffer, and he simply asks him, "Shall I shoot? I can get inside the Führer's headquarters with my revolver. I know where and when the conferences take place. I can get access." Bonhoeffer really—we can go into this in the Q&A, but he's really puzzling through his involvement in this larger plot.

7.39 But let's just go back to where things stand now. He has proposed to Maria. She has accepted. Her mother has asked for a year of separation. So suddenly it's 1943. The months are passing. The mother has asked them not to write to each other. So what does Maria do? She writes letters to Bonhoeffer in her journal. Maybe she'll mail them later, but she nonetheless is writing letters to him in her journal, but they have no contact with each other.

7.40 Then it happens. April 5th, 1943, Bonhoeffer is at home—you can go, you can visit it. I recommend you do in Berlin on the Marienburger Allee. The house is there. It's like a museum. You can visit his room. I've done it many times. It's all pretty much the same. He did his writing there. This was his base. He's at home on April 5th, and he calls the Dohnanyis. The phone was answered by an unfamiliar man's voice. Bonhoeffer knew instantly what's going on. The Gestapo had made their move.

7.41 We know from what I said yesterday, Operation 7 was this plan that Bonhoeffer and Dohnanyi were involved to get seven and then ultimately 14 Jews out of Germany into neutral Switzerland. The Gestapo picks up on this. There's some financial irregularities. They pull the thread. It leads them to Dohnanyi, to Bonhoeffer—they didn't know if they had anything, but they had enough to make some arrests.

7.42 So they arrest Dohnanyi, which is a huge deal because he was a very big deal in the German government, in the Abwehr. Bonhoeffer knows it's happening. He goes next door. His sister Ursula lived next door to where the Bonhoeffer family is, and you can see both houses today. He lets her know what's going on. He knows—listen, they're coming for me. I'm going to be arrested. She prepares him a big meal because he's not going to get a big meal where he's going. Two hours later, or rather at 4:00, Bonhoeffer's father comes over to the Schleicher's, to Ursula's house, and says, "There are two men who've just arrived who wish to speak with you." It was a Gestapo official and Judge-advocate Roeder.

7.43 Bonhoeffer met them, took his Bible with him, was escorted to their black Mercedes, and taken away, never again to return. He's taken to Tegel military prison. Now, we've got to be clear, and again—when I write biographies, the facts are very important to get this straight because there are all these myths and stories. Let's get it straight. He's

taken to Tegel military prison, not to a Gestapo prison. He hasn't been arrested for his involvement in the plot to kill Hitler. He's been arrested for some financial irregularities, whatever it is.

- 7.44 And Tegel military prison was nothing like the Gestapo prison. It was not nice. It was a prison, but it was not so horrible. Again, all roads lead to the Bonhoeffer family. It's like the Forrest Gump stuff. His uncle, Paul von Hase, was the military commandant over all of Berlin. He's going to a military prison. His uncle is over all this stuff. When he's first at the prison, nobody knows who he is. But pretty soon, they figure out—oh my gosh! This is the nephew of our big, big boss. So they start treating him with kid gloves. They give him certain privileges and stuff. It wasn't fun, but it really was different than what you think of. When you think the Nazis arrest you, you think they're sending you to a concentration camp. They're going to do this, they're going to do that.
- 7.45 So he's there. And just so we get the picture. He is under the impression that he can beat the rap. This is like some financial thing. He wasn't really that involved. So he just has to go through the motions or whatever. He's able to write letters. At first, it's just one every 10 days or whatever. But then he gets more and more privileges because he becomes friendly with the guards.
- 7.46 They allow him to function as a pastor, to hang out in the sick bay, to minister in a pastoral sense or whatever. So it ends up being about a year and a half at Tegel military prison in cell 92, hence the title of Maria's sister's book, *Love Letters from Cell 92*. But so he's there. He's expecting eventually to be exonerated and to get out. There's so much more that can be said about this, but I don't want to go into it too much.
- 7.47 One thing I'll say is that on April 5th, the day he's arrested, Maria writing in her letters to Bonhoeffer, not actually mailing them to him, but she writes in her journal on that day—in her diary-journal letters to him, "Dietrich, has something bad happened? I'm afraid it's something very bad." She somehow knew, it seems, that something terrible had happened. Eventually, she was able to visit him in the prison. She was a real source of strength to him, I think. His engagement to her and relationship to her gave him real hope in the midst of this time. Again, they didn't know where this was going.
- 7.48 I have to say that especially as we get into 1944, there was hope every single day that the Allies who—remember D-Day has happened, people know the Nazis are going to lose. So it's now a waiting game. When are they going to lose? How are they going to lose? And in the meantime, you have the assassination plot to kill Hitler goes on. So they fail twice. The third one, the most famous one, the von Stauffenberg plot. Some of you saw the movie *Valkyrie*, that takes place July 20th, 1944, 25 years to the day for when Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin landed on the moon: July 20th, 1944.
- 7.49 Dietrich and his family, everyone knows at any moment, Hitler may leave the world and we're all free and everything's great. So they're waiting and waiting. There's a lot of hope. Maria visits him in the prison. At one point, this is May of 1944, Maria visits

Dietrich's parents in Berlin, where she's received as Dietrich's fiancée. She spent a long time alone in Dietrich's room on the third floor, and she writes to him now, "My dear, dear Dietrich, you thought of me yesterday, didn't you? I sense how constantly you were at my side, how you went with me through all those unfamiliar rooms to meet all those people, and how everything suddenly seemed familiar, homely, and very dear." She's in his parents' home, and it's like he's there with her. "I like your parents," she writes. "The moment your mother greeted me, I knew I couldn't fail to, and that you're giving me infinitely more than I ever dreamed. Oh, I fell in love with everything. Your house, the garden, and—most of all—your room. I don't know what I wouldn't give to be able to sit there again, if only to look at the ink blots on your desk pad."

- 7.50** "Everything has become so real and clear to me since I met you at your parents' home yesterday." She didn't meet him, actually, but it's like I know you on a deeper level. She writes, "The desk where you wrote your books and your letters to me, your armchair and the ashtray, your shoes on the shelf, and your favorite pictures. I never thought I could miss you and long for you more than I do, but I've done so twice as much since yesterday. My dearest Dietrich, every morning at six, when we both fold our hands in prayer, we know that we can have great faith, not only in each other, but far, far above and beyond that. And then you can't be sad anymore either, can you? I'll write again soon. Whatever I think or do, I'm always your Maria."
- 7.51** It's just amazing to me. He's in prison, but they are— I won't go into it, but they're beginning to plan their wedding. The biggest misconception about Bonhoeffer comes from this period because Bonhoeffer was during this period, finally able—thanks to his relationships in the prison—to write more letters, to write as many letters as he wanted. And so he wrote a lot of stuff to Eberhard Bethge, figuring Eberhard Bethge can keep this safe.
- 7.52** So a lot of theological musings. He's thinking about the future of Christianity. The world has fallen apart because of the failure of the church. He's wondering, he's musing about what is the future of Christianity in Germany, in the world? He's writing all these letters and he gets to mail them to Eberhard Bethge. Eberhard Bethge takes them, hides them in a gas mask canister and buries them in the Bonhoeffer's backyard—all these letters.
- 7.53** After the war, he digs them up. He has these treasures. Bonhoeffer, by then, has died. And Eberhard Bethge says, "I think perhaps we should publish these or show them to some people or whatever." This leads to the first book that ever came out by Bonhoeffer. Well, I shouldn't say the first book, I mean what brought him to the world's attention. It's called *Letters and Papers from Prison*.
- 7.54** And *Letters and Papers from Prison* is a very, very strange book. I really can't even recommend it because it's Bonhoeffer's very personal letters to his very best friend about this high-level theological stuff. What occurred is that a lot of the postwar theologians—who really did not know Bonhoeffer and certainly didn't know the Bonhoeffer that's revealed in his journal, in his letters to his family, whatever—they

seized on this and interpreted in the way they liked. They give the world a picture of Bonhoeffer that has subsequently, at least or maybe principally as a result of my book, been completely corrected and debunked.

7.55 But for decades, all people knew was these highfalutin theological musings. Not only is that the case that these things existed, but that a lot of very liberal and agnostic "theologians," academics, interpreted these things exactly the way they wanted—really twisted the meaning of it, as I'll get into probably in the next lecture. It gives you a very twisted view of Bonhoeffer and a real misunderstanding of what he meant by the term "religionless Christianity." But that's only because he had this opportunity to write all these letters to his friend who hides them and so on and so forth. We'll get to that.

7.56 But where we leave things now is that Bonhoeffer is in Tegel Prison. I mentioned that his uncle is the military commandant, so they're treating him with kid gloves. He's getting to write these letters. It is not hellish. It's not fun, but it's not hellish. He's in a waiting pattern. He knows at some point he's going to get out, whether when Hitler is killed or the war ends or his case comes to trial, he's going to get out.

7.57 But then, as I mentioned, July 20th, 1944, the Valkyrie plot finally happens. Von Stauffenberg delivers the bomb to Wolfeschanze in East Prussia. The bomb goes off. Hitler is not killed. Now, Hitler was not killed in the other plots, but the difference is this time the bomb goes off. This time the plot is exposed. This time, von Stauffenberg is arrested, executed. Many others are arrested, tortured—names come up, names come up. Hitler goes scorched earth on his enemies. And one of the names that pops up is Dietrich Bonhoeffer. For the first time, the man who is at Tegel military prison for Operation 7 is exposed as someone involved in the plot to kill Adolf Hitler. Suddenly, everything changes. Suddenly, he's a marked man.

7.58 I go into it in my book—I won't now, but I will simply say Bonhoeffer had an opportunity to escape Tegel military prison. One of the guards whom he had befriended wanted to help him escape. He could have escaped, but he realized that if he does that, first of all, it's going to be hard to get out of Germany. Secondly, it will point the finger more harshly at his brother Klaus, who has been arrested, at his sister, who has been arrested, taken to a women's prison, it's going to be harder, so he decides not to do that. But he knows that the future now is—it's not clear, but it doesn't look great.

7.59 He's transferred at some point, a few months later, I think it's October of '44. Imagine how late this is. The war is going to be over in a few months. In October 44, he's transferred to the Gestapo prison. Now, this is a dreadful thing. Nothing leads us to believe he was tortured. He was certainly threatened with it. He describes his interrogations there as frankly repulsive. He was threatened that his fiancée and his other family members would be in trouble if he didn't give the Gestapo the truth they were looking for. He can no longer write to Maria. She makes the trek to the prison,

which is in Berlin many times, hoping for permission; each time, she's denied. From this point on, information on Bonhoeffer becomes scarce. I'll get to that in the next lecture.

- 7.60** It's a strange thing that he is now in the hands of the Gestapo. They know him to be genuinely involved in the plot to kill Hitler. The only question is: What will they do? Why don't they kill him right away? Part of it should be said that he and a number of the other prisoners in this Gestapo prison are really thought of as potential bargaining chips, because we get the picture as 1944 is winding down, that the Nazis are losing the war suddenly.
- 7.61** I think the smarter members of the Nazi elite recognize they're probably going to need some bargaining chips if they lose the war to preserve their own lives. Well, we'll trade you Dietrich Bonhoeffer, we'll trade you this one. So the conditions in the Gestapo prison were really horrible, but not as horrible as they might have been. I think we'll leave it there for now. We have time for a few questions, so let's stop there.
- 7.62** I think the question of whether Dietrich Bonhoeffer was justified in being involved in the plot is relevant because the whole issue of just war theories and so on. I was wondering if you could point to historical precedents that would help us understand his position and if I could just frame the issue briefly that this has to do with just wars or Godly actions as opposed to selfish wars. We have examples starting with a long time ago: Joshua, of course, King David, a lso, Joan of Arc, our American Revolutionary War could all be considered miraculous and Godly actions. Then we have other examples of selfish wars that didn't turn out too well. But given Bonhoeffer's involvement in this, as you pointed out, he certainly shouldn't be considered a pacifist that wasn't really in his purview. But I think these are historical precedents that could justify his actions. Would you agree with that?
- 7.63** Yes, I would agree. I did want to say this, and actually, this is a great time for me to try to tease out what his thinking was. I've touched on it in the past, but Bonhoeffer had the courage to ask the hard questions. An easy religious answer would be, "Killing is wrong." Killing is definitely not wrong. Murder is wrong. It says in the Ten Commandments: "Thou shalt do no murder." It doesn't say all killing is wrong. Having a military to protect people from foreign invasion, having a police force to protect people from criminals. That's Romans 13. Governments have been instituted to use the sword to protect people from evil.
- 7.64** Then the question is, what does that mean? We can think of just war theories related to that. Bonhoeffer is thinking about this because if it's just about let's kill somebody, so the plotters, the people involved in the larger assassination, but they're puzzling this out. What will be accomplished if we kill Hitler? Part of the problem, part of the reason they didn't kill Hitler or didn't kill him sooner or didn't succeed was because it was more complicated. They thought, we can't just kill Hitler. We've probably got to take out his top lieutenants because if we just kill Hitler, he'll be replaced by Himmler or Goebbels or Goering or any of these evil figures. So that was part of it.

- 7.65 And the von Stauffenberg plot. Von Stauffenberg was really disappointed when he arrives at Wolfeschanze and realizes, "Oh, I thought Himmler was going to be here. I thought—" so it was complicated. And I think that Bonhoeffer, there's a quote of Bonhoeffer, when he was asked by Werner von Haeften, "Shall I shoot? Shall I kill Hitler?" Bonhoeffer makes it clear that the shooting by itself meant nothing. Something had to be gained by it, a change of circumstances of the government, and the liquidation of Hitler would in itself be of no use. Things might even become worse. So they're really thinking about that.
- 7.66 But I should say that it was Bonhoeffer's knowledge of the mass murder of the Jews. It's like you think—why did Truman drop the bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki? Well, it was because he knew that if he didn't, several hundred thousand Americans would lose their lives. It's that simple. In other words, if you didn't know that, then you'd think, "Well, how can I do something like this? This is really dramatic." But Bonhoeffer and the others knew that hundreds of thousands, millions of Jews are daily being murdered—that every day they cease to act, they share in the guilt for those murders.
- 7.67 There's a line, I think, in the movie that is fiction, but it sums up the idea that somebody says to Bonhoeffer, "Will God be able to forgive us if we do this?" Then Bonhoeffer in the movie says, "Well, will God forgive us if we don't do this?" This gets to the theology of Bonhoeffer, this idea that we can live guilt-free or that we don't ever have to do something which might be on the border, which might get us involved in getting our hands dirty in some way. That's the pietistic religious thinking that I talked about several lectures ago. It's not biblical thinking. Biblical thinking, and Bonhoeffer pushed this farther than almost everyone, really requires us to wrestle in a way that it's easier not to wrestle.
- 7.68 In my book, I write that "Bonhoeffer knew that to live in fear of incurring guilt was itself sinful." In other words, if you simply shrink from acting because you don't want to get your hands dirty, that's not okay. "God wants his beloved children to operate out of freedom and joy to do what is right and good, not out of fear of making a mistake. To live in fear and guilt was to be religious in the majority of sense that Bonhoeffer so often talked about. He knew that to act freely could mean inadvertently doing wrong or incurring guilt."
- 7.69 He wrote an essay New Year's 1943, or actually, he wrote it at Christmas 1942. There's a quote in there. Bonhoeffer writes, "Who stands fast? Only the man whose final standard is not his reason, his principles, his conscience, his freedom, or his virtue, but who is ready to sacrifice all this when he is called to obedient and responsible action in faith and in exclusive allegiance to God—the responsible man who tries to make his whole life an answer to the question and call of God." That is a very dramatic statement. That's very hard for most Christians who are looking for an easier answer. He was really wrestling with this.

- 7.70** In another place, he writes, "If we want to be Christians, we must have some share in Christ's large-heartedness by acting with responsibility and in freedom when the hour of danger comes, and by showing a real sympathy that springs, not, from fear, but from the liberating and redeeming love of Christ for all who suffer. Mere waiting and looking on is not Christian behavior." That, to me, is probably where we get this quote, "Silence in the face of evil is itself evil." A lot of Christians have this utterly un-Christian, unbiblical idea that if I do nothing, if I keep my hands clean, I'm good. Bonhoeffer says —no, you are guilty if you do nothing when you sense maybe I ought to do something. And that's he felt about the situation with Adolf Hitler and the Nazis.
- 7.71** He writes, "The Christian is called to sympathy and action, not in the first place by his own sufferings, but by the sufferings of his brethren, for whose sake Christ suffered." In other words, you're not acting, and—I've said this a lot in the last two years to American Christians about certain situations in which we find ourselves—that this idea that you need to do this for the church. No, no, no. The church needs to do these things for the sake of those outside the church, for all those who are suffering as a result of, let's say, government policies.
- 7.72** In the case of the Nazis, Bonhoeffer understands it's the Jews who are suffering most of all, and we have a duty. Now, he says this in the essay that he writes, *The Church and the Jewish Question*. In 1933, he gets this. But more and more and more, he says, "The Christian is called to sympathy and action, not in the first by his own sufferings, but by the sufferings of his brethren, for human beings who are suffering." In this case, clearly, it's the Jews. He knows what's happening, and he knows that every single day that I do nothing because I'm not sure—he knows that that is a cop-out. I'm not sure. Well, you may never be 100% sure, but you can be sure that God will judge you as guilty if you do nothing just because you're not 100% sure.
- 7.73** So this is really a high standard, but Bonhoeffer makes it clear that this is what God expects of Christians. You may never get it exactly right, but God is calling you to try, not to do nothing. And so this gets to the idea, and I'll close with this. He wrote many times—I quoted him in 1928 in Barcelona, and then later on—he says, "I fear that Christians who venture to stand on Earth on only one leg will stand in heaven on only one leg, too." You have to live in this world. You have to make tough decisions. This idea that I can be religious and I can just be hanging back and I never have to get my hands dirty. He knew that that wasn't right, and he lived it out. That's what's so extraordinary. He didn't just write about this stuff. He actually—he lived it out.
- 7.74** I'll close this session with this quote. April 11th, 1944—by now, this is very late. He writes, "If I were to end my life here in these conditions"—in prison— "that would have a meaning that I think I could understand; on the other hand, everything might be a thorough preparation for a new start and a new task when peace comes." He really has no regrets. Even in prison all through this period, he just makes clear over and over,

over again: "I'm just trying to do the will of God, and wherever that leads me, I'm at peace." So we'll leave it there.

Lecture 8: Final Acts of Faith

At a glance — Final acts of faith.

- 8.1** All right, welcome to lecture eight, the eighth and final lecture in this Bonhoeffer course. If you want to see my notes on your midterms, you go to ericmetaxas.com, you'll find that everything is there. At the end of the last lecture, we were talking about where Bonhoeffer is now. He was in Tegel military prison for quite a while. When the July 20th plot, 1944, goes wrong. The bomb explodes, Hitler survives, hundreds, if not thousands, are arrested, tortured, killed. One of the names that pops up is Dietrich Bonhoeffer.
- 8.2** He knows that his days are numbered or might be numbered. He's transferred, as I mentioned, to the Gestapo prison. I think it's October of 1944. The conditions there are not good. Our information on him at this point becomes sketchy because he's no longer able to write in a diary or letters or anything like that. One of the principal figures at this point is a character named Payne Best, who writes a book called *The Venlo Incident*. We get a lot of information on Bonhoeffer's last months from Payne Best.
- 8.3** The Gestapo prison, as we know, was in Berlin. Try to picture this now. This is the end of '44, the beginning of '45. The Allies are winning. Germany is daily becoming thinner as the forces are coming in from the east, the Allied forces, the Soviets from the west. Germany is getting thinner and thinner and thinner. The Americans, principally, are bombing the heck out of Berlin. And since the Gestapo prison is in Berlin, Bonhoeffer hears the bombs. Everyone knows what's going on, wonders how this is going to play out.
- 8.4** It was I think February, I want to make sure I get the dates right, that the Nazis realized—well, if we want to keep these prisoners alive as bargaining chips, we better get them out of Berlin because the bombs are just reducing Berlin to rubble. At some point, I believe it's early February, Bonhoeffer is told, "You're going to get on a bus and we're taking these prisoners out of here." This is hard stuff. His fiancée, as I said, is unable to visit him. They just don't know how it's going to turn out.
- 8.5** In any event, here's the page. "In early afternoon of February 7th, Bonhoeffer and a number of other prominent prisoners are taken from their cells in the dreaded Gestapo prison and made to wait near two vans that were going to take them to the concentration camps at Buchenwald and Flossenbürg. There were 20 men there, principal figures in the conspiracy, a stunning array of people—Hjalmar Schacht, who was the former head of the Reichspakt." So huge job in the German government. He'd enabled Hitler's rise to power and later saw what he had done and fought against this monster that he had created. Schacht had spoken against the treatment of the Jews early on, and in 1938 was involved in one of the plots to kill Hitler.

- 8.6** Here was Admiral Canaris, General Oster, Judge Sack. They were key figures in the conspiracy. Bonhoeffer—if he didn't know them personally, he would have known them through his brother-in-law, Dohnanyi, and on and on. Here they are standing in front of these two vans ready to leave Berlin to be taken to Flossenbürg and Buchenwald. Bonhoeffer, as he's getting on the van, there's a figure I haven't had time to mention named Josef Müller. Bonhoeffer and Müller were handcuffed as they're getting onto the van. Bonhoeffer protested at the handcuffs. And Müller, who had suffered horrors, offered a word of encouragement to Bonhoeffer, his friend, and fellow prisoner, and fellow believer, I should say, because Müller was a serious Catholic Christian.
- 8.7** He said to Bonhoeffer, "Let us go calmly to the gallows as Christians." So Bonhoeffer, of course, at this point, is an ambassador in chains, and now he would take a long journey 200 miles south to Buchenwald. What is Buchenwald? Buchenwald is one of these camps. It was not a death camp. It doesn't mean that 56,545 people were not killed there, but it was not set up as an extermination camp or as a death camp. But the Buchenwald camp was where Bonhoeffer was headed. People have often said, and it's not true, that Bonhoeffer was sent to a concentration camp—no. All this time, he was at Tegel, then he's at the Gestapo prison.
- 8.8** Now he's taken to Buchenwald, but not into the camp itself. On the outskirts of the camp, and he was there for what ended up being seven weeks. There were Gestapo barracks. In the basement of the Gestapo barracks was a makeshift prison cellar of this yellow tenement-style building—really set up for the Buchenwald staff. The cellar had been previously used as a military jail for the SS, and now it would be where 17 of these illustrious prisoners, Bonhoeffer, among them, will be kept in 12 cells.
- 8.9** We have no letters from Bonhoeffer during this period, but one of the men he met here, whom I've mentioned, was a British intelligence officer, Captain Payne Best. He wrote an account of his final years in German captivity called the Venlo Incident, and a lot of the information we get from Bonhoeffer comes from his account. Bonhoeffer, in February and March, which are his last months in this world, is hanging out with a cast of characters. I don't have time to go into it now, but they are very colorful cast of characters.
- 8.10** As far as I'm concerned, the most colorful is this British intelligence captain officer named Payne Best. When I think, if you know the actor Terry Thomas, I just think he was this kind of a character, almost like a British caricature with a monocle and big teeth. He spent time, of course, with Bonhoeffer and said of Bonhoeffer: "his soul really shone in the dark desperation of our prison. Bonhoeffer had always been afraid that he would not be strong enough to stand such a test but now he knew there was nothing in life of which one need ever be afraid."
- 8.11** There are many similar encomia that witnesses to Bonhoeffer's last months have given us. I don't know how many I will get to, but it's fascinating that in these very trying

circumstances, many people commented on his towering faith, his calmness, his strength, his equanimity. There are many of those kinds of quotes. Now, I say that he spent seven weeks at Buchenwald in the cellar of this staff tenement. I don't need to get into everyone who was there, but I want to mention two figures who were there, just to underscore, in case we've forgotten, the Satanic evil of the Third Reich.

- 8.12** One of these figures who was there was Dr. Waldemar Hoven. He had been the chief doctor at Buchenwald. Now, let's think about this. The chief doctor at Buchenwald. We all know Mengele, but there were a number of these evil Nazi doctors. We say evil Nazi doctors, we don't just say it like evil Nazi doctors. They were satanically evil. They had a view of human beings, and this was the Nazi view, that human beings are not made in the image of God. There is no God, and, therefore, human beings are nothing. We can murder them, we can experiment on them, we can do incredibly cruel experiments on them to further science. We have no compunction about doing these things. It's rare that you get a really clear glimpse into what a life led apart from God looks like.
- 8.13** Because we live in a world where you rarely see it clearly and say—oh, everybody's a nice person, and I believe everybody's basically good. Well, when you really see clearly where a view, a deeply atheistic view leads, the Nazis are the classic case. It's logical to say, if there's no God, then human beings are not created in anybody's image. Human beings are just animals. Some human beings, to quote George Orwell, "some are more equal than others."
- 8.14** If you are a prisoner, if you're an enemy of the state, then you have zero value. I can torture you, I can murder you for your organs, I can dissect you for your organs to give to people who are more worthy than you. That's going on today in another place where they have this view of human beings. It's called the Communist Republic of China. Any place in the world where they live out this worldview, it is horrific.
- 8.15** Here, Bonhoeffer is spending time with two of these figures. So one of them is Dr. Hoven. I quote from my own book, "Dr. Hoven stood once together with"—the person who gives this quote—"at the window of the pathological section"—at Buchenwald—"pointed to a prisoner not known to me, he crossed the place where the roll calls were held. Dr. Hoven told me, 'I want to see the skull of this prisoner on my writing desk by tomorrow evening.' The prisoner was ordered to report to the medical section after the physician had noted down the number of the prisoner. The corpse was delivered on the same day to the dissection room. The postmortem examination showed the prisoner had been killed by injections. The skull was prepared as ordered and delivered to Dr. Hoven."
- 8.16** It doesn't get clearer than that. That's Dr. Hoven. Dr. Hoven was not at Buchenwald for very long with Bonhoeffer. He's replaced by someone equally wicked: 36-year-old Sigmund Rascher. This is February 28th, 1945. Payne Best met Rascher in the lavatory that morning. He writes about him: "Rascher was the man who planned and supervised the construction of the gas chambers and was responsible for the use of prisoners as

guinea pigs in medical research." This is who Dietrich Bonhoeffer is hanging out with in his final days on this earth.

8.17 Now, if you made this up, people wouldn't believe it. But I think perhaps someone may write a play. It would make an extraordinary play of this last season of Bonhoeffer's life, where one of the holiest, most extraordinary men of the 20th century is hanging out with one of the most wicked human beings of the 20th century. What might they have said to each other? It's at least fascinating. But Rascher genuinely was the man who came up with the gas chambers. Now, in his defense, just so you understand, things are never so black and white. The whole idea was to murder as many people as possible, but not in a cruel way.

8.18 So the gas chambers were, at least according to Rascher, designed so that they wouldn't know what hit them, they will pass out and die. But when I discovered this, and I don't think there's any other Bonhoeffer book that even touches on this, I said, "This is unbelievable," that in the last two months of his life, Bonhoeffer is spending time with all these characters, including this guy. It is, as I say, at least fascinating. Payne Best—he also said of Bonhoeffer that Bonhoeffer was "all humility and sweetness; he always seemed to me to diffuse an atmosphere of happiness, of joy in every smallest event in life, and of deep gratitude for the mere fact that he was alive. He was one of the very few men that I have ever met to whom his God was real and ever close to him."

8.19 So, Fabian von Schlabrendorff, whom I mentioned, Maria von Wedermeyer's cousin, he was briefly in this place. They're there for seven weeks at Buchenwald. It's interesting that Dr. Hoven and Dr. Sigmund Rascher are both slated for death. In other words, here they were a big deal in the world of the Nazis, but then, at some point, they say something wrong or do something wrong, and now they are going to their deaths as well. I forgot to mention that one of the things Payne Best said about Bonhoeffer—and again, this is Bonhoeffer in the bleakest place of his life imaginable, and Best sees him in this situation. But Best said that Bonhoeffer was "cheerful and always ready to respond to a joke." It's just amazing to see how the light of God shines through him in this darkest of dark places.

8.20 In any event, the Allies keep bombing. Germany is getting thinner and thinner. At the end of March, 1945, all of these prisoners in Buchenwald are informed—we're moving again. They are—I believe I mentioned—actually, no, we're not clear on where they're going at this point. The point is that the German elites want to keep these prisoners alive as bargaining chips. The war is winding down and they want to get them out of here. This is the end of March, 1945: "On April 1st, Easter, the thunder of the American guns could be heard in the distance. They were someplace across the Werra River. It would all be over soon."

8.21 The Nazis don't want these prisoners to be freed. They want to keep them in their custody so they can use them as bargaining chips, so they've got to move them again. On April 1st, which is Easter Sunday, the chief guard at Buchenwald, Zypok, tells the

prisoners to get ready to leave. Where are they going? Nobody knows. They are forced to get in a van—now, I won't go into this, but this is just crazy stuff. It's a van that is powered by a wood engine. So they're feeding wood into it. They're cramming 16 prisoners into this van along with their luggage. They're unable to move an inch, and they don't know where they're going. I mean, it's a crazy thing. Again, this starts April 1st. On April 9th, Bonhoeffer is executed.

8.22 This is the last week of his life. I have to say I did something strange in the writing of my book. I stretched out—the time seems to dilate, at least in the way that I wrote my book. Time seems to stretch out. The last week of his life, I'm giving more and more details of his life. Why? Almost because I want to keep him alive. I want this to go on and on. The last week of his life in this van going around Germany, they don't know where. It's a very strange, interesting journey. They're out of the dank prison at Buchenwald. They are now in the open air traveling through this country, Germany, that they haven't seen with their eyes for a long time. It's this wood-fueled engine, as I said. When they first start the journey, now imagine like you made it up for a movie, Bonhoeffer is in here with the man who designed the gas chambers, in this van.

8.23 Before the gas chambers were designed, the Nazis would kill people by putting them in a car like this, filling the back with this gas so that the people would die, and by the time it got to where it was going—the crematorium—everybody in there would be dead. I know I talk about that earlier in my book, but I haven't mentioned it here. But on this day, the wood-fueled engine starts to fill the van with fumes, and somebody says, "My God, this is a death van. We are being gassed." Now, that was perfectly within the realm of possibility here. Yeah, get in the van and we're going to kill you.

8.24 But Rasher, who's in the van, who designed the gas chambers, tells them—no, from what he knows, that's not the case. They're on their way. It looks like, at this point, to Flossenbürg. They travel through the night in these cramped conditions, joggling along, having to stop every hour to refuel wood into the thing. It's a bizarre, strange journey. Payne Best says, "After leaving Weiden, there was a marked change in the attitude of the three SS guards. They had obviously left Buchenwald with orders to take us to Flossenbürg, and for so long, they had felt themselves constricted by the sense of an authority guiding them."

8.25 But at some point, they get to Flossenbürg, "Flossenbürg refuses to receive them, and they're apparently sent off on vague instructions to continue a southward course until they found some place where they could deposit their prisoners. In a measure"—and again, this is Payne Best writing—"they felt that they shared our lot"—the SS guards—"and like us, were just sailing along into the blue with no certain destination."

8.26 I write in my book, "The Van with Bonhoeffer and now 13 companions continued its wheezing, clanking journey southward toward no place in particular. They were like the troupe of actors from Ingmar Bergman's *The Seventh Seal*, cheerful and peripatetic, but shadowed as they went by the hooded dark figure of death." It's a strange week.

They're traveling in this van, stopping now and again to relieve themselves. I don't think that there's any food.

- 8.27** At another point, they stop at a prison where they stay for the night. I think it's August 5th. At some point, they stop the van in front of a farmhouse and I write, "What a jolly scene it must have been. These august figures, weary from hunger and lack of sleep, standing outside in the sunshine around a pump"—a water pump. "To stand outside in the afternoon sun in front of a Bavarian farmhouse after two months at Buchenwald was something. The farmer's wife emerged carrying several loaves of rye bread and a jug of milk. Best said it was, 'real good rye bread such as none of us had tasted for years.' Then back into the van, which was much roomier now, several of them could take a nap. 'The window over the door was left open,' Best wrote. And as it was a lovely day, everything looked bright in our cage.
- 8.28** They rambled like that through town after town, southward through the Nahe Valley. Many of them had almost forgotten that Germany, with its natural beauty and farm villages, was a real place in the present and not just a memory." So it goes on and on. I give in my book the details of this. At some point, they get to Regensburg, the city of Regensburg, and they go to the state prison because the SS guards go, "Here's a place where we can deposit them." They go into the state prison and basically are bumping into people they know, other figures in the conspiracy who are kept there. Anyway, on and on it goes. After this, the van breaks down. They have to wait for a bus. They get on a bus. It just goes on and on like this.
- 8.29** Finally, they come "to the small Bavarian village of Schömburg and stop in front of the village school, a squarish white building of four stories. They reached their destination. Bonhoeffer and his fellow prisoners were taken into the school and shown into a large room on the first floor. This was to be their common cell."
- 8.30** This is April 7th, two days before his death. "The room had been a girls' infirmary and was set up with rows of beds. It was all very cheering. The blankets were in bright colors and there were inviting white feather beds, too. Best said that 'despite the fatigue and hunger, we were all in the highest spirits, nervous, excited, and almost hysterical in our laughter.' There were large windows on three sides of the room so that everyone could look out and drink in the green scenery of the valley. Bonhoeffer sunned himself at one of the windows, praying and thinking. He spent time talking with one of his fellow prisoners, Punder, and spent time with Kokorin."
- 8.31** Now, Kokorin was a committed atheist. But during this period, Bonhoeffer is sharing his faith with Kokorin, and Kokorin, being in these dire straits, is listening. We learned that they even exchanged addresses. And Bonhoeffer, even at this late stage, still had a few books with him, a volume of Goethe, a Bible, and Plutarch's Lives. As I say, you can get the details from my book, but it's incredible. This is Saturday, April 7th, they're in this school. It's cheerful. They don't know what tomorrow holds, or they don't know what next week holds. They're just going along.

- 8.32** The next day, April 8th, was the first Sunday after Easter. It's Bonhoeffer's last day in this world. Punder, who'd gotten close to Bonhoeffer, was a Catholic, and he asked Bonhoeffer on this Sunday in this school room if he would conduct a service. The fact that Kokorin was an atheist caused Bonhoeffer to demur. He didn't wish to impose. But Kokorin himself insisted. Less than 24 hours before he left this world, Bonhoeffer performed the offices of a pastor.
- 8.33** "In the bright Schomberg's school room that was their cell, he held a small service. He prayed and read the verses for that day, Isaiah 53:5—"with his stripes, we are healed." And 1 Peter 1:3—"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. By his great mercy, we've been born anew to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead." He then explained these verses to everyone. This is less than 24 hours before his death. He is preaching, exegesis. Payne Best recalled that Bonhoeffer, "spoke to us in a manner which reached the hearts of all, finding just the right words to express the spirit of our imprisonment and the thoughts and resolutions which it had brought."
- 8.34** There were other prisoners in the schoolhouse who catch a word that Bonhoeffer is doing a service in the next room in the other cell. They asked, "Would he hold a service for us?" So Payne Best describes what happens: "Bonhoeffer had hardly finished his last prayer when the door opened and two evil-looking men in civilian clothes came in and said, 'Prisoner Bonhoeffer. Get ready to come with us.' Those words 'come with us'—for all prisoners, they had come to mean one thing only—the scaffold. We bade him good-bye. He drew me aside—'this is the end,' Bonhoeffer said, 'but for me, the beginning of life.'"
- 8.35** Bonhoeffer asked Payne Best—"please remember me to Bishop Bell," because he assumes Payne Best is going to make his way back to England. Six years after this, Payne Best wrote a letter to the Bonhoeffer family and said that "Dietrich Bonhoeffer was a good and saintly man. In fact, my feeling was far stronger than these words imply. He was without exception, the finest and most lovable man I have ever met." We're not making this up. This is what the people around him reported.
- 8.36** What happens here, of course, is that—I don't think I've ever mentioned it because it gets complicated. But Dohnanyi, while he was conducting this plot as he's making the evidence—he's compiling evidence about the atrocities of the Nazis so that when they kill Hitler—of course, they don't— but so that they can show Germany what most Germans, my relatives included, never knew. The Satanic evil of the Nazis, the death squads, murdering civilians, the horrors that we now know of, which were unknown to most Germans, Dohnanyi was compiling this, compiling films, photographs, testimonies, everything.
- 8.37** This becomes what's called the Zossen file. But not long before this period, the Zossen file is discovered. That's when Hitler personally orders the execution of Bonhoeffer and

all of these other figures. He doesn't care if they're going to be used as bargaining chips. Petty to the last, this sick monster orders that they all must be executed.

8.38 Pastor Bonhoeffer, come with us. This is the afternoon of April 8th. They drive with him about 100 miles to Flossenbürg concentration camp. Now, a lot of people say, if you visit Flossenbürg, they're like—Bonhoeffer! Bonhoeffer! Bonhoeffer was there 12 hours. He was not there for weeks or months or anything. It's where he was executed. So he gets in the car and he goes all the way to Flossenbürg—what went through his mind, we will never know. He had his volume of Goethe with him, we know because it was recovered afterward at Flossenbürg.

8.39 I said it in the Q&A a few sessions ago. The Nazis felt this perverse need to give the picture of justice to have a court martial trial. In other words, you think what they ought to have done is just take a gun and kill the people they want to kill. But no, they couldn't do it that way. They had to preserve this bizarre illusion of fairness and justice after all that they had done and all that we know that they had done.

8.40 So Bonhoeffer is taken to Flossenbürg. They set up a so-called summary court martial. There for this charade was Dr. Otto Thorbeck, an SS Judge. That Saturday night, this is the 8th of April, Canaris, Oster, Dr. Sack, Strunck, Gehre, and Bonhoeffer would be tried and executed the following morning. Eberhard Bethge writes that it was "the summary court"—as it was called, says that it "sat for quite a long time. It examined—its officers claimed later—each prisoner individually and confronted them with each other. After midnight, Canaris returned to his cell after an absence of some time and signaled by knocking signs to the man in the next cell, the Danish Colonel Lunding, that it was all up with him." They all know they're going to be executed in the morning. Whether Bonhoeffer slept, we can never know. I wouldn't think so. At dawn, he's summoned to the gallows and executed.

8.41 Now, in my book, I think I said this, I stretch things out in the last days. Similarly, I'm not sure why I did this exactly, but I bend the narrative in such a way. It's almost like a narrative sleight of hand, so that there isn't any moment where he's executed. I'm referring to it in the past tense.

8.42 The camp doctor at Flossenbürg recounts "On the morning of that day"—this is the 9th of April—"between five and six o'clock"—AM— "the prisoners, among them, Canaris, Oster, General Thomas, and Sack, were taken from their cells. The verdicts of the court martial read out to them. Through the half-open door in one room of the huts, I saw Pastor Bonhoeffer before taking off his prison garb, kneeling on the floor, praying fervently to his God. I was most deeply moved by the way this lovable man prayed, so devout and so certain that God heard his prayer. At the place of execution, he again said a short prayer, and then climbed the steps to the gallows, brave and composed. His death ensued after a few seconds. In the almost 50 years that I worked as a doctor, I have hardly ever seen a man die so entirely submissive to the will of God."

- 8.43** Now, it's interesting because some people have disputed that account. But when you look at everything everyone else ever said about Bonhoeffer, that's a perfect description of him. I think the onus is on those doubting it. It makes perfect sense. Bonhoeffer would have thought himself privileged to die in the place where so many Jews died, to have his body thrown on a pile and cremated the way so many Jews were disposed of.
- 8.44** It's interesting. When I was writing the book, I remember at the end—when I got to this part, some part of my brain lit up; something I had read many weeks before I got to this part of the book—a sermon that Bonhoeffer gave in 1933, 12 years before his death. This is a sermon he preached in London many years before. But I thought, if you don't—because our temptation is to say, "Oh, we're so sad. He was executed."
- 8.45** Okay, well, what's Bonhoeffer's point of view? What has Bonhoeffer been saying from the beginning? What has he been saying over and over and over and over and trying to communicate about his view of what is life? What is death? What are these things? In 1933, he preaches the sermon, and in the sermon, he gives us his view of death. Twelve years before he's executed, he says, "No one has yet believed in God and the Kingdom of God. No one has yet heard about the realm of the resurrected and not been homesick from that hour, waiting and looking forward joyfully to being released from bodily existence."
- 8.46** Bonhoeffer is saying in 1933—anyone who is actually a Christian looks forward to meeting God in person. So if any of us doesn't, that should chill you a little bit. Are you a person of faith or do you just think you are? Because Bonhoeffer is saying, which I think is absolutely true, although if you say it—"No one has yet believed in God and the kingdom of God. No one has yet heard about the realm of the resurrected and not been homesick from that hour, waiting and looking forward joyfully to being released from bodily existence."
- 8.47** Bonhoeffer goes on in the sermon, "Whether we are young or old makes no difference. What are 20 or 30 or 50 years in the sight of God, and which of us knows how near he or she may already be to the goal? That life only really begins when it ends here on earth. That all that is here is only the prologue before the curtain goes up—that is for young and old alike to think about. Why are we so afraid when we think about death? Death is only dreadful for those who live in dread and fear of it. Death is not wild and terrible. If only we can be still and hold fast to God's Word."
- 8.48** "Death is not bitter if we have not become bitter ourselves. Death is grace, the greatest gift of grace that God gives to people who believe in him. Death is mild, death is sweet and gentle. It beckons to us with heavenly power. If only we realize that it is the gateway to our homeland, the tabernacle of joy, the everlasting kingdom of peace. How do we know that dying is so dreadful? Who knows whether in our human fear and anguish, we are only shivering and shattering at the most glorious, heavenly, blessed

event in the world? Death is hell and night and cold if it is not transformed by our faith. But that is just what is so marvelous that we can transform death."

- 8.49** So the human temptation is to think—oh, how sad. Bonhoeffer goes to his death. He's 39 years old. He'll never get married. He's engaged. How sad, how tragic. Except that's not Bonhoeffer's view. So if you think he's so wonderful, you're obliged to think about what he says about death. And what he says about death is this is the greatest thing imaginable because you don't actually die. If you believe in Jesus who defeated death on the cross, then you understand, you actually understand that this life is prologue and that to go into the presence of God is the most glorious thing imaginable. In fact, it's so difficult for us to imagine that we usually don't try and we cling to this life.
- 8.50** He, in a sermon in 1933, he's a young man, he's 26, 27. He's explaining to the congregation in London: Ladies and gentlemen, [buzzer sound] wrong! Death is "the gateway to the realm of the resurrected, to the tabernacle of joy." Now, that is correct Christian preaching. That is Christian thinking. Anyone who would call himself a Christian who doesn't get that is missing the most important thing.
- 8.51** Bonhoeffer, as is his job, as is his calling, he is pushing the people in the pews in the London Church in 1933 to get this. This is God's will that we understand this, that we get this, then we say—oh, yeah, it would be nice if I believe that. It's like he's saying, he wouldn't put it this way, but it's like saying "Hey, idiot." It's like saying, "I wish I could believe $1+1=2$." No, it's actually true. If you don't believe it, you're a fool. Bonhoeffer is really pushing on this.
- 8.52** This is just one example, but this is an example of his whole life. He knows this to be true. He knows when he's praying to God that God hears his prayer. He knows what is true, and he's trying to get other people to know it also, not to hope, because, again, it's one of these pious things, where "Oh, I hope so. Oh, that would be great. Yeah, I want to believe that."
- 8.53** It's like, whom are you kidding? It's God's will that you believe that. If you don't believe that, Bonhoeffer says, that's just disobedience and foolishness. He calls us higher to actually believe what is true, and he lives it out. Again, you have all these quotes. I haven't quoted them all, but people like Payne Best and so many others just say—wow, boy, did he shine in these last days, in these dark days. He's not putting it on. When you see the real guy, he really believes it.
- 8.54** It's just, to me, amazing that we have what we do. I'm proud of what I accomplished in the book, in a sense, pulling all this stuff together so you have it because I'd never seen all these things pulled together. It's important. Otherwise, you're going to get a distorted view of Bonhoeffer or a distorted view of the Christian faith.
- 8.55** I start my book at Bonhoeffer's memorial service. It was at Holy Trinity Brompton Church in London. There was a service three months after his death. Of course, his twin sister who lived in England with her husband, Gerhard Liebholz, they were there. Their

two girls were there. His best friend—Bishop Bell, of course, was there. His best friend, Hildebrandt, was there.

- 8.56** What's amazing to me is that three months after Bonhoeffer's death, his mother and father did not yet know whether he had died. Try to imagine the chaos at the end of World War II, that there's no way to communicate. They still didn't know. Somebody tells them, tune into the BBC on this date. I think that they're going to be having a memorial service for Dietrich. This is July, I think, 27th, 1945. In their house in Berlin, they turn on the radio and they hear the memorial service from Holy Trinity, Brompton Church in England for their son, Dietrich Bonhoeffer.
- 8.57** I end my book, as I say, I bend time or stretch time with the narrative, and I go right into that service. I quote a lot of the sermon that is preached, the hymns, so that the reader can experience this as Bonhoeffer's parents experienced it listening to the radio. Then Franz Hildebrandt, Bonhoeffer's very, very dear friend who is, as we've said, ethnically Jewish, preached the sermon, and I quote most of the sermon at the end of my book, just that we can be there. The last line in my book is, "When the service ended, Karl and Paula Bonhoeffer turned off the radio." That's how they knew their son had died. Let's leave it there. I think we have time for some questions.
- 8.58** Can you tell us a little bit about your own personal quest of getting this information, putting it all together?
- 8.59** I'll be real clear. I was an English major at Yale, and I knew I wanted to be a writer. I didn't know what I wanted to write. Around 1988, a few years out of Yale, I had this really dramatic Christian conversion, which changed everything for me. I thought, "Okay, God, I want to be a writer. What do you want me to write?" It was a long journey for me. I guarantee you I never wanted to write a biography. I never had an ambition to write a biography, ever. But circumstances—it's funny to watch how God can maneuver us, if we're willing, into certain things.
- 8.60** I found myself writing a biography of William Wilberforce, the great parliamentarian who, roughly 200 years ago, led the battle against the slave trade in the British Empire. Because of his Christian convictions, led the battle against the slave trade. An amazing character. Wilberforce is an amazing hero of the faith. I hope maybe I'll do a course for Peterson Academy on Wilberforce because he's so fascinating. But when I wrote that book, I thought, "Okay, I've written a biography. I'm satisfied that I can do it." Because as I say, I'd never done one before, and I thought, what does it entail? Well, I was pleased enough that I thought, maybe I'll write another biography someday.
- 8.61** People kept asking me about whom I would like to write. I thought, well, if I were ever to write another biography, it would have to be about Bonhoeffer. I don't know that I will, but I might. Eventually, I was persuaded that, yeah, I think because of the connection to my family, because my family lived through this period, his story was particularly fascinating to me. At some point, I decided to do it. Initially, I wrote it and

the publisher said, "No, it's just too long. You pretty much got to cut it in half" or something like that.

8.62 By that point, I realized I can't do that. I realize what I've written is definitive. My goal in any of my biographies—but especially this one and my Luther biography—is to write a definitive biography. So if somebody says, who's Bonhoeffer? I go, well, read this and you'll know. You can't do it in 200 pages. You have to give the background of his family so you get some sense of who the players are. You get some sense of who he was as a result of growing up in this family. Then you have to give all the background. I didn't get into it much during this course, but—of what's going on in Germany so you understand why the Nazis rose to power and then what Bonhoeffer is pushing back against. You need all of that historical information. Otherwise, you're just getting the story of Bonhoeffer in a vacuum.

8.63 So I went through my manuscript with a fine-tooth comb, just looking for any fat that could be cut, and there was very, very little. And I said, I will not cut muscle and bone. It is what it is. So I ultimately had to switch publishers because I refused to do that. And the publisher that released me, they were happy to get rid of this 600-page book about a German theologian that obviously nobody's he's going to buy. Thomas Nelson said, "Well, we'll publish it." They published it, and it sold over a million copies, and it became the Evangelical Book of the Year and on and on and on. I was vindicated that I'm not crazy. I'm not in love with my words. But if you want to understand the story of this man, you need more in-depth. Believe me, the book could be twice as long. But I said, I want it to be readable—so it was a really crazy journey.

8.64 One of the most difficult things of my life was writing this book. But I can say bluntly, I knew the Lord was with me. I won't go into the details, but I wrote a book called *Miracles*, and I tell that story. But it really was—It's become increasingly clear to me that my writing this book was not my idea, that there was a purpose in it. That's as brief as I can be on that. Thanks for the question.

8.65 Are there any particular biblical passages that Bonhoeffer claimed to be intimate inspirations to him, long-standing, favorite gems of courage and transformation?

8.66 I think, in a nutshell, no. He was so familiar with the Scripture that you get many, many, many examples, so it's hard to home in on a few. I was just ending with his memorial service, and the Scripture that his friend Franz Hildebrandt quotes, which I almost did and which I now will, is Second Chronicles 20:12, "Neither know we what to do: but our eyes are upon thee." That idea, in some ways, sums up Bonhoeffer. All through his life, he's asking the question—what do I do now? What do I do now? Things keep changing.

8.67 It's silly to say, well, it's really easy. The Scripture says do this, do this. You have to have a personal relationship with God, and you have to ask God to lead you by the power of the Holy Spirit. Lead me, Lord. Show me what Scriptures to read. I've seen that in my own life, definitely, Bonhoeffer lived that way—that he says, I don't know what to do.

My eyes are on you, God—and God, show me what to do. That really, over and over and over again, it is a theme, so I don't know that he would have singled that Scripture out. But it's interesting that his dear friend Franz Hildebrandt sums him up with that Scripture.

- 8.68** Franz Hildebrand says, this is the opening of his sermon in London in July of 1945, he writes, he says, "In May 1932, a few months before Hitler came to power, Dietrich Bonhoeffer stood in the pulpit of the Dreifaltigkeitskirche in Berlin and preached from this text." Now, we could find that sermon, and I didn't. That's what I'm saying. My book could just be endless. You can write—because most of his sermons exist, you can find them. Because so much of his writing exists, you could have a book that is 2,000 pages long. But in any event, I would point to that because it sums up how he lived his life. You've gotten that from the eight hours of this series.
- 8.69** You had said there had been conflicting accounts of the final moments of his life that you were happy to clear up. What were the major conflicting accounts, and why do you think that they persisted so long before you were able to write this?
- 8.70** I think if we're honest, and I always think, let's be honest, we don't know for sure a number of things. Then we have to be honest. We say, well, we know this and this and this, but we're not so sure what it adds up to. Bonhoeffer's last moments, all we have to go on is this account, which Eberhard Bethge quotes in his biography. Now, Eberhard Bethge's biography is 1,100 pages long, very, very dense, very hard to read, but it's an amazing resource. So he quotes that at the end. But people have said, "Oh, the guy who gives us this quote, he was on trial and he's trying to make himself look good, so he would have said this or he would have said that."
- 8.71** I don't think we know. I think that there are some people who are always looking for the ugliest detail. I think, honestly, we don't know. So it seems to me the description, at least the description of Bonhoeffer's, it just seems so much like Bonhoeffer. He was literally there for a few hours. It's not like the guy, this doctor at Flossenbürg, had a few weeks to observe Bonhoeffer. He doesn't know anything. This guy shows up for a few hours and whatever. It seems to me like an accurate report.
- 8.72** But people like controversy and you get this with anybody. They like to stir the pot. I like to do what I think is right, tell the truth, do the best we can. Be honest if we're not so sure. But yeah, to my mind, it sounds right to me. So I just I'll leave it at that.
- 8.73** One time I was talking about one of your books, and I gave a couple of critical reviews to people. One was a glowing Wall Street Journal book review, and then one was, I can't remember what, a contemporary Christian journal, and I gave it to the person and they said it was almost impossible to reconcile the two reactions. How has the journey been for you as far as the—controversy is good—because people are talking about the book, but how has it been for you, the disparate treatments of—or the disparate reactions to the books?

- 8.74** I think I got to put my cards on the table. I did not kiss the rings of the Bonhoeffer scholars when I wrote my book. I realized that there's all of this information out there. I don't need to go to anybody to tell me—what do I make of this? The information is all there. So I wrote my book, and I am a 1000% confident that exactly what I wrote is exactly what is true. I couldn't live with myself if I was putting English on the ball or twisting things to suit my narrative.
- 8.75** What I discovered as true, I wrote, and I do that with all of my books, all of my biographies, whether it's about Wilberforce or about Martin Luther, warts and all, just try to tell the truth. In this case, using so much of his own writings. But what really happened is that without realizing it, by writing what I wrote about Bonhoeffer, I think it ended up humiliating some of these lifelong Bonhoeffer scholars because I show them to be wedded to a version of things which simply ain't so.
- 8.76** I think they were furious that I would dare to do that. I didn't do it intentionally, but if you tell the truth, people who are wedded to a different narrative, they're going to get their noses out of joint. I think they probably were furious that the book sold so well because their turgid academic treatments are not—people aren't interested in reading that. So the bitterness came out. I read two reviews and I thought to myself, this is utterly subjective nonsense. But again, I've lived long enough to see how it works. Somebody doesn't like you, so what do they do? They find anything questionable and they make a big deal out of it.
- 8.77** So there was three typos in the first edition of this, and they act like, look at that. It's a typo. It's like a mistake, which I'm happy to change. But when they do that, you realize they're not being fair-minded. But there were two long-time Bonhoeffer scholars who are wedded to a very different version of Bonhoeffer. They want to present him to be this agnostic humanist, hippy-dippy, pacifist, blah, blah, blah. I did the research and I thought, "Sorry, kids, that's wrong." I mean I can see where you get some of it, but it's basically wrong.
- 8.78** It's really a little shocking when you're naive and you step into this thing and you think, "Gosh, there are people who, they're not going to thank me for this. They're just going to hate my guts because I have put a version of things in it." But again, there's just a nasty subjectivity to it because you think that, show me exactly what I got wrong because I'll fix it, but they don't do that. They just say, "Eric Metaxas has presented blah, blah, blah." You think, "well, that's just an opinion. Show me what am I quoting that's wrong."
- 8.79** I mean, you've heard me in the course of these eight hours, Bonhoeffer was disgusted with the theological liberalism at Union. For years, people at Union are like, "Oh, Bonhoeffer is our guy." It's like, well, when you read what he wrote about you, I wouldn't be crowing about it too much. He was gracious, but he was honest that he really was stunned at the sloppiness of what passed for theology at Union. Then again, in 1939, he goes to Riverside Church and he hears a sermon that disgusts him. He

writes in his journal. I quoted it two lectures ago. If you want a clear view of where he's coming from, he gives you letters and journals and letters and journals so you can see exactly what he thinks. All of that stuff had been avoided by these Bonhoeffer scholars. They don't get into that because it doesn't suit their narrative. I see that as simply dishonest. You've got to tell the truth.

- 8.80** When I started to write this book, I didn't know what I would find. I thought, maybe I will find that at the end of his life, he goes wobbly. I thought, "Well, I'll have to report. I'll have to write it." Well, what I found was exactly the opposite. But this brings up something which I wanted to talk about, and I hadn't. If you had talked to anybody, whatever, 15-20, before my book came out and asked about Bonhoeffer, half of them who'd heard of him would say, "Oh, yeah, religionless Christianity." It's amazing that—remember I said he's at the end of his life and he's writing these letters to his best friend, Eberhard Bethge. And he's writing on this very high theological level to his super smart best friend who's going to understand just what he means. He's not writing for a general public. But these are notes. He figures if I survive, I'll get out, I'll get this stuff back and I can work on a book or something.
- 8.81** So a lot of that stuff—if you're an academic and you want to make a name for yourself, you go, "Oh, I got something, and I'll write about Bonhoeffer or whatever." They created this completely fictional theology as though Bonhoeffer was pointing towards something. It's really what they were wanting, and they twisted his stuff to mean that. At the heart of it is his use of the phrase "religionless Christianity."
- 8.82** Bonhoeffer is talking to Eberhard Bethge in these letters. He's saying, religion in the negative sense, in the Barthian sense of religion has failed—look what happened to Germany. All of this, these church services, whatever passed for Christian religion, failed. Somehow, he's effectively saying, "We've got to get honest. We've got to get real about—what does the faith really mean? It means living out your faith." It means all kinds of stuff. He uses the phrase, he says, "What we really needed was a religionless Christianity."
- 8.83** In fact, here's the quote—again, at the end of his life, writing to his best friend, "What is bothering me incessantly is the question what Christianity really is, or indeed who Christ really is for us today. The time when people could be told everything by means of words, whether theological or pious, is over, and so is the time of inwardness and conscience— and that means the time of religion in general." Now, you can see how people could twist this, what I just read. He says, "We're moving toward a completely religionless time." He's basically saying that what passes for Christian faith—we've just been going through the motions and it's failed. We've got to somehow translate what it means to live a Christian life for people who don't speak our theological language.
- 8.84** A number of these academics, theologians, they grabbed on this and a few other things he said, and they built this whole world of Bonhoeffer theology, which didn't reflect Bonhoeffer at all. It's just completely nonsense. It wasn't until 1967 that Bonhoeffer's

best friend, Eberhard Bethge, finally gets so ticked off that at a conference, he says, "The isolated youth use in handing down of the famous term 'religionless Christianity' has made Bonhoeffer the champion of an undialectical shallow modernism which obscures all that he wanted to tell us about the living God."

- 8.85** The people that didn't like my book and all of these Bonhoeffer scholars, this is what they were pushing forever. The "God is dead" movement of the 1960s grabbed on to what Bonhoeffer had written in Letters and Papers from Prison, almost to say like, "Oh, so we're moving to a world beyond, not religion, but beyond Christianity or something like that, that we've got to be honest. There's no God. God is dead. And so we've got to"—and they made it sound like Bonhoeffer would approve of this, which is lunacy. But there are people that want to believe that. So when I wrote my book, I think it really infuriated a lot of those people. I didn't know that that would happen. But when I saw there were two reviews in particular, I thought, well, I read the reviews, and I think we always have to be honest, is there something I'm missing? Because I want to change it or whatever.
- 8.86** But the more time has passed, the more I felt that, no, there's not. I reread my book recently for the first time in all these years to prepare for this, and I was astonished. I thought, maybe I'll find something that I want to change. But I think if you're really wedded to telling the truth, you're going to upset some people. And so I think ultimately, we can let God sort it out. I always say if somebody can find— if somebody just says, "Oh, it's a terrible book," I think, "Okay, tell me what you mean. What is wrong? What is it?" You have a lot of people, and again, I've never experienced this before, who are—the knives are out because you maybe made them look bad or something like that.
- 8.87** I can say with joy that more than one of Bonhoeffer's relatives and others, when the book first came out told me that it was their favorite book about him. I thought that's really gratifying. Also, a number of Germans told me they had never understood what happened in Germany until they read my book. Now, I'm writing not just as an American, but as a German myself. I want to know what happened, what happened to my people? What were they—that was part of my goal in writing the book was trying to figure out what happened.
- 8.88** Because if you put it in a category like you go, well, that was what happened in Nazi Germany and Hitler, that doesn't relate to the rest of the world. You think, wait a minute. That's as racist as saying the Jews are bad. If you say the Germans are uniquely bad, you have to accept responsibility. Wait minute, they were human beings. We're human beings. If they are capable of that, why wouldn't we be capable of that? What happened?
- 8.89** In the course of telling the story, I realized that a lot of what happened there is happening here and has happened here in America. I didn't quite know it while I was writing the book, but if you tell the truth—the truth is the truth—and eventually you'll

find out how true. I think that more recent years have borne out what my instinct was when I was writing the book. So thank you.

- 8.90** What do you think Bonhoeffer would suggest to someone who is an exemplar of the Christian faith but maintains a qualm about the literal resurrection of Christ?
- 8.91** I think—you always have to be clear about when we're talking about something like the resurrection of Jesus. I think the whole point of the resurrection is people are not supposed to rise from the dead. If somebody's objection is like, "Wait a minute, that doesn't happen." That's the whole point. Of course, it doesn't happen. If it happened, it is an insane miracle done by God, the same God who created the universe out of nothing, to force us to see who he was—who Jesus was, who God the Father is. I think that Scripture itself makes it clear that you can't have all the stuff you like without the resurrection.
- 8.92** I think I've written in two of my previous books, I deal with the apologetics, like how do you explain the resurrection? How do you do—whatever. What I was stunned to find, really stunned—because I thought, "Okay, I believe it happened, but I understand why somebody wouldn't." But the evidence for the resurrection is astonishing. I thought to myself if you're honest and you read all this evidence, you're like, well, I would have to say it probably did happen versus it didn't happen because the excuses given against it are just silly, like the apostles stole the body, the disciples stole the body. But in other words, every excuse given for what really happened makes much, much less sense than the idea that no, this miracle actually happened.
- 8.93** But it's interesting. I think that anybody who is serious about the rest of the stuff—because if somebody has qualms about the resurrection, I would say, well, then just look at all the other stuff, because I think eventually it will draw you to understand that the God behind all the stuff you like is this amazing God who created the universe out of nothing. So, raising someone from the dead is nothing compared to creating the universe. It's not even in the same category.
- 8.94** I think that—I always say this at Socrates in the City, "If you're interested in the truth, keep going." You'll get to it. You don't have to believe everything right away. But if you're interested in the truth, the truth who is God is interested in you, and He will lead you to Himself if your heart is open and your mind is open. That's really the key, is to be open-minded in the positive sense of the term. I'll leave it there. Thank you.